

Psych 260 Psychology of Social Status

Numbered Transcript

PSYC 260 • Dr. Rob Henderson

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Lecture 1: Status Psychology

At a glance — Henderson introduces the psychology of status.

- 1.1 Good morning. My name is Dr. Rob Henderson, and I'm the instructor for this course. So these lectures will be based on ideas I've been researching and thinking about and developing for several years now. Of course, I'll be drawing on the work of many other brilliant researchers and scholars and their studies and their ideas.
- 1.2 I received my PhD in psychology from Cambridge University last year. And one of the benefits of taking a course with a recent PhD graduate is that most of the studies I cite throughout these lectures will be recent. This is the latest stuff, the most cutting-edge work. If you take courses with some senior professors, often you'll find that many of the references and studies that they cite will tend to cluster around a certain point early on in their career. Those are the findings that made the strongest impression on them. I'm no different. I just finished. But in this case, it's an advantage.
- 1.3 Much of the research I'll be discussing has been published after the wake of the replication crisis. How many of you are familiar with the psychology replication crisis? A few of you? That was quite a large disruption in several fields in psychology. But there have been many formal changes made that have improved the quality of research—things like preregistration, meaning you have to formally announce your hypotheses before you start the study instead of finding a significant result and then ex post facto rationalizing, "Oh, this is the finding we predicted all along."
- 1.4 Larger sample sizes, better statistical methods, making the data publicly available so other researchers and statisticians can check the work. These are just a few of the changes that have been implemented over the last 7 or 8 years. Broadly, I'm confident that the ideas I'll be presenting in these lectures are solid. It's not to say that all of them will unfailingly replicate, but I'm confident in these findings.
- 1.5 So we can get into the actual content of the course. So there's been a perennial question about what motivates people. Psychologists, philosophers, and theologians have long wondered, "What drives people?" So here are some of the things we'll be discussing in lecture one. We'll be discussing social status, the evolutionary and developmental roots of the desire for status. So here's Abraham Maslow, 20th-century psychologist. Some of you may be familiar with his hierarchy of needs, but here is how he defined status.
- 1.6 "Reputation or prestige, defined as respect or esteem from other people, recognition, attention, importance, or appreciation. " The philosopher Agnes Callard: "What is status? It's how much value other people accord you." This is a very simple definition. It's an intuitive definition, and this is probably the simplest way to remember what status is. Status is interesting because it lives in the minds of other people. You don't

get to decide how much status you have. You can't just say, "Hey, everyone, I have high status," and people will say, "Prove it," and they get to decide.

- 1.7 So why do we care about status? There's a neuroscientist I really like, Michael Gazzaniga, who says, "When you get up in the morning, you think about status. You think about where you are in relation to your peers." Gazzaniga is a neuroscientist. There's a lot of interesting work within neuroscience about what people think about when they have free time, when their mind starts to wander. So when you're not focused on a task immediately at hand, what areas of the brain are active? And neuroscientists call these areas of the brain, when you're mind-wandering, the default mode network.
- 1.8 What they find is that the default mode network, the regions of the brain that are active, overlap with the regions of the brain that are active when people think about their social lives, when they think about themselves in relation to other people, when they think about other people and how they are evaluated. And what this suggests is that, when we have free time, when our mind starts to wander, what do we think about? We actually think about what Gazzaniga is talking about here. That's where our mind seems to naturally drift, when you don't have any external pressures or when you're not immediately focusing, on something in front of you.
- 1.9 So I mentioned we'll be talking about the evolutionary roots of psychology and our psychology. So what is the field of evolutionary psychology? There's a nice definition here from the evolutionary psychology professor, Tania Reynolds. A recent definition, she defines evolutionary psychology as "examining how the mind has been shaped to solve recurring problems faced by human ancestors. It contends that natural selection has produced mental adaptations that enhanced our ancestors' ability to survive and reproduce."
- 1.10 It's important to remember here, a lot of people will conflate environments. When we say, "This is what's advantageous for survival and reproduction," they think that it applies to the present moment, but it doesn't. Humans, we evolve—the environment evolves faster than we do, is one way to think about it. So the way that our minds and our bodies have been shaped—300,000 years, roughly, of human evolution—this is roughly the modern form of Homo sapiens. 300,000 years ago, we lived in mostly nomadic hunter-gatherer groups until about 10,000 years ago. Then with the agricultural revolution, we stayed in stationary areas where we grew food and formed villages and cities and so forth.
- 1.11 But for most of our history, we lived in these small nomadic groups as hunter-gatherers. That's where our psychology evolved, in the Pleistocene, in the ancestral environment, which I'll be describing throughout this course. That's where our minds are adapted for. So one way to think about it is, a common example is food. So 20,000 years ago, if you had food, it was in your best interest to eat as much of it as possible because you don't know when you're going to see food again.

- 1.12** I saw this documentary of these hunter-gatherers, I think somewhere in Central America, and they were, I think they were on a hunt, and then they saw a beehive, and they immediately stopped everything. They grabbed that beehive, and they had little techniques down. It was amazing to see how they were able to evade getting stung and take this beehive down, and they just gorged themselves on this honey. That's what you should do if you're in an environment where calories are scarce.
- 1.13** But now, in the modern environment with an abundance of food, this natural adaptation to eat when calorically dense food is available is perhaps maladaptive with the rise of obesity and associated health issues. Keep that in mind as we go through this course. When I say this is a mental adaptation or we evolved to do X, Y, Z, this is in the ancestral environment, thousands of years ago, not in the modern environment, 2023.
- 1.14** Why do humans care about status? Well, humans evolved to pursue status because it leads to reproductive benefits. So reproductive benefits, the currency of evolution is offspring. A lot of the motivations that humans have are associated with the attainment of attracting romantic partners, survival, and reproduction. So we're securing allies, territory, resources, mates, but ultimately the currency is offspring. Reproduction is actually what evolution cares about, not actually survival. Survival is only important within an evolutionary framework insofar as it allows you to live long enough to reproduce.
- 1.15** So there are traits, for example, that will actually be detrimental for your survival, but if it enhances or aids you on your path to reproduction, then the trait will actually proliferate. In contrast, if there's a trait that will enhance your survival but damage your reproductive prospects, then your genes will not spread and the trait will not proliferate within the population.
- 1.16** So an example might be risk-taking. Risk-taking is actually a trait that can be very damaging to your survival. If you take risks and it increases your odds of death, not good for survival, but if risk-taking increases your access to certain kinds of resources and ultimately impresses potential romantic partners, then you will find that this trait will spread. The genetic properties will spread throughout a population, and this will increase the likelihood of that person or those genes spreading.
- 1.17** In contrast, if you have someone who's very preoccupied with survival; they have no interest in mating whatsoever; all they want to do is live to be 100 years old, not interested in romance, not interested in anything; they just want to do all they can to survive and avoid any risk—I mean, that's great for that individual person, but it's bad for their genes. We are the descendants of people who cared about reproduction, not necessarily the people who cared about survival. Our ancestors had to walk that tightrope. They wanted to live long enough to reproduce. And that's where we came from.

- 1.18** We talked about that. Reproduction is what evolution cares about. We'll do things that enhance reproduction potential, not just at the expense of survival, but also at the expense of happiness. People will do things that are good for their genes, but bad for themselves. We'll talk a bit more about this later. But a lot of our emotions—guilt, shame, embarrassment, humiliation—these are terrible feelings, but they do serve an adaptive purpose. For our ancestors, they served the purpose of modifying our behavior to increase our appeal to potential romantic partners, and ultimately increases the odds of having offspring. Greed, shame, envy—these kinds of things.
- 1.19** These feelings tend to peak right at the age when we are most interested in mating. A lot of our most intense emotions will be clustered in our teens and our 20s. You'll find that across the life span, the intensity of emotions tends to dwindle. Emotions serve a critical role, which we'll discuss more later as well.
- 1.20** I mentioned earlier that people talk about money as the be-all end-all of why people do what they do. Throughout this course, I'll be making the case that status is an important incentive as well. It's a resource as real as oxygen or water. Often people will actually exchange material wealth for status. So an example of this—I read this article a couple of years ago in the New York Times of influencers paying for followers. Why would you do that? If money is what makes the world go around, why would you pay for followers? I guess you can make the argument, "Oh, the followers, maybe you could sell something to them. It's an investment."
- 1.21** I don't think that's what's going on, though. I think there's a lot of investment involved in raising your social prominence up. And follower count is a very visible metric. Also, displaying your bank account and your money and that thing, it's gauche. It's, I mean, if someone posts online, "Here's how much money I have in my bank account," a lot of people, that person will be mocked, right. I'm going to laugh at this person. But if you say, "Hey, I just got to a million followers, everyone. Thanks," that actually raises your status even more to post that and to highlight that.
- 1.22** There's an example here that I like to give. I had this conversation a few years ago with a lecturer at Yale. He was a non-tenured lecturer. He told me that he received an offer, a tenure-track offer, at a university somewhere in the Midwest. I want to say it was Indiana. It probably wasn't, so I'll just say Indiana. And the job offered more money, it offered tenure, it offered job security. That's the dream job of most academics, is to get a tenure-track job somewhere. This person had a non-tenure-track, low-paying job at Yale. I asked him, "Are you going to take this job?" And he said, "No, it's tempting, but no." I said, "Well, why not?" And he replied, "The name brand of Yale is just too valuable. I'm not going to—"
- 1.23** So this guy is choosing to live in more economically precarious circumstances simply because it probably impresses people more when he says, "I'm a lecturer at Yale" than "I'm a junior professor at Indiana University." So this is one reason why I think that status is so important for human behavior choices.

- 1.24** I mentioned before, status isn't only just one thing. There are two different forms of status. There are two facets here. There's dominance and there's prestige. Dominance is evolutionarily older. Prestige seems to be mostly, most prominent among humans. It's more pronounced among humans. You will see some rudimentary elements of prestige among chimpanzees and primates. But in the animal kingdom, dominance is what prevails. Among humans, it's a bit more complicated, as we'll see.
- 1.25** So what is dominance? We'll talk about dominance first, the evolutionarily older form of dominance, or status, rather. Dominance is associated with narcissism, aggression, disagreeableness. This is in humans, specifically. How dominance works is people instill fear in others through coercion, intimidation, being confrontational, either using violence or the threat of violence to get people to do what you want. And so why do dominant individuals obtain status? Because of what they can do to them—this is one way to do it—to them, so they can inflict costs, pain, humiliation, disfigurement, the threat of violence, and so on.
- 1.26** In response to this, people are willing to defer to a dominant individual. But as we'll see, this type of status, this route to social status, is unstable and often doesn't work out very well for the dominant individual. Here's an example. This is a recent example that I just read of what a dominant individual is. This is Comrade Duch. He was a commandant for the communists in Cambodia. And this is from a book called *The Lost Executioner*, about what occurred in the Communist Revolution in Cambodia.
- 1.27** "It wasn't until he returned"—he, meaning Comrade Duch—"returned to the capital to work at"—no, no, no, rather, this is an employee, sorry. "It wasn't until he returned to the capital to work at Tuol Sleng that he realized how terrifying his new boss could be," his new boss being Comrade Duch. "Nhem Ein said that Duch was hot-tempered and irrational, particularly with his staff. 'He became angry without thinking and ignored their reasons,' he said. 'He gave execution orders without hesitation. They lived in constant fear, ruled by the whims of an arbitrary boss.'" This regime only lasted about 4 years. They sort of speed-ran a communist revolution and destroyed their country after just a few years. That is an example of a dominant leader.
- 1.28** Prestige, on the other hand, is conferred to people for what they can do for you. So dominance is inflicting costs. Prestige is conferring benefits. So prestige is associated with stable self-esteem, social acceptance, conscientiousness. Here's a picture of Stephen Hawking. He is a very high—he was and still is, in the minds of many or most people—a high status person, and he's not a dominant individual. He's a prestigious individual because of his achievements in physics and in science and in science communication.
- 1.29** So it's freely conferred. Dominance is when people take status. They're grabbing it and they're forcing people to bend to their will. Prestige, on the other hand, is freely conferred. Someone does something impressive or important or prominent or beneficial, and we think of that person as having status. We confer this kind of prestige

to them. What can they do? They can provide benefits, teach things, grant access to resources, and often you'll receive a status boost from being associated with them. So if I saw Stephen Hawking, I might be like, "Hey, can we get a picture, Dr. Hawking?" Then you just post the picture online. Even being around them, being in their circle, can elevate your status, even if you yourself haven't done much impressive. But it communicates that "I'm impressive enough to be associated with this high status, prestigious person that they would even want to be around me."

- 1.30 We'll return to dominance and talk about its origins. There's a discussion of dominance hierarchies. You'll see this in a lot of the animal research. Chimpanzees have an established social rank, a social hierarchy. They usually have an alpha chimp. He's not necessarily the strongest chimp, but he can be physically aggressive. You'll seldom see the weakest chimp become the top of the hierarchy within a chimpanzee community. Chickens have literal pecking orders where chickens will peck one another, and then this chicken can peck that one, but not that one. They break out and fight each other. And then very clearly, an order will be established as to who can peck who. And the one who doesn't get pecked at all is the alpha chicken.
- 1.31 Wolves as well. Wolves will engage in these ritualistic combat situations where often one wolf will submit to the victor and expose their neck to the dominant wolf. This is communicating that "you've won, you could kill me if you want." Often, the dominant wolf will actually not kill because they work in packs, but they have to fight each other to suss out who's going to be the leader of this wolf pack.
- 1.32 Dominance works on avoid rather than approach motivations. The idea here is that we do what dominant people want because we want to avoid the cost that they might inflict. So yes, they bargain by inflicting costs. This isn't to say, though, that the subordinates or those underneath the dominant will unfailingly do what the dominant wants. Subordinates can bargain as well by withholding benefits. We'll talk about more of the dynamics of this later. But among animals, subordinates bargain. They'll withhold grooming among apes. They'll maybe conceal food. They won't share. They'll relinquish cooperation when it's convenient and the costs are low.
- 1.33 But at least among animals, and perhaps among human organizations as well, hierarchies are not necessarily a bad thing. A dominance hierarchy among humans usually looks pretty ugly. Among animals, it may be beneficial for them. Prestige hierarchies among humans tend to be quite functional and adaptive. But hierarchies in general, there's a discussion. "Should we all be equal? Should we have an egalitarian society with no hierarchies?" There do seem to be some benefits to hierarchies, depending on what they're based on, prestige or dominance.
- 1.34 Among animals, hierarchies seem to keep the peace. There are some interesting studies with macaque monkeys, for example, where researchers have essentially played this game. They'll look at a community of monkeys, and they'll knock out the top monkey, the alpha monkey. They'll remove him. What tends to occur as a consequence

is bloodshed. Immediately with no leader, the monkeys start to tear one another apart. And what they're trying to do is basically figure out who's the toughest, who's going to take that top spot again. Then they have the new alpha monkey, and then the researchers take him out, see what happens. And they did this a few times. What they basically concluded is that, actually, hierarchies are sources of information for the animals. Once the hierarchy is established, the animals know, "OK, so that person's here, that person's on top, or this monkey."

- 1.35** Something similar seems to happen in prison systems as well. Often when a leader in a prison gang leaves, there's an unstable situation within the prison system, within that gang. When newcomers arrive to prison as well—this is interesting that, when a newcomer arrives, often one of the long-term inmates will challenge the newcomer to a fight because they want to know, "Where would this newcomer stand?" Often what will happen, the newcomer will arrive, someone will pick a fight, and then the other inmates will start to cheer them on because they want to see what this new guy is made of. Where will he fit in this hierarchy?
- 1.36** However, when two inmates who have been in prison for a long time are in the early stages of a potential fight, the other inmates will often interfere. They already know who would win. They have this information already, so they just want to break this up. They don't want to disrupt and destabilize the community. The hierarchy has already been established. These two don't need to fight if they've been here a long time and we already know. OK, so hierarchies are informational sources.
- 1.37** OK, so high rank in a dominance hierarchy. There was an interesting study on chimps recently which found that, well, unsurprisingly, attaining high status in a dominance hierarchy is energetically costly. It's also stressful. It's associated with elevated levels of glucocorticoid, which is a hormone associated with stress. What these researchers suggest is that achieving dominance can increase a chimpanzee's odds of reproduction, but it will also potentially come at the cost of reducing their life span and the increase of general negative emotion and stress.
- 1.38** We talked about this earlier, right, that sometimes traits will evolve that will increase the odds of reproduction at the expense of long-term survival. So yeah, these researchers suggested a cost of dominance rather than a stress of subordination approach. Maybe for longevity in these communities, it's better to be a subordinate, but for reproductive opportunities, it's better to be dominant, even though it can potentially inflict harm on you in these chimpanzee communities.
- 1.39** This is a great book from the personality psychologist, Jessica Tracy. She's talking specifically here about humans. She says, "Dominant people pay for their less kindly route to status by incurring the dislike and even hatred of their fellow group members. And for many of us, this price is simply too high. We'd rather be low on the totem pole than be perceived as arrogant and domineering." We'll talk a bit more about the potential hazards of seeking status via dominance later in the lecture.

- 1.40 Let's talk a bit about prestige, the other route to status. Prestige seems to be uniquely human. I mentioned before that you can see early signs of it, rudimentary signs, among chimpanzees and other apes. But it really seems to be a prominent feature among humans. Based on admiration rather than submission, it's based on approach motivation rather than avoid. So with dominance, they achieve status because people want to avoid the costs that they may inflict on them. Prestigious individuals, we tend to want to approach them. We tend to seek them out. "Oh, this person's high status," and we want to become closer with them.
- 1.41 Mentioned before—because they can confer benefits. So potentially, there's some benefit that you could receive from being affiliated with them in some way. And we freely confer status to these individuals. In the evolutionary or the ancestral environment, humans attained this form of status. They've attained prestige by being skillful and knowledgeable, so whether in hunting or warfare or navigation or storytelling or identifying sources of potentially critical resources, toolmaking, and so on. And that property of our psychology exists today where—there's this interesting conflation now where we confer prestige to people who are knowledgeable. And sometimes people obtain prestige because they're not knowledgeable, but we assume that they have knowledge.
- 1.42 This whole idea of famous for being famous, where someone is very prominent, there's some public figure, maybe because, I don't know, they can eat a lot of food on YouTube or something, but because they have millions and millions of subscribers, people will want their take on things like, "Oh, this guy can eat 10,000 calories in one meal. What do you think about what's going on in Russia, Ukraine?" Somehow people will think, like, "Oh, this guy, because he has so much social attention, he probably has some useful knowledge to share about other topics."
- 1.43 OK, more on prestige. Rank disparities. How do these emerge? I mentioned before—hunting, warfare, navigation, storytelling, and so on. In hunter-gatherer communities, which consist of about 150 people, not everyone is equal on these socially valued traits. Not everyone is as talented as the others in hunting and warfare and so on. So these rank disparities tend to emerge based on what people are good at. We mentioned exceptional knowledge, exceptional skills in valued domains.
- 1.44 What's interesting, though, and we'll talk a bit more about this in a minute, is that even though people may attain high rank within these societies, often they'll downplay it. So in hunter-gatherer communities that exist today that anthropologists and researchers have studied, sometimes there will be leaders and headmen and chiefs and big men and so on, and often what they find is that these socially prominent individuals will downplay, they'll display a lot of humility, self-effacement. They don't want to attract negative attention or the potential envy of their peers. We'll talk about envy more later, too. OK, so we got there.

- 1.45 We'll talk about this transition from dominance to prestige. Dominance among humans—dominance hierarchies tend to be unstable and often hazardous, both for the person who's attempting to achieve dominance, but also for the others as well. The reason for this is documented in this terrific book, *Hierarchy in the Forest* by Christopher Boehm. I wrote a review for it in my Substack last year, I think it was. What Boehm basically argues in this book—and this is like a landmark book, one of the most important books in the field of study of hunter-gatherers—that human communities in the ancestral environment and in existing hunter-gatherer communities today, the few that remain, they tend to be relatively egalitarian. They tend to have status-leveling mechanisms, such that people are roughly equal in social status, that one person doesn't rise too high above the others.
- 1.46 The reasons he gives for this, there's a transition in human evolution where pre-humans, our ancestors before we took on our modern form as *Homo sapiens*, our early ancestors, were more like existing apes today. Very dominance-oriented chimpanzees and gorillas and so on. Even bonobos, a lot of people think—they'll read about bonobos and how they're far more peaceful than chimpanzees. But if you compare bonobos to humans, bonobos, too, are actually far more violent than human beings are. Yes, they're like 1/100th as violent as chimps, but chimpanzees are about 550 to 1,000 times more violent than humans are to one another, to their own peers.
- 1.47 So early humans, they were dominance-oriented. Then as we transitioned into hunter-gatherer communities, there was this shift away from dominance. Humans didn't like dominance, and they found ways to create these mechanisms such that people would not rise too high in the status hierarchy. How did this occur? This was basically through the slow and gradual elimination of bullies. Christopher Boehm suggests three factors that led to egalitarian hunter-gatherer communities, egalitarian meaning status equal. The invention of hunting weapons and the advent of large game hunting. So people could, essentially, once the advent of toolmaking and weapons arose, people could inflict violence on others, on other human beings, with little cost to themselves.
- 1.48 Often, if you watch nature documentary videos or something, or even in fights among humans, if multiple people gang up on one individual, unarmed, the person can usually inflict a bit of damage on the others, even if they're ultimately defeated. But with the rise of arrows and spears and so on, people could kill another individual with little harm done to themselves. This seems to have been—first, these weapons were first used for hunting, and then transitioned into using them for warfare and for taking out members of one's own community.
- 1.49 Then the development of a large brain and cognitive and linguistic capacities, so conspiracies, rumors, gossip, innuendo, and so on. People could form whisper networks. So early humans could basically say—so, the people who were killed in these communities tended to be bullies, what you would think of as a domineering, dominant, alpha male-type, someone who's trying to take all the food, maybe try to

sleep with someone else's wife, try to take more resources than other people believed that they should. The other maybe physically smaller and less dominance-oriented males would basically just conspire with one another and say, "Hey, this guy's a problem." Then they'd get their spears and take them out.

- 1.50** There's a story that I read about some hunter-gatherers a few months ago. I want to say it was actually in this book that we'll be talking about next, where basically, it was a hunter-gatherer group. There was a bully, and he was a risk-taker. The other guys, they're out on a hunt, and they ask him, they dare him, they say, "Bet you can't climb into the top of this tree and get that piece of fruit up there." And so the guy drops his weapons. They didn't like this guy for the reasons I had mentioned. He was a bully. He's like, "Oh, yeah, I'll get that piece of fruit." Takes his weapons off, climbs up to the top of the tree, and when he comes down, the other guys picked up his weapons and stabbed him to death. And that's how we became a bit more docile, and we'll talk about that now. But that's an example of the process that occurred.
- 1.51** This gets us to the self-domestication hypothesis. This is Richard Wrangham's idea. Richard Wrangham is an evolutionary biologist at Harvard. A brilliant scholar. He wrote this excellent book, *The Goodness Paradox*. I mentioned before that, to compare with in-group physical aggression among chimpanzees to human hunter-gatherer communities, chimps are 150 to 550 times more likely than humans to inflict violence against their peers. These are people who they live with, not some enemy or some out-group. This is among their own peer group. Chimps are far more brutal. And bonobos are also more violent as well.
- 1.52** So, let's see. We'll talk about the self-domestication hypothesis, which is roughly what I had mentioned before, that early humans were a bit more, say, wild, so to speak. There were more bullies and dominance-oriented individuals. Gradually, we weeded them out. It's not to say that these traits completely disappeared from the population, but they're far less prominent and prevalent now. You're far less likely to see this pervasive, overt violence, especially within communities. People are far more docile and peaceful relative to our nearest evolutionary relatives.
- 1.53** This is Wrangham's idea of coalitionary proactive aggression. This is what actually distinguishes humans from chimpanzees and bonobos and orangutans and so on. It's not tribalism. Other apes can be tribal, too. They also form groups. If you watch nature documentaries, you'll see chimpanzees go on a hunt against other chimpanzee groups if they're competing for resources or for females and so on. Wrangham makes this distinction between coalitionary proactive aggression and coalitionary reactive aggression. So we'll talk about reactive aggression first.
- 1.54** Reactive aggression is—an example of this would be, I mean, if one chimpanzee just goes up to another chimp and pushes him, just does this, the other chimp will immediately lose his mind and try to kill the one who just did that. They're extremely on this hair-trigger temperament. Very quick, very impulsive, hot-tempered, ready to

throw down at all times. Coalitionary proactive aggression is what distinguishes humans. So early humans, as I mentioned, through this process of self-domestication, we weeded out or eliminated those hot-tempered humans, primarily males, which led to us being more docile among our peer groups.

- 1.55** But it's coalitionary proactive aggression. So rather than being hot-tempered, it's the reverse of that, where it 's associated with strategic-oriented, calm, rational planning. Think about the way that humans carry out warfare. If someone attacks one group, the other group doesn't immediately just lose their mind and launch all the weapons and go after them. They pause and step back and think, "OK, what are we doing now? How can we best hurt that other group?" This works at the individual level, too. If you push one of your friends or something, they're not immediately going to try to kill you like a chimpanzee would. But if you do it enough times, they may start to slowly plan, "How can I get this guy back? What can I do to this person?" It's associated more with a calm, deliberate, calculated planning.
- 1.56** And this is what makes us unusual. Wrangham claims that this gradual transition from weeding out the impulsive intemperamental males and this transition to us being a bit more docile and calm around our peers has also allowed us to be far more vicious to our out-group, this transition to planning, to strategy, to impulse control, and so on. It's good for our in-group, but terrible for our out-group. We tamed ourselves to be kind to those closest to us, to our community, to our social circle. And it also allows us to plan large-scale killings. Wrangham, in this book, he says something along the lines of, I 'm paraphrasing here, but we talk about something like genocide as inhuman. But Wrangham says, actually, it's uniquely human. Only humans have ever carried out a genocide, where they try to take out an entire population of humans.
- 1.57** I should mention here that when I talk about in-group and out-group, we'll talk a bit more about it, not a lot in this course, but in-group and out-group, these are terms that vary. Your in-group could be your sports team, for example. It could be your neighbors, your city, your state, your community. It could be your ethnic group, but not necessarily. As you'll see with sports teams and militaries, people of different ethnic groups can view themselves as part of the same team against an out-group, even if the out-group has members of their same shared ethnic background. You see something like Russia-Ukraine, for example. These are two groups that are very similar in appearance and ancestry, and yet they're going to war with one another. In-group and out-group—these are, they're not clearly defined hard and fast terms. There's a lot of dynamics that underlie these ideas.
- 1.58** I don't want to close you out on this with this idea here. I once heard a psychologist say that a psychopath is someone who treats their in-group the way that ordinary people treat their out-group. That's vicious, impulsive, callousness, this disregard for their feelings, this tendency to dehumanize them. Psychopaths kind of view everyone this way, regardless of whether they're the same group or not. But ordinary people, when

they think of outsiders, of someone from the opposite sports team or the opposite political party or something along those lines—if things get too out of hand, we can start to think in that psychopathic way of like, they're actually not human. They don't feel. They're unthinking, unfeeling, and we tend to dehumanize them.

- 1.59** OK, so a bit more on prestige. I think prestige is more interesting than dominance, too. There's a book here, *Very Important People*, by the sociologist Ashley Mears. In this book, she goes undercover as a model for nightclubs. I think this was in New York City. And what she says in her book, "Free things are a clear marker of status in the VIP world. Free entry, drinks, and dinner signal recognition of a person's social worth. I always said, in nightlife, it's not what you can spend, it's what you get for free. That 's real power." Again, we'll talk more about the actual definition of power later. Just using it in a more colloquialist way here.
- 1.60** So here she's getting at this idea of prestige. It's freely conferred. "You're such a high status person. You don't have to pay anything to get in. Come on in. You're elevating the status of this nightclub just by your very presence. So come on in." So dominance is kind of a, it's an archaic, old—like I said, it's prevalent in the animal kingdom. It makes intuitive sense that if you're going to get hurt for not doing this, then you're just not going to do this, or you're going to listen to this person if they could credibly inflict harm on you.
- 1.61** But prestige requires a bit of foresight. You have to start to think ahead like, "Oh, this person is high status. I'm going to approach them. I'm going to build a relationship with them." You have to think a bit more long term about the rewards that you could receive from building this relationship with them. This is why, this is another reason why, it's a bit more prominent among human beings because we have this capacity to think ahead in a way that other animals don't. Here's prestige. I mentioned before, prestige, conferring status freely. We confer status because we want to, not because we have to. I mean, prestige is interesting, right? How do these ads work? You just put a brand name next to a hot celebrity, and somehow this works to get people to want to buy that more.
- 1.62** So prestige isn't—I mean, it can be used for other things. Besides fancy washes and sugar water, prestige can be used by celebrities for noble ends as well. So there was an op-ed about 11, no, 10 years ago, 2023, 2013, by Angelina Jolie. She wrote an op-ed in the New York Times about getting screened for breast cancer and how this probably saved her life. Some researchers actually looked at the impact of this op-ed and saw this massive increase in the number of women getting breast cancer screenings after this op-ed was published. Even after 6 months, there were still surprisingly high rates of women getting breast cancer screenings after this op-ed.
- 1.63** That doesn't really—I mean, there's something interesting here, because if a doctor writes an op-ed in the New York Times, saying, "Hey, get a breast cancer screening," OK, fine. Doctor telling you about it. Angelina Jolie does it, whoa. Angelina Jolie says to

get a breast cancer screening. She used her prominence to raise awareness of this important issue. Research has dubbed this the Angelina effect. This is how prestige works. Just by the fact that she's prominent and high status and is at the apex of this social ladder that we're far more willing to listen to what she has to say. This issue affected her personally, but it's not as if she has special medical expertise in this, and yet people were willing to listen.

- 1.64** OK, status is not power. We've been talking a bit about status. I've mentioned power a couple of times, but they're not the same thing. Power has a very specific definition in psychological research. What is power? It's control over access to resources. If someone can control whether you receive a paycheck, or control whether you can enter a nightclub, or can control whether you receive a promotion or not, that's power. It's not the same thing as status. Just because someone can control whether you receive a promotion, it doesn't necessarily mean you're going to confer any kind of prestige to them. Dominance is a tricky question there, but the person clearly has power. Status is something separate from that.
- 1.65** Power seems to be a novel development in human evolution simply because, as I said before, hunter-gatherer communities are primarily egalitarian. There's not any one individual who wields immense outsized power. There can be, like I said, big men and chiefs and so on. They wield a bit of more social influence, but it's not as if they can control who gets to eat or not, or who gets to have a wife or not. There's not any one individual who has that level of power in a small-scale human society, where status is something that has existed for a long time.
- 1.66** This quote from Mao Zedong, "Power grows from the barrel of a gun." I think this gets at this idea. Power is something that you need—you need immense resources and a very serious credible threat in order to control access. Power sort of relies on force or the threat of force. If someone tries to control access to resources and he doesn't have violence to back it up, then people will just take the resource from them. Power is something that is novel. So status is not power.
- 1.67** Olympic athletes, here's an example. So, gold medalists. This is Michael Phelps. He has high status. He has prestige. He's reached the pinnacle of his sport, but he doesn't have power. Michael Phelps doesn't get to decide who gets to eat or who gets money, who gets a promotion, anything like that. We confer a lot a lot of status to him. And so, nightclub bouncer. I used this example earlier. You're not necessarily going to think that a nightclub bouncer is the most impressive or prominent or important person in the world, but they do get to decide whether you get to the nightclub. They have high power and low status.
- 1.68** I'll tell you this story. I was enlisted in the Air Force years and years ago. When I arrived at my first duty station, you have to go through this orientation, this first term airman's orientation. The classroom—they had to have a class leader who reported to the instructor and told them what was going on with the class. Most of us, we were

relatively new, had one or two stripes. In the military, there is a very visible ranking hierarchy where, as you move up, they literally sew a stripe on your sleeve and add another one. You can see, "Oh, this guy has high status and power as well." And actually more power than status, as this story will illustrate.

- 1.69** So we had this guy who was our class leader. He had three stripes. The rest of us had one or two. Although he had power, he could potentially issue disciplinary measures or potentially get us maybe demoted. He probably couldn't get us kicked out. He didn't have that level of power. But he did have control over resources, whether you'd—where you would go next, how your day would go, potentially the direction of your career.
- 1.70** So he had this kind of power, but he didn't have status because none of us respected him. He was a goofball. He wasn't especially competent. He wasn't in really good physical shape or anything. It was just a goofy dude who stayed in long enough to—he was in it a bit longer than us and had three stripes. If you've ever had a boss who you listen to simply because they sign your paychecks, but you don't respect the boss, then you'll understand that. You don't really confer status to your boss, but you understand that they have some power over you because they control what your income looks like.
- 1.71** So, sex differences in desire for power. We'll talk more about sex differences later, but I think this is an interesting finding that, who desires status or power more, so you can see that—I'll basically just spell it out. Men want power more than women do. So you see here, let's see. So the darker bars are men. So who wants more power? So men compared to women. And then status, you see that women want status more than—is that right?—more than men do. So surprisingly enough.
- 1.72** That might be an interesting finding that women want status more than men do. Until you think women are a bit more—we'll talk about personality traits later—but women tend to be more agreeable. Most status today relies on prestige. If being well liked, well respected, associated with stable self-esteem and those kinds of things, more affiliated or more associated with women than men. But having control over resources, that's something that men seem to be more interested in than women.
- 1.73** I think there's something interesting here, too, about affiliation. Status, as I said, lives in the minds of other people. You sort of have to be good at building relationships, especially in the prestige route, the prestige-oriented status-seeking. Whereas power, power is about resources, having resources, access to resources, and so on. And in a way, if you have lots of power, you don't need relationships. You can live on a resort and have access to all these resources. You never really need to rely on anyone or have relationships with anyone if you don't want. I think that style of life—I mean, it probably doesn't appeal to many people, but if it does, it probably appeals more to men than to women to retire on a resort and not have to deal with people. We'll talk more about sex differences later.

- 1.74** Also important here that, in terms of status and power, men seem to want it in equal amounts. That's also a notable finding as well. But the main finding I want to focus on here is that men want power more than women do. OK. We'll talk a bit about now the developmental origins. We're talking about the evolution of status. Thus far, we'll talk about the developmental origins. It seems that young children understand what social status is. This is a question, if something is, roughly speaking, nature or nurture. Is it innate? Is it social learning?
- 1.75** I had a professor once in undergrad who was a developmental psychology professor, who said, "If you want to understand the mature form of an organism, it helps to understand its history." This was part of his case for studying children and infants and their psychology. There's a large body of work testing whether young children, preschool-aged children, do they understand what status is? How do they respond to status? Research indicates, for example, that 5-year-old children are selective copiers. If you compare how likely they are to imitate a head teacher versus someone who is equally familiar, same age and gender, maybe a lower-ranking teacher within the school system, children are more likely to imitate the head teacher.
- 1.76** Children seem to observe and see, "Oh, the other teachers are responding to this head teacher, and so therefore, maybe I should pay extra close attention to the head teacher as well," and they're more likely to imitate them. Imitation is essentially like an acknowledgement that someone has high status, if you're willing to do what they do. Imitation was advantageous. We're high-fidelity imitators, humans, and this was adaptive in the ancestral environment. You'll find, for example, that if someone is especially good at tool-making, you'll see the others follow along. If someone's good at navigation, they'll imitate that as well.
- 1.77** But then we sort of over-learn this. If humans learn that there's a guy who's really good at navigation, but then the person is also going fishing, they're more likely to copy that person's fishing methods, too. We overextend that person's skill set and think that they're good at other things as well. You can see this pattern today as well. There's also research indicating that 5-year-olds, if you ask them to evaluate status based on imitation patterns, they assume that someone who imitates another is lower in status. They don't just assume that someone who's being imitated is high status, but they also seem to understand that the person who's doing the imitating is actually probably lower in the status hierarchy than that person who's setting the behavioral norms and the standards in the environment.
- 1.78** Those are 5-year-olds, kindergarten, preschool-aged. But there's also work on infants as well. I'm really glad—so I spent a lot of time when I was an undergrad research assistant working at Yale and Stanford. I started out in infant labs and child labs, and it was a really great experience to learn, how do you test an infant in psychological research? With humans, you put them in a brain scanner, you can have them do behavioral studies, look at their preferences. But with this sort of a blob—I once heard,

I heard Mikhaila Peterson on a podcast describe a baby as a wet noodle with a heavy head. And that's kind of what a baby is. It's just this lump of dough.

- 1.79** But researchers have found clever ways to test what goes on in the minds of an infant. One of the most widely used experimental approaches is looking time studies. Essentially, this is intuitive that you'll habituate to something if you see it repeatedly. When a novel object appears in your visual field, you'll stare at it. You'll see, what is that thing? Then after a while, you'll lose interest. Babies are like this, too, where if something novel appears, something unexpected appears, they'll look at it for a long time. And if they habituate and it lingers for a while, or it continues to flash and reappear, babies will say, "OK." They get bored.
- 1.80** You can see here the looking time. At first, they'll look for a long time, and then it'll dwindle. But then if there's a novel display, something new, they'll look at it a bit more and then it'll kind of dwindle again. Research has used this to see, what do babies expect to happen in the world? Do they have an intuitive understanding of, say, physics? What you find is that, if you show a baby a rubber toy sitting on a table—what they do is they have the baby in this high chair, and then there 's a curtain stage, a little one in front of them, and they open the curtain, and then they see a little rubber toy on a table. How long does it look at this before they start to get bored? If they see a toy sitting on a table, maybe they'll look for a few seconds, and then they start to wander around.
- 1.81** But if researchers rig this visual field so that they open the curtain and there's a rubber toy that appears to be floating in midair—it's not sitting on anything, they rig the contraption so it looks like it's floating—babies will look at it a lot longer than if the toy is sitting on a table. What this suggests is that babies do have an intuitive understanding of how material objects in the world work. They have this intuitive folk physics. They think, "Objects can't just float in midair like that. What's going on here?" It 's as if they're asking themselves, "How is this possible? What's going on?" If they close the curtain and open it again, they'll still continue to stare it for a long time before they start to lose interest.
- 1.82** Whereas if they see the toy, they open and close the curtain, and it's still on the table, they're like, "All right, can we move on?" All right, so that's how they test infants, their expectations of how the world should work. And if they look longer at something to suggest this is novel or unexpected, and therefore, they come into the world with expectations. So now that we've laid out how the looking time studies work, I'll walk you through this slide.
- 1.83** When researchers, basically—what they do for this study on whether infants understand status, this is a tricky thing to do, to set up a scenario in which babies can follow along, follow a story, and then see what their expectations are. But basically what they find is that, when they show infants—so ignore this for now, but we'll just look at this right here. In the absence of information, babies expect resources to be

equally distributed. What does this mean? What they do is they show babies two puppets, and then the researchers will distribute some treats. They'll distribute some resources to them, some treats, and then they'll test how long they look at this distribution of treats.

- 1.84** In one condition, they'll have equal treats. They'll show that each puppet gets five treats. Then in another condition, they'll show babies a situation in which maybe one puppet gets five treats and the other only gets one. In the second case, in which one puppet gets way more treats than the other, babies look longer at that, suggesting that they actually expect equal redistribution of the treats. In the absence of other information, all they're seeing are puppets and treats. If they look longer at the unequal distribution, this is something novel, unexpected. It's as if they're asking themselves, "Hey, why did that puppet—yeah, why did this puppet get more than that one? That's not fair."
- 1.85** Whereas in the other condition, when the treats are equally distributed, they don't look that long. They're thinking, "Yeah, they get an equal amount. That makes sense." So that's in the absence of information. But upon learning, so we're looking here now, upon learning who has status in a hierarchy, it seems that infants expect higher status individuals to receive more resources. They actually used—this is actually funny. It's more of a dominance framework. But what they did is, so first, the infants, they see a small stage. There's a little box, and then there's this high pink chair, pink or magenta. They see a chair in a box, and then they see two puppets come onto the stage, and they're fighting over the big, nice, shiny pink chair. Have a little battle. They battle it out for a minute.
- 1.86** Then one puppet wins. He gets to sit in this shiny chair. Then the other puppet, the subordinate, the loser, gets to sit on the box. They watch this, and then the next thing they see is distribution of resources. In one condition, both puppets, the winner and the loser, receive an equal amount of treats, and in another condition, the winner receives more treats than the loser. Babies look longer when the treats are equally distributed. It's as if they're asking themselves, "Hey, that puppet got the nicer chair. Shouldn't he get more resources? Shouldn't he get more treats?" They're looking longer at this, confused. They expect the winner to receive more. When the winner does receive more, they don't look that long, presumably because they expect, "Oh, the victor should get more of the spoils, " so to speak.
- 1.87** So this seems to capture something about how we enter the world. This expectation about status appears to be, to some extent, intrinsic. But both of these findings, I think, are important, where, in the absence of information, if you know nothing else, the default is resources should be equitably distributed. We don't know anything about anyone else. We start from the point of everyone should have an equal share. But then once we gather information about who has status within the hierarchy, infants seem to

think, "OK, well, maybe resources shouldn't be necessarily equally distributed, but should be distributed based on these status concerns."

- 1.88** We'll talk a bit about sociometric status now. Sociometric status is basically the way that we think about prestige—respect and admiration from our peers. To me, one of the most interesting findings over the last, it must have been 10 or 12 years now, is that sociometric status is a stronger predictor than socioeconomic status for happiness and well-being and self-esteem. This is within developed countries, for example. This is in first world or modern countries, suggesting that once you reach a minimal level of basic material and physical needs, what really seems to contribute to the way we feel about ourselves is how much other people like us.
- 1.89** There was an interesting study more recently showing that people with high sociometric status were actually envied more than the economically rich. They asked people, "Here's a person with high social esteem. They're well regarded, well liked. Then here's a person who's very economically wealthy, high income, high earnings, assets, and so on." People actually report in these studies feeling a bit more envy toward the high sociometric status person than the high socioeconomic status person. It seems like we intuitively understand this, that that's what we are really after—again, once our basic material needs are met.
- 1.90** I haven't seen these studies done in developing countries or in small-scale societies in which their survival is an everyday concern. But once it's not, it seems that this social esteem is more pronounced in our minds. I mentioned before, modern status, primarily based on prestige, and it can be hijacked by advertisers, by influencers. In the ancestral environment, prestige was primarily conferred by useful knowledge and skills. Again, hunting, navigation, warfare, tool-making, etc., whereas today, if you obtain prominence for other reasons, if you manage to gain, whatever, millions of subscribers or something, people will confer prestige to you, even if what you do is not necessarily useful to your community.
- 1.91** Again, we have to remember that a lot of the properties of our psychology evolved in a different environment. Today, it can be manipulated and hijacked. We have to understand that the environment that we're in now is extremely evolutionarily novel. But still, I still think, oh, prestige conferred for whatever—being an influencer or something—it's still preferable to dominance. Dominance, especially in human societies, that route tends to be deadly.
- 1.92** OK, so now we'll talk about—we mentioned before, fundamental human motives. What does it mean to be fundamental in psychological research? There seem to be 4 key criteria for whether something is considered fundamental—this basic primary need. The first criteria: It shapes long-term health, adjustment, well-being, your health. Does it contribute to those things? Does this motive induce goal-directed behavior? Do you chase this? Do you pursue this need, this desire, as an end in itself, rather than as a means to another an end? I 'm sorry, that's the nonderivative. That's number three.

- 1.93** Number two, induces a wide range of goal-directed behavior. It's fundamentally pleasant to obtain it. And failure is fundamentally unpleasant. And then, universal and observed across cultures and individuals, so that makes sense. If it's fundamental, humans, regardless of time and place, should be pursuing it. Status does shape health and well-being. It shapes your adjustment. People with high status feel better. They have higher self-esteem. There's a striking effect size. We won't get into statistics in this course, but basically, this is a large effect size in psychological research, the relationship between subjective well-being and sociometric status. Strong predictor, which we touched on before.
- 1.94** People with high status have fewer health issues, less mental and physical illness. Low status, in contrast, is linked to more depression, more anxiety, negative emotion, and so on. Prestige is good for your health, whereas dominance might be detrimental. As I mentioned before, dominance is associated with stress. Anyway, higher status equals higher self-esteem, higher health, and so on. This suggests that status is a fundamental human need. It does induce goal-directed behavior.
- 1.95** People are vigilant in the way that they monitor their status in relation to their peers, even if it's not conscious. A lot of this stuff, it's not like a conscious, like, "Oh, I'm number three, and he's number two." It's nothing like that. It's just sort of, if you feel put down or belittled, you'll respond with negative emotion. That's your implicit unconscious body responding to a potential falling down that, at least momentarily, that status ladder. And it'll sort of encourage you to either stop doing what you just did that led to that embarrassment or shame, and encourage you to repair whatever it is that you've done, and then seek the positive emotion that results from, whether it's an apology or doing something that leads to whatever, reconciliation.
- 1.96** There's a funny three-pen study. This is one of the early basic studies in social status research. Basically, they found that—these researchers monitored this branch of a finance firm, and there's all these vice presidents working there. At first, they all had one pen on their—this was in the 1950s, by the way. It's all guys, all young men, vice presidents, and each guy had one pen on the desk, and then one of the guys put two fountain pens on the desk, and soon all the others put two fountain pens on the desk, too. Then that guy put three, the other guys put three. It was like suddenly this pen became this arbitrary marker. How many expensive pens do you keep on your desk? This became a little game that they were playing to see who could reach the top, despite the fact that they all had the same official position within the firm, all vice presidents.
- 1.97** Preference for groups, organizations. We tend to seek out affiliation with social organizations that could potentially increase our status. This can vary, whether from sports teams or clubs or universities. We have strong reactions to gain status. Again, these aren't conscious, calculated thoughts that we have. We just have these emotions. We feel pride, jubilation, honor. You glow when you receive adulation and adoration

from other people. When you don't, when people disapprove of you or condemn you in some way, you respond with these negative emotions. And these emotions are basically information, and motivate you to shift your behavior.

1.98 There's been some interesting discussion around fairness as well, that people are highly concerned with fairness, and specifically with regard to the distribution of material resources. Often what people really care about, it's not that they care about the material resource in itself, but they care about—they claim they care about the fairness, but what they really care about is, do you respect me? Do you confer me enough status to treat me the way that I'd like to be treated?

1.99 For example, if you discover that other people at your job, other people with the same position as you, are getting paid more than you, even if you have a comfortable salary, imagine you're still comfortable, you're still making a lot of money, but you discover your coworkers are making way more than you, you're going to say, "Hey, there's something wrong here. This is unfair. What's going on?" If your boss says, "Well, we're paying you a lot of money anyway. Just relax," you're going to respond with anger, right? "This is not right." That feeling, that belittlement, that feeling is that you're not being treated with the same level of status as the others despite the fact that you are earning a high wage, just lower than the others.

1.100 Status is nonderivative. It feels good in and of itself. I mentioned before that people will forgo material resources for status. They'll pay for social media followers, and they'll forgo other kinds of material resources. They'll forgo food. People will forgo food to look attractive. They'll forgo sleep, like a physiological need. They'll stop sleeping because they want to work hard to get promoted and earn more money, or to impress other people, or work on their craft. If they're an athlete, their sport, they'll literally damage their health, at least temporarily, to chase this invisible resource. I told the Yale lecturer's story already.

1.101 OK, status is universal. You'll find it cross-culturally. I've been talking a bit about hunter-gatherer communities, the research from Christopher Boehm and others, Richard Wrangham. Status—it's called different things, though. A lot of people, when I talk about status, when I do interviews and stuff, they'll say—status—people feel almost offended by this. Like, "Is it really just about status? Do people really care that much about status?" It feels like this cheap term, status. "Oh, status pursued." But there are other terms that other cultures use, and we use these terms as well, to some degree.

1.102 Somehow these terms are—like, using the term respect. If someone says, "I'm doing X because I want status," you'll think like, "What are you, like a superficial, shallow person when you just want status? That's so, it's so cheap, vulgar." But if he says, "I'm doing X because I want respect," oh. they're basically synonyms, right? But for some reason, respect carries these more respectful connotations. Other cultures say things like face, they're chasing honor, esteem. Status is the term that we use in psychology.

- 1.103** Hunter-gatherers, we've talked about what are the qualities that lead hunter-gatherers to attain status. Hunting, I mean, hunters—a lot of the research on status has been done on hunting because it seems to be a very—well, first of all, it's dangerous. I think just studying this dangerous activity is interesting for researchers. But then also this is a very obvious and direct way for hunters to display all of these qualities that confer status. Hunters receive more respect, they have more sexual partners, they have more offspring. These are on the relatively few existing hunter-gatherer communities that remain. This is what researchers have found. Anthropologists.
- 1.104** There's some interesting work on big game hunting and status. Robin Dunbar and others, they've discussed this, other researchers, about—Kristen Hawkes, this is the person who I think did some of the original research on this, where they found that, in terms of return on investment, big game hunting is actually probably unwise, where hunter-gatherers would probably be better off killing rabbits and squirrels and raccoons and small game. They could catch more of them in a shorter amount of time and so on. Whereas it takes hours, sometimes days, to track a big animal and take him down. Yes, you get more meat, but in terms of time spent versus calories received, it's actually not a wise strategy.
- 1.105** But what Kristen Hawkes and other anthropologists just have suggested is that big game hunting is basically a way to demonstrate athleticism, bravery, prowess, all of these things that are attractive in a potential romantic partner. And so the big game hunters, they partake in this on—it's not to say that they don't do it for food. Of course, they want the food. But there's also that added incentive. The reason why it seems to be an unwise investment from a caloric perspective is in part probably because it's a wise perspective from a reproductive evolutionary perspective. It motivates them to do this impressive thing, to take out a big animal.
- 1.106** Yeah, overconfidence. Overconfidence, in some regard, is probably wise. If you want to bolster your status, believing you can do something can often help you to actually do it. But the areas in which people are overconfident tend to be associated with the domains that confer status in a given culture. In more individualistic cultures, especially in the U.S., people tend to overestimate their ability to lead. If you measure their actual leadership ability and their resume and their record of leadership versus what they say about their ability to lead, there's a mismatch. People think that they're better leaders generally than they really are.
- 1.107** In collectivistic societies, the ability to listen is highly valued. If you ask people about their own ability to listen, and then you ask their peers separately, "How good is this person at listening?", you'll often find this mismatch where people systematically overestimate this ability. This suggests, too, that status is universal because the thing that's valued is the thing that they overestimate themselves on.
- 1.108** We're going to go a bit over. So, pain of low status. I've talked a bit about emotions and how emotions basically feed into your knowledge, your feeling. Our concerns about

status aren't necessarily conscious, explicit, verbalized in our minds, but rather through how we feel. One of the most interesting research models that looks at how social exclusion and thwarting fundamental human needs can lead to losses in self-esteem and so on, it's this game called Cyberball. It's a very simple game, and I've used it in some of my own research. Essentially, you want to induce social discomfort in participants. You want to get them to feel excluded.

- 1.109** It's a very simple game. Basically, you have them play this ball-tossing game, this digital ball-tossing game. This is you, you, as in the participant, and you're playing with two other players. It's actually part of a computer game, but you tell the participants, "Hey, you're playing with two other people in different locations, and toss the ball back and forth." In one condition, you're included throughout the game. As a participant, you basically just toss this digital ball for about two minutes. Kind of boring, just tossing the ball back and forth. You click your mouse, you click this guy, you can toss the ball to him, he can toss it to you, you may click this guy, and so on.
- 1.110** The other condition, basically, you are the player and you're tossed the ball one time. Then for the remainder of the game, you just watch these two players toss the ball back and forth, and you're just sitting there. I did my studies—a lot of these studies—when I did this study here, this was during the lockdown, so I had to do this online. But researchers have done this in a lab setting where they bring people and sit them down on a computer. When they are excluded from the game, often participants, they'll get visibly upset if they're not included in the game. Some of them will tap the computer screen as if this is going to alert them like, "Hey, what's going on? Hey, I'm here, too." They get upset at being socially excluded.
- 1.111** And after they play this game, we ask them, we ask these scales about your self-esteem, your sense of control, your meaningfulness, your sense of belonging. We'll ask you all these questions. You find this massive effect size that people feel much worse about themselves, even after playing this silly two-minute game. We find this effect even when you control for personality traits. For example, introverts, extroverts, disagreeable individuals, everyone feels upset when they're excluded from this ball-tossing game.
- 1.112** The origins of this game, by the way, are interesting. So the person who invented this game, Kip Williams, in the early—I want to say this was the early 2000s—the idea for Cyberball came to him when he was sitting in a park by himself, and he says a Frisbee landed next to him. He picks up the Frisbee. He's like, "Where'd this come from?" He sees two guys playing Frisbee with one another, and he's like, "Oh," tosses it back to them. He watches them toss the Frisbee to one another, and then they toss the Frisbee back to him. Now he's included in this game. He tosses the Frisbee.
- 1.113** Then after maybe one or two rounds of this, the two guys walk off and return to their game. He says, "Now, I'm sitting there in the park, and I was like, 'Hey, I thought we were part of this game.'" He suddenly felt bad about himself. He didn't know these

guys. They were complete strangers to him. Randomly, the Frisbee lands, and he's momentarily included, and then he's excluded. And he felt surprisingly sharp emotions for this—what you would expect, in an objective sense, a silly, trivial thing. And so this led him to invent Cyberball.

- 1.114** But why do we feel so bad? These sort of one-shot contact. You're momentarily excluded in a silly game with strangers, even in a computerized context where you don't even see the person. The reason seems to be that we didn't meet strangers in the ancestral environment. Human beings almost never had these one-shot encounters with another person. Almost every single person a human would ever meet in a hunter-gatherer, a small-scale society, is someone that they would have iterated, repeated interactions with over and over. Each interaction held high stakes in terms of reputational concerns.
- 1.115** Because that was the environment in which our psychology evolved, we still have those properties in our mind today, and we respond to each social encounter as if it holds immense consequences. You get a coffee at the shop, and the person says something impolite to you, you'll respond like, "Oh." For some people, that will ruin their whole day. For a lot of people, it will upset them for a few minutes, even if you never see that person again. In some cases, this can be helpful. It keeps us honest when we deal with strangers. Because even though, on an objective rational level, I'm never going to see this person again, you still have the psychology of a human being who would feel that they would interact with this person again.
- 1.116** It can be detrimental as well. Sometimes we have a bit too much anxiety and other negative emotion for fleeting and consequential interactions with strangers. I've worked with and talked to young guys who can't even order a pizza on the phone because they're so fearful of embarrassing themselves or saying the wrong thing when they order food. For them, they always just order online. That kind of social anxiety is obviously maladaptive.
- 1.117** So thwarted status, this Cyberball game, feeling excluded. This is what some researchers, they call it a strong situation. In social psychology, there's this idea of situational strength. What situational strength is—when a situation is strong, people will respond to it the same way regardless of their individual traits, regardless of personality and intelligence and impulse control and so on. An example is a red light. This is a strong situation. Regardless of your personality traits and all these other measures, almost everyone will stop at a red light. Regardless, it's strong.
- 1.118** A yellow light is what's called a weak situation. There's no explicit protocol for how to respond to a yellow light. Some people, perhaps with less impulse control or lower on conscientiousness or something, they'll just speed right through. Other people will slow down. They'll even slow down perhaps a bit too early. And so in some cases, our individual differences tend to matter a lot. In other cases, when the rules are clear and rigid, we'll respond in the same way. Being excluded seems to be a strong situation.

Regardless, as I mentioned, regardless of personality, being excluded hurts. Losses, thwarted status, reduction in esteem. It seems to hurt everyone. Some people will say, "I don't care what people think." Most of the time, that's nonsense.

- 1.119** Psychological adaptation. There have been some interesting studies on this idea of the psychological mechanism in humans called the sociometer. This is basically belonging. It monitors whether you belong in the environment. This is pre-attentive. This is unconscious, the way that we monitor the environment. You're not consciously thinking, "Do I belong? Am I accepted? Am I excluded? Am I excluded?" Again, you just respond in with certain kinds of emotions if you are excluded versus if you are not. It's relevant to status, but it doesn't actually monitor status. Belonging and status are tightly linked, but they're not the same thing. The sociometer seems to monitor communion—how much you're getting along with other people, how much social acceptance you have. You can belong even if you have low social status. But we'll talk more about agency and communion in a minute.
- 1.120** Then there's the hierometer. The hierometer is about status. It tracks and regulates where you stand in a social hierarchy. This psychological mechanism is—again, it's correlated with but distinct from status. You can think of cases where you can be low in belonging but high in status. People can regard you or hold you in high regard, even if they don't necessarily accept you. You can think of lonely CEOs or something like that. This is more preoccupied with agency. We'll talk about agency and communion. High status identities, we'll talk about that later.
- 1.121** Here's a diagram of how hierometer and sociometer works. Hierometer tracks status, sociometer tracks inclusion. Hierometer is basically tracked by how you feel about yourself, your self-esteem, but also with narcissism. We'll talk a lot about narcissism later in another lecture. These regulate assertiveness—assertiveness meaning, are you going to put yourself out there to attain status? The sociometer is more about affiliativeness. So self-esteem, how you feel about yourself, tracks your belongingness, and then this leads you to build relationships with other people. The goal of sociometer is actually to avoid exclusion.
- 1.122** OK, so yeah, this is just the summary here. One monitors inclusion, one monitors status. One's communal in character, sociometer is communal in character, the hierometer is agentic in character. And in some cases, people will sacrifice status to get along, and in other cases, they'll sacrifice getting along in order to attain status. We're chronically conflicted, human beings. We want to fit in and we want to stand out at the same time. That's one way of thinking about it.
- 1.123** OK, so I like this example. I don't know how many of you read *The Great Gatsby* or watched the movie from 10 years ago now. But Nick Carraway in the book, he states in the book that, "I graduated from New Haven in 1915," and Carraway is the narrator of this story. New Haven, he's not talking about—I think there is a University of New Haven. I don't know if there was one in 1915. But he actually went to Yale. Yale is

located in New Haven. But he says, "I went to New Haven." He downplays his educational pedigree. He wants you to know, the reader, as the narrator, he wants you to know "I'm a humble guy." He comes from this old money background. He's not trying to impress you. He's just trying to tell you a story. He's communal. He wants to get along.

- 1.124** Gatsby, on the other hand—he is very quick to tell Nick Carraway in the story, "Was brought up in America, but educated at Oxford." He tells him explicitly what his fraudulent educational credentials are. Gatsby, actually, he wasn't educated at Oxford. But Gatsby is chasing status. He wants to be accepted. He's new money. He wants to be accepted by this old money society. He wants the acceptance of Nick Carraway and, ultimately, to try to win Daisy back. He's agentic in character, and he's going for an overt bid for status.
- 1.125** These are the two—well, one researcher called them the big two, the cardinal axes, along which we chart the course of our lives. Communion is about getting along. Agency is about getting ahead. One is about belonging, the other is about status. If you're high agency, high communion, you're directing, helpful. If you're low agency but high in communion, you're understanding and you're compliant. But these two traits govern our social lives. We want status, but we also want to be accepted. Sometimes if you chase status too much, you can actually, you can actually lead people to dislike you or to envy you or to abandon you. So we're constantly walking that sort of tight rope.
- 1.126** Morality and competence are two traits that are associated. Morality is associated more with communion, with getting along. Competence is associated more with agency or getting ahead. Collectively, these two traits, your moral character and your competence, seem to encompass the bulk of how we form our impressions of other people. We implicitly ask ourselves, "Is this person a capable person?" Then, "How good of a person is this?" Those are the two traits that we seem to focus on the most when we meet a new person and form our impression of them. Moral character is actually the trait that people are the most concerned with when they meet a new person and try to determine what type of individual they are.
- 1.127** We're reaching the end here. I want to just briefly touch on insults as status injuries. Most insults that are directed at people, other than appearance, appearance is like an obvious one that people make fun of. But appearance aside, where do people direct their insults? Mostly to their competence or to their morality or their ability to get along or get ahead. So male-directed insults, so worthless, weak, poor, pussy, dumb, useless, scared. This is directed at their competence. And then shithead, controlling asshole, self-absorbed liar. These are directed at their moral character.
- 1.128** Then for female-directed insults as well—worthless, poor, needy, disgusting, annoying. These are kind of insults directed at competence, and then slut, skank, gold digger, or shallow. These are the most common insults, and they tend to be directed, I mean, these are sort of affiliated with moral character. These are the most common insults, by

the way. This was a recent study, 2021. These are the most common, not necessarily those words specifically, but those words and their synonyms. We're going to talk about psychopathy much more in this upcoming lecture.

Lecture 2: Status Dynamics

At a glance — Status dynamics.

- 2.1 So far, we've been discussing status as a universal fundamental human motive, and we've covered plenty of evidence suggesting that this is indeed the case, that everyone is motivated to some extent to pursue the respect and admiration of other people. But today, we're talking a bit about the individual differences.
- 2.2 Some people desire status more than others. Not all of us have an equally intense desire for it. You can think of it as something akin to hunger. Everyone wants food, but some of us feel hunger more often than others. The intensity of this experience varies from person to person, and the same is true of status. The intensity of the desire for status and its pursuit are associated with various traits we'll be covering today. We'll speak about intelligence. We'll speak about the Big Five personality traits. We'll talk about a concept in social psychology known as self-monitoring. We'll talk about the Dark Triad personality traits. We'll talk about light triad, as well as age, virtue signaling, moral grandstanding, and if there's time, maybe a bit more.
- 2.3 Before we continue, I want to point something out. We'll be discussing these traits and these individual differences in terms of averages. Naturally, with social scientific phenomena, there are going to be exceptions to many of these cases. In some of these studies, the relationships between variables will be small to moderate in magnitude. Most guys are shorter than the typical WNBA player, and yet this doesn't refute the general fact that, on average, men are taller than women. So if you can think of an exception to something, that's fine, but that doesn't negate the fact that average differences exist and that outliers exist. Just keep that in mind moving forward.
- 2.4 I also I wanted to say that we're going to reserve Q&A for this session for the beginning of the start of the next lecture. If you have questions, it'd probably be best to write them down, write some notes, and we're going to reserve those for later. OK, so let's go ahead and and get started.
- 2.5 We're going to start with intelligence and its association with status. What is intelligence? The psychologist, Arthur Jensen, described it as "assimilation of experience, learning, into cognitive structures which organize what has been learned in various ways or in ways that subsequently permit quick and adequate retrieval and broad transfer of the learning in new relevant situations."
- 2.6 "Stated in simplest terms, the process of understanding what one has learned, getting an idea, catching on, having the aha experience that may accompany or follow experiencing or learning something, and the relating of new material to past learning and vice versa." Essentially, how quickly can you absorb and synthesize information and apply it to novel contexts? How quickly can you retrieve information that you know and

also to absorb new information, integrate those things, and solve puzzles and problems in a variety of contexts?

- 2.7** Intelligence and status, they do seem to be some correlation here. IQ is—among the traits that we've studied in psychology, IQ seems to be the strongest predictor of income, for example. Correlation coefficient is around 0.3, 0.4. This is relatively large in psychology. Intelligence also seems to consistently predict leadership emergence as well, both in university settings and in occupational settings as well. People generally accord higher status to competent, intelligent individuals, people who are good at quickly grasping new material, or seem to know a lot of things. We do tend to accord higher status, especially higher prestige, to these kinds of people.
- 2.8** What's interesting, though, so there is a link between education and intelligence. People who score higher on measures of intelligence tend to achieve more education. But if you measure people's need for status, people with the highest levels of education report the strongest desire for status. The more education you receive, the stronger the status, the need for status, becomes. This doesn't necessarily imply a causal mechanism like, "Oh, as you obtain more degrees, you suddenly want status more." It could go the reverse, where people who really want status pursue it by attaining more degrees. It could be a reverse causation.
- 2.9** But what seems to happen, at least, what I think might be going on, at least in some circumstances, is that education raises your expectations. There's some research indicating, for example, that education has no relationship with happiness. If you take two individuals and one has more education than the other, it's not going to tell you anything about who's happier than the other person. And what some researchers have speculated is that basically education raises your expectations for yourself. You think, "Once I get the degree, I'm going to earn this much." And especially people who get more education believe, they predict, that they're going to have more free time. They're going to have more vacation time, more downtime. They're not going to have to work as hard and so on.
- 2.10** Actually, what happens is that often more education comes with more hours, more work, more responsibility. And so there's this mismatch. You expect your life to go one way, and actually, you end up having very much the opposite—less free time, more responsibility, more stress, and so on. And so as a result of these expectations not being met, your happiness suffers as a result. So this expectation-raising effect may explain both the desire for education, but then it also predicts this, this need for status.
- 2.11** Interestingly, though, there may be this sweet spot for intelligence and social influence. The psychologist, Dean Simonton, has suggested that, actually, "for social appeal, to gain followers, to be respected and admired by a large number of people, you want to be smart, but not too smart." Around IQ 119, which is a bit higher than the average college graduate, which is around 110 or 111, but it's lower than the typical graduate of an elite university, which is around 125. You're a little bit smarter than the average

college graduate, but maybe not as high as really at the peak of the university system. So 119 IQ, a little bit more than a standard deviation above the mean.

- 2.12** Basically, Simonton suggests that if you want to be a leader, it's good for you to understand complex ideas and arguments and so on from the real geniuses, but then also be able to relate and communicate and interact with ordinary people, less educated people. Interestingly, I think it was Simonton, it might have been another researcher who suggested that, for presidential elections, it's actually the less intelligent candidate who tends to win in presidential elections. This isn't borne out by empirical research. This is just a speculation by some psychologist.
- 2.13** By the time you get to the general election, you've passed certain thresholds of intelligence. You've been filtered out. You've probably graduated college, and you've probably done some impressive thing or another in your career, whether in politics or otherwise. You've already met a minimal threshold. Maybe you've met that threshold of 119. But when you have two people and you have, like, one really smart guy or woman or someone who's less intelligent, but still more intelligent than the average, that person may be more likely to appeal to large numbers of voters.
- 2.14** Even prominent politicians who have successfully won presidential elections and have been smart, some political analysts and commentators and so on have acknowledged that they're actually really good at communicating with ordinary people. Bill Clinton was an example. Bill Clinton was a Rhodes scholar, high educational pedigree, but he also grew up in a trailer park and spent a lot of time in his early life around ordinary people. This may have contributed to his ability to connect when he was the president and when he was running.
- 2.15** Another interesting thing here about this sweet spot effect. Other research has found that this may be the case for romantic partnerships as well. When you ask people how smart you would like your potential romantic partner to be, they tend to pick around 120 IQ. They want partners who are roughly at the 90th percentile of intelligence, someone who's smart but not too smart, not someone who's so smart that maybe they can't relate to them or have shared interests anymore. They want someone who is intelligent, but that they can still have conversations with about a wide variety of topics.
- 2.16** OK, we'll move on to personality. Essentially, intelligence does seem to predict, to some extent, social status. Personality traits. The most widely used model of personality is the Big Five model. Many people can easily sort of retain this in their mind with the acronym OCEAN, so openness, conscientiousness, extroversion, agreeableness, neuroticism. Neuroticism is sometimes reverse-scored as emotional stability. Then they break down into these lower-order facets. We're not going to get into the low-order facets. We'll be talking about the Big Five traits in a broad level.

- 2.17** What is openness? We're going to briefly cover what each trait is, just so you have a sense as we move forward. People who are open tend to be entrepreneurial and creative. They tend to receive information from a larger variety of sources. Open-minded, a lot of people can get it in an intuitive sense from that term. They're more likely to get tattoos and piercings. They're more likely to relocate for school and work, more —not open, but they are more open to going somewhere new, doing something different, trying out new things. In terms of their tastes, they enjoy philosophical novels, surrealist films, more abstract intellectual entertainment. On average, openness is associated with higher levels of education, and people high in openness tend to have fewer children.
- 2.18** There's conscientiousness. Conscientiousness is industriousness. It's orderliness. It's punctuality. People who are high in conscientiousness tend to excel at school and work, save more money. They have more impulse control. They stick to their habits and routines. In terms of their tastes, they like books about history and leadership, and enjoy films with plots involving weddings or fist fights. In that study, I didn't actually see them break this down by sex or gender, but I'm guessing there is probably a gender difference there in terms of the movies.
- 2.19** More likely to use filled pauses. This was an interesting study, too. This is a relatively recent study. They used these discourse markers. People high in conscientiousness are more likely to say, "Uh, um, I mean, you know, like, well—" All of these pauses in their speech, perhaps because they're less impulsive, so they're thinking through, and that's a filler. There's sort of a gap as they, "Do I really want to say this? Where am I going with this?" It takes a bit of effort for conscientious people to overcome this and speak without them, whereas less conscientious people will just speak because perhaps they're not quite thinking as clearly about where they're going to go next, and they're just moving forward and going for it.
- 2.20** OK, so extroversion. People generally know extroversion versus introversion. Extroverts enjoy social attention. The real difference between extroverts and introverts is how you feel after social interactions. So extroverts, when extroverts spend a lot of time around other people in social environments, they tend to be energized by it, and they tend to feel an emptiness when they go long periods without social interaction. Whereas introverts, they feel drained after social engagement. They need a minute, they need to go decompress, wind down, they need to take a breather.
- 2.21** But this is not like a dichotomous variable. Extroversion—all of these traits are on a spectrum. Some people score high, some people score low, or somewhere in the middle. There's also this term ambivert, which hasn't—I don't think it's quite caught on in the personality research, but it's this phrase I've seen thrown around where people can go—they like being around people, but they need it in small doses. They can't have intense social interaction all the time the way that someone who's really high in extroversion would. But they also don't like to be completely socially isolated either.

- 2.22** They're more likely to assume leadership positions. This is interesting. I mean, extroversion is, it's a trait that makes you more assertive. People who are assertive and put themselves out there are naturally going to capture the attention of other people. When people need to elect leaders or put someone in a position of prominence, extroverts tend to be selected for many of those positions. Extroverts have more friends and sexual partners. Unsurprising, they are more social. More car accidents, too. Spend more time on the road. They're more likely to be injured in various kinds of physical events, sports, and so on. In terms of their tastes, they favor memoirs, books about relationships. It's unsurprising. They're interested in the social world. Oh, yeah. Comedy and movies about dating and friendship.
- 2.23** Then what's interesting here—we may have time to get to this later, but introverts actually report being happier when they go against their natural impulses and behave in a more extroverted fashion. There's this affective forecasting error where introverts predict that they will feel worse after social interaction, but oftentimes, they'll actually feel better. And oftentimes they'll actually feel —they'll report feeling more authentic, which is interesting that you ask them about how authentic they feel in very social situations. And if we ask you to behave like an extrovert, how authentic would you feel? Introverts say, "That's not who I am." But then after they do it, they actually do report feeling more authentic.
- 2.24** The reasoning here seems to be that, generally, people report feeling more authentic when they do things that give them status. When they do things that are socially valued, they report feeling higher levels of authenticity. And those studies were done in the U.S., and in the U.S., being an extrovert, being extra social, and so on, those things tend to be highly valued. Therefore, people report feeling higher levels of authenticity because they receive higher regard from other people when they're around people versus when they're isolated.
- 2.25** Agreeableness. People who are agreeable, they tend to avoid conflict. They like social harmony. They like compromise, they like negotiation, they don't like tense social situations or disagreements. They're more likely to volunteer and help people in need. They tend to have, for men at least, fewer sexual partners, high agreeableness. Disagreeable men tend to have more sexual partners. For women, there doesn't seem to be much relationship or association between agreeableness and sex partners. Agreeable people tend to have more children. It's also associated with lower earnings, especially for men, but for women to some degree, too. This high agreeableness, lower earnings. They like books about family and relationships and conventional feel-good movies.
- 2.26** Then there's neuroticism, finally. This is the last of the Big Five. The hallmark of this trait—so again, neuroticism, these two terms are used interchangeably now. I think there's this slow transition now. More studies I'm seeing using this term emotional stability. It's the reverse. It's neuroticism, reverse-scored. It's the opposite, basically, of

neuroticism. I think it's because the other four traits have these positive connotations, being conscientious, being open, being agreeable. These are like positive. Then neuroticism has this negative charge to it. So they switched it to emotional stability, I think, because now they're all positive, more or less.

- 2.27** So the hallmark of this trait, mood variability, strong reaction to emotional setbacks. It's your emotional ticker, how much it swings up and down, and the magnitude of those swings. People high in emotional stability tend to experience less depression and anxiety, whereas people who are high in neuroticism experience more frequent bouts of low mood and irritability and so on. People who are high in emotional stability—this is high, high emotional stability, low neuroticism—they like action movies and books about philosophy and science.
- 2.28** Then I briefly want to talk about the HEXACO model. We're not going to talk a lot about this, just very briefly. This is a competing model, the HEXACO personality model. There's a lot of overlap between the HEXACO model and the Big Five. HEXACO, it's like, so honesty humility, which we'll get to in a minute. But then emotional control, which is like stability, extroversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and openness.
- 2.29** The main difference here is the H in HEXACO, which is honesty humility. There's some overlap here with honesty and humility, or honesty humility—it's one trait—and agreeableness. There's still some debate about it, but basically a simple way to think about this is people who are high in agreeableness are more willing to interact with someone who might exploit them. They're forgiving, they're accepting, they're flexible, they prefer harm, they want people to get along. Honesty humility is more about your—I guess you could think about your ethical character, how authentic you are, essentially how willing you are to exploit others. So agreeableness is, "I'll cooperate with someone even if they might exploit me." People who scores highly on honesty humility is, "Wouldn't exploit someone else." That's one way to think about it. Willingness to be exploited versus willingness to exploit.
- 2.30** OK, so personality and status pursuit. There are basically two factors here that predict status. Your own motivation and desire and ability to attain it, and then the group's judgments, other people's judgments, of what you've done to attain it. Other people get to decide. So, how much you want it and how much other people confer to you. Individuals motivated to attain higher status. Motivation does—it's unsurprising, people who want status more are, in fact, more likely to attain it. Strong status motivation is associated with greater attainment of status.
- 2.31** Let's move on to personality traits. Do these personality traits actually predict status? Let's discuss. Personality and status pursuit. Before we actually get into the individual-level traits and their association with status, we should talk a bit about, we've been touching on it on and off in the last lecture and in this one, about how much of this is conscious, calculated, deliberate. Are people just calculating status in their minds in a verbalized, explicit way? The answer is no. Evolution made most of our desires and

motivations and so on unconscious. It's operating under the hood, so to speak. But we still speak about people as if, "Oh, he wants status, they want status," and so on. Sometimes it's conscious, most of the time it's not.

- 2.32** I really like this analogy. This is from the philosopher Daniel Dennett. He says, "A single-celled organism doesn't know the reason why it swims toward nutrients." It doesn't know anything at all. There's no internal representative model of why it's behaving as it does. But when we speak about single-celled organisms, we say, "It wants nutrients, it's seeking sustenance." We speak about it as if it's this agentic thing that has an internal model and is pursuing something, but it actually has no internal conscious awareness. When a spider builds a web, it doesn't have an image of the web in mind as it's building. It's following its instincts, and then as a result of it, just doing what comes naturally. The web appears, and then they act from there.
- 2.33** I think most of our behaviors are this way, too. We, humans, we're reflective, we're smart, but most of the time, even humans, we don't really know all the reasons why we do what we do. Throughout this course, I'll be discussing status as one of those motivators, whether conscious or unconscious, but largely unconscious. Talked about that. So we'll start with extroversion. This one seems to have the highest relationship with status. I touched on this earlier, that extroversion —we'll start with this study.
- 2.34** Study of groups, individuals. Basically, when you put groups of individuals and they interact with one another, this is a classic study—that a hierarchy emerged within just, well, within one minute, 50% of the groups, a hierarchy had emerged, and then with five minutes, the other 50% had formed a hierarchy as well. This is an older study, but there have been similar studies done since then. Basically, what I think is going on here, and I think it's informed by a lot of research, is that extroverts are the ones who attain status in those situations. That's just because they talk more.
- 2.35** People who talk a lot, they occupy a lot of our mental real estate, and we think like, "Oh, who should be a leader? Who should be in charge? Who should be the one to manage?" It's like, "Oh, the person who talks a lot." It doesn't necessarily mean that extroverts are, in fact, more capable as leaders. It just means that we think they are, and they are more likely to attain those positions. There is a small correlation between extroversion and income. It's small in magnitude, I mean, a correlation coefficient of 0.5. It's not huge, but it's a small boost.
- 2.36** Yeah, extroverts are not necessarily more talented or competent, but they put themselves out there. They're assertive. They're willing to talk to you and talk to others and be more sociable and seek that social attention. They can be better leaders in some context. I think there are other factors that are involved. If you're an extrovert and you're intelligent and aware and good at getting along and agreeable and those kinds of things, then you can become a good leader. Extroversion is just one ingredient, and it doesn't seem to have a lot of predictive power.

- 2.37** However, there was one study which found that, just among men, not among women, but among men specifically, a one standard deviation increase in extroversion was associated with almost half a million dollars more throughout the course of their careers. Again, this isn't to say that they're more competent or talented at their job, but it's just when you are assertive and put yourself out there, you're just more likely to be open to these kinds of opportunities, to be promoted, and so on. If you work long enough in different organizations, you'll see that a lot of people who talk a lot in meetings, they seem to receive a lot of attention and maybe be put into positions that they're not always the most suited for, but simply because, "Oh, we need a person here. Oh, well, who can I think of? Oh, the person who talks a lot." OK.
- 2.38** The smartest person versus the smartest movie style genius. This is basically that a lot of the smartest people, the most competent people, they're not actually that extroverted. A lot of highly intelligent people are maybe more introverted. They're just not in a position to constantly broadcast their intellect. But if you're a smart person and you're extroverted, then those are the kinds of people that we tend to think, "Oh, that's a really smart person because they talk a lot, they broadcast the things that they know, and they talk about it," and so on.
- 2.39** So extroversion and status-pursuing behaviors, there is a sizable link there, correlation there. People who are more extroverted do tend to pursue status more often than people who are relatively low on extroversion. So they do seem to be interested in status, and that may be one reason among many why they enjoy social attention and talking so much. OK, so agreeableness and status. This one also seems to have a relatively small effect, an inverse correlation, meaning that disagreeable people, people who are low in agreeableness, or another way to think about it—high in disagreeableness—are more likely to attain status.
- 2.40** There was a study of high IQ individuals, people—this was a longitudinal study over the course of their lives. These were just on high IQ men, I believe. This was a 20—yeah, where basically agreeable men, on average, earned \$267,000 less over the course of their lives. Agreeable people are less likely to be nominated as leaders, and they also report a smaller desire, less desire, for status. Interestingly, though, there's no correlation between the behaviors of pursuit of status, but there is a reduced desire. They're no more or less likely to behave in a way that will accrue them status, but they just report less desire for it.
- 2.41** So often with an agreeable person, maybe you'll want to give them a promotion or something like that, and maybe they'll downplay or they'll recommend someone else. Even though they're doing the things that may lead to promotion, they'll try to often resist because they just have that less of a, less of a desire. Why do disagreeable people attain status? Well, we'll get to that a bit later. But often, for example, disagreeable people are more likely to negotiate for higher salaries. They're more likely to pursue promotions. They're more likely to prioritize getting ahead versus getting along.

- 2.42** Conscientiousness and status. This is an interesting one. Higher status, or higher conscientiousness individuals will attain higher status, but primarily in task-focused context. So engineering—things in which there's a non-social context in which you have to meet a deadline or win a sports game. Conscientious athletes, conscientious workers in these kinds of non-social roles, they do tend to increase their status. Conscientiousness is associated with a small wage boost, one standard deviation, 7.2% wage boost, a small correlation between conscientiousness and income.
- 2.43** My guess, though, is that—I haven't seen any study specifically looking at this, but if you work in a non-social environment, it's actually going to be much higher, the correlation coefficient. If you're an engineer and you're high in conscientiousness versus when you're an engineer and you're low in conscientiousness, there's going to be a significant difference there. But this figure here, it's an aggregate snapshot figure across a wide variety of occupational fields. Then, yeah, high conscientiousness athletes are rated as higher prestige among their team members. But then if you look at non-task-oriented environments, you'll find that dormitories, fraternities, sororities—this is an older study, but they found that conscientious individuals were no more likely to attain status than others.
- 2.44** Emotional stability and status. Well, low emotional stability or high neuroticism, perhaps unsurprisingly, it predicts lower income. So again, this gets a bit confusing. I should have made it consistent. But if you're high in emotional stability, it predicts slightly higher increase in income. If you're high in neuroticism, you tend to be rated lower by your peers and your coworkers. Interestingly, neuroticism or low emotional stability seems to be more damaging to men's status relative to women.
- 2.45** Men high in neuroticism are less likely to be nominated as leaders and tend to hold lower status in college dormitories. Whereas for women, there's no link between their neuroticism scores and their likelihood of being nominated as leaders or their status in these social environments. It's as if people expect men to be relatively emotionally stable, and if they fail to meet that expectation, then they subsequently evaluate them to be a bit lower.
- 2.46** Openness and status. There's been weak and inconsistent evidence around this. I think, again, this is one of those personality traits that depends on the context. This aggregate overall snapshot statistic of 0.1, that's a small effect, very small. If you're a bit more open, or if you're a lot more open, you may receive a small increase in your earnings. But there's no link between openness and peer-rated influence. If you measure people's personality, and then you ask their peers to evaluate them in various ways in terms of how much respect and admiration you may have for this person, there's no link between how open they are and their peer-rated scores on that.
- 2.47** There was a study among women in occupational prestige, which found that among women at age 21, if they were high in openness, they were more likely to ascend in their careers by age 52. But that's just one study. Again, this is inconsistent, these

findings. My sense is that, if you're high in openness, again, it's helpful if you're working in a creative context or an artistic context, certain kinds of fields, it may be rewarding to be a highly open person. But in most jobs in which there's clear-cut expectations and standards, and there's not a lot of room for open-mindedness and creative thinking, openness just isn't going to help you very much in occupational domains.

2.48 The lack of link between openness and peer-rated influence, I'm not exactly sure what's going on there. That's an interesting one. It may be that once you're in a peer group already, you've already met a certain minimal threshold for how open that group is and having any more openness may not be especially advantageous.

2.49 So self-monitoring. So now we're moving on from the Big Five. Self-monitoring instead. So self-monitoring is a concept in social psychology. It's a trait that captures how sensitive and aware you are to other people's behavior and the way that they interact in a given context and how likely you are to use them as an example yourself. So if you're high in self-monitoring, you use it to guide your own presentation, how you come across to others. If you're low in self-monitoring, you behave the same in every single context. You're not looking at cues around you and responding based on that.

2.50 I use this—I think this is going to be the last Leonardo DiCaprio still I'll use. I don't know how many of you have seen Catch Me If You Can. It's a great movie. But it's based on a true story of this guy, Frank Abagnale, who successfully impersonated a doctor, a lawyer, and a pilot for a commercial airline. This guy was almost certainly high in self-monitoring. The movie depicts this. I'm sure there's some creative license going on here, but you see him watching these movies. You see him looking at the other pilots and carefully studying their behavior and then imitating them. He was able to pass and fool other people into thinking he was one of them.

2.51 Self monitoring, it seems to—a lot of the research on self-monitoring seems to have been done on MBA students, MBA graduates. There does seem to be some positive correlation. Higher self-monitoring is associated with higher levels of peer-rated influence, how high your peers evaluate you in terms of your social influence in project teams, higher status in MBA cohorts as well. People who are high in self-monitoring also are more likely to be promoted.

2.52 Now we'll talk about the Dark Triad, which I think at least one person asked about psychopathy. Maybe we'll get to some of your questions. The Dark Triad is a constellation of personality traits encompassing narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism. We'll walk through them, step by step. We'll start with narcissism. This is a term that I think a lot of people are familiar with. There's actually two types of narcissism. The Dark Triad only captures grandiose narcissism, but there's the second type, which we'll briefly go through that one as well.

2.53 These two types, grandiose and vulnerable, they share a core. They share the same basic traits of self-centeredness. They're superficial, shallow, antagonistic, hostile. They

think that they are more important than other people. But the way that it expresses themselves between the grandiose and the vulnerable narcissists are different. So, grandiose narcissist, low emotional distress, low in neuroticism. They tend to be extroverted. They're happy, they're thick-skinned, they're impervious to insults, they self-promote, brag, name drop. I call them a wolf in wolf's clothing because a grandiose narcissist, you can spot them immediately just by the way they dress, the way they act, the way that they talk. You can immediately spot a grandiose narcissist.

- 2.54** I think the distinction between these two is important because a lot of people think if someone is a braggart or speaks very highly of themselves—there's been this debate within psychology about, well, actually a narcissist deep down, deep down, they actually have low self-esteem and they're overcompensating something. Well, actually, more recent research indicates that these can be broken. There are some narcissists who are that way, but a grandiose narcissist is not. They actually really do feel good about themselves. If you insult them or denigrate them or belittle them, it doesn't really affect them. In their own mind, they really do think that they're better than everyone else.
- 2.55** But then there's, OK, so here's some sample items of grandiose narcissism. "Others' opinions of me are of little concern to me." So you ask participants these questions, and then they rate how strongly they agree. "I get lots of enjoyment from entertaining others." "Someday I believe that most people will know my name." "Others say I brag too much, but everything I say is true."
- 2.56** OK, so then there's vulnerable narcissism. Again, this trait is not captured in the Dark Triad. The Dark Triad captures grandiose narcissism, not vulnerable narcissism. But we'll cover it anyway, just because I think it's interesting and important. In some of the research and some of the literature in psychology, they call them covert or hidden or shy narcissists. They're high in neuroticism, prone to negative emotion, and they are hypersensitive to criticism. If you say something derogatory about them, it will stick with them, and they'll linger on it. Even if they don't openly express it, they will dwell on it. They tend to be envious, self-effacing. They often crave recognition, but then when they receive it, it's not what they thought it would be, or they're not satisfied with it. They think that maybe they didn't receive enough or that the way that it was expressed wasn't up to their standard.
- 2.57** They're prone to anger, to humiliated fury, narcissistic rage. Wolf in sheep's clothing, because often, vulnerable narcissists conceal this aspect of themselves. They don't loudly announce themselves the way that a grandiose narcissist would. Often, they're good at concealing this and not always openly expressing it. Some sample items. "I often feel as if I need compliments from others in order to be sure of myself." "It really makes me angry when I don't get what I deserve." "When I realize I failed at something, I feel humiliated." "I often interpret the remarks of others in a personal way."

- 2.58** Also interesting is that, perhaps unsurprisingly, grandiose narcissists—males score higher on grandiose narcissism than females. For vulnerable narcissism, there's no sex difference between men and women in vulnerable narcissism.
- 2.59** OK, so psychopathy. This is the second trait in the Dark Triad. This is callousness, disregard for others. People who are high in psychopathy engage in constant social comparison, evaluating themselves in a relation to other people. They tend to be less happy. Hervey Cleckley wrote a book called *The Mask of Sanity* in the 1940s. He basically said that he started to meet these people in his clinical practice, and he would find that a lot of these people, on the surface, appeared very normal. Then he would start to talk about their personal lives and their interests and their habits and discover that these were very odd, very unusual people who had very little sympathy for others and were preoccupied with getting ahead and seemed unconcerned, had a lack of remorse, this poverty of emotion. They didn't really experience much in the way of their inner lives.
- 2.60** Another hallmark of psychopathy is low impulse control or low conscientiousness. They also are preoccupied. Narcissists as well, are preoccupied with creating an attractive veneer. They're very interested in bolstering their appearance and looking as good as possible. The psychopathy sample items. "I like to pick on losers." "People who mess with me always regret it." "I sometimes get into dangerous situations." "I like to get revenge on authorities."
- 2.61** Then there's Machiavellianism. There's Logan Roy. I don't know how many of you watched the *Succession* finale, but that was so good. It was so good. So Logan Roy would probably score high on Machiavellianism, which is strategic exploitation and duplicity. They are cynical, suspicious of others' motives. They tend to have a hidden agenda themselves and expect that other people have these hidden motives as well. Logan in *Succession*, he'll often ask, "What's your angle?" He always thinks that people are up to something, that they're after something. There's always the superficial thing that they're ostensibly asking, but what they're really after is something else, angling and so on.
- 2.62** So, yeah, shallow affect, relatively low ability to experience joy. There's some research. It seems to be inconsistent that Machiavellianism is associated with depressive symptoms and anxiety, anhedonia. A recent study also found that they're quick to make last-minute cancellations for better opportunities. I think of the three dark traits, it was only Machiavellianism that predicted this. But interestingly, so Machiavellianism—one thing that distinguishes it from psychopathy is that people high on this trait tend to have high impulse control. They're actually pretty good at keeping their emotions in check and not acting out without thinking through what they're doing. They're careful about their behavior.

- 2.63** Some sample items. "I like to use clever manipulation to get my way." "It's wise to keep track of information that you can use against people later." "You should wait for the right time to get back at people." "It's not wise to tell your secrets."
- 2.64** OK, so Dark Triad and status pursuit. I think a lot of people would say, "Oh, these traits, they probably do predict status attainment." People who are calculating and conniving and scheming. Well, is it true? Well, at least when you compare the Big Five with the Dark Triad personality traits, the Dark Triad trait has the strongest correlation with what's called disagreeableness, to keep it easy. So the more disagreeable you are, the more likely you are to score highly on psychopathy, Machiavellianism, and narcissism. These are strikingly high correlations. If you're high on disagreeableness, we learned earlier that it does have some predictive power for earnings and income and so on. And so this does suggest maybe, maybe there's some link.
- 2.65** Let's look more at it. We'll look at narcissism first. Remember, this is grandiose narcissism in the Dark Triad. Narcissists are very interested in attaining status, unsurprisingly, but they don't always get it. Narcissism and income, there's a relatively small correlation. In narcissists, they, on average, tend to earn a bit more, but not that much more. In the aggregate, there does seem to be this inconsistent link. What seems to happen is, if you compare across a representative sample of the population, measure status attainment of narcissism, there's not a lot going on there. But then if you look specifically at people who have achieved outsized recognition and achievement and accomplishment and so on, they tend to be higher in narcissism than the average.
- 2.66** Narcissism can be beneficial, but only in situations where you have other traits along with it. One way to think about it, there's this conditional probability. Most tall people don't play basketball, but most basketball players are tall. Most narcissists don't attain high status, but most high status people are probably a bit higher than average on narcissism. Why is that? Why is there that inconsistent link overall between narcissism and status attainment?
- 2.67** Research suggests that narcissists tend to make a really good first impression, and then people's evaluations of them rapidly decline as they get to know them. Strangers seem to like narcissists. If you present people with, "Hey, look at this narcissist, what do you think?" and so on, people seem to evaluate them pretty highly. But then over time, gradually, their evaluations decline. In his book, *The New Science of Narcissism*, Keith Campbell proposed this—I don't know if it was his original idea or if he was reporting on someone else's, but he talks about the chocolate cake model. And the idea here is that it's good at first until it makes you sick. Like, chocolate cake tastes really, it looks great, it tastes great, and then you keep eating it, and then suddenly you want to throw up.
- 2.68** This is an analogy here to be drawn with narcissists, where at first they're really fun to be around. They're really exciting. They're often good at making you feel good about

yourself, too. They can determine what you like about yourself, compliment you on it. They're really good at these. But then, gradually, they start to become overbearing or start to try to exploit you. Narcissists often have to move on to different circumstances, different situations, or regularly update their social circle and keep moving along.

- 2.69** Psychopathy. Psychopathy and status. Psychopathy is associated with higher levels of status-driven risk-taking, similar to narcissism. Status-driven risk-taking, here's a sample item. "I would enjoy being a famous and powerful person, even if it meant a high risk of assassination." People high in psychopathy are more likely to strongly agree with that kind of a statement. Among the Dark Triad, status-driven risk-taking has the strongest link with—yeah, status-driven risk-taking in psychopathy, strongest link there. That's pretty striking, 0.53. But status-driven risk-taking is also associated with Machiavellianism and narcissism as well.
- 2.70** People high in the Dark Triad are really interested in status. They're willing to take risks for it. But as we have seen and will continue to see, the links are tenuous at best. Psychopathy is not a predictor of income or occupational prestige. They really want status, they seldom attain it. Then, again, I think that the basketball analogy might be helpful here, where generally people who score highly in psychopathy are not going to attain high status. But then among high status people, they probably have a bit of this in them, a bit of psychopathy, subclinical, moderate doses of it.
- 2.71** The prevalence of psychopaths, like actual clinical psychopaths, in the general population, have been estimated in the general population to be about 1-3%. Estimates vary depending on the scale used in the population test. It's about 1-3%. What's interesting, though, is that Robert Hare, one of the foremost experts on psychopathy, he and some others have developed this idea of organizational psychopaths, or corporate psychopaths. And some researchers have found that about 13% of executives and managers, advertising workers, people in these white-collar occupations, 13% would qualify as having clinical psychopathy.
- 2.72** Prison inmates, it's 20%. I've seen other estimates that are as high as 30% among inmates. So among executives, it's not as high as the prison population, but it is strikingly high relative to the general population. Also interesting is students. College students, 8%. That's about 4 times higher than the average. Some of that may be due to age, but I also think that anywhere where status can be attained, it's just naturally going to be an appealing environment for psychopathically oriented people.
- 2.73** OK, so Machiavellianism and status. There's a small link with income and with leadership as well. Machiavellianism. Again, this is strategic exploitation, people who think things through, high impulse control. I think one of the reasons why psychopaths don't tend to, on the average, achieve income or occupational prestige is because they tend to be low in impulse control. This is why prisons are filled with psychopaths. But if you have high impulse control and you have psychopathic traits or Machiavellian-type

of traits, that alongside high impulse control can actually be a very useful combination for certain kinds of success.

- 2.74** There was an interesting study that suggested that intelligence might be what's called a moderator, basically. For Machiavellianism—I think this may be true for the other traits as well, especially for psychopathy—if you're high in Machiavellianism, and you're high in intelligence, then that's linked to higher earnings. But if you're high in Machiavellianism and low in intelligence, that actually predicts lower earnings. This may be because, if you're a scheming person, but you don't have the intellect and competence to pull it off, you may spoil your ambitions. You'll get caught out or you sort of fumble along the way, and then you'll fall down the ladder or fail your goals. It seems like intelligence is a booster. It facilitates it; it helps it. I think this may be the case for psychopathy as well, maybe narcissism to some extent.
- 2.75** I think for autism as well. I think a lot of people, when they watch movies or something, Rain Man, they think that autistic people, they think of these savants. But actually, on the average, people with autism have lower than average intelligence. But if you have autistic traits and you are high in intelligence, high IQ scores, then those two things together, those autistic traits along with high intelligence, can actually be incredibly useful in certain kinds of tasks and contexts.
- 2.76** OK, so yeah, the overall picture here. Psychopathy seems to be either null effect or detrimental effect for status attainment, likely due to problems with impulse control. Machiavellianism might be beneficial. Grandiose narcissism, probably helpful in small to moderate amounts. But ultimately, the reason why there's been this inconsistent link and why, in the aggregate, it doesn't actually seem to do as you might think, people generally don't like bullies. They don't like manipulation. They don't like cruelty.
- 2.77** Of the three traits, it seems that narcissism, grandiose narcissism, is actually the trait that is the most predictive of status attainment. That may be because narcissists are more prestige-oriented. They actually don't seem to derive that much pleasure from dominating other people. They actually like the admiration in the status, which is more associated with that other avenue of status attainment. Whereas psychopaths and Machiavellians, they actually, to some extent, enjoy—they derive some degree of pleasure duping people or getting one over on others. This may be, again, linked to self-domestication, why over time we've become generally more cooperative and docile.
- 2.78** I've mentioned narcissism may be more prestige-oriented. Narcissistically oriented people, they want to get along and get ahead. They want high levels of achievement and success and so on, but they also want to be well-liked as well. And so this may be why a bit of narcissism may be useful, at least in the attainment of status and, to some degree, in belonging as well.
- 2.79** I should note here, though, that when I talk about the Dark Triad—psychopathy and narcissism, specifically—the Dark Triad scales aren't meant to capture clinical levels of

narcissism and psychopathy, like actual diagnosable psychopaths or narcissists. The Dark Triad, these scales were designed to be used on the general population. What this means is that all of us, to some degree—very few of us would score zero on a Dark Triad scale. All of us have a bit of this within us. The scales are designed for this very purpose, to follow along a normal distribution. Most of us will have some degree of narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism within us. However, if you score, if you're in the top 1% of the psychopathy scale in the Dark Triad, there's probably a pretty good chance that you'd qualify for a clinical diagnosis for an actual antisocial personality disorder.

- 2.80** OK, so why would narcissism be more predictive of status than the other traits? I mentioned the hierometer from the earlier lecture. The hierometer guides and monitors our status relative to others. It suggests that narcissism is this psychological mechanism that's designed to get us to pursue status. What is this? Yeah, low on the dial, helpful, but people detest domineering types. Basically, having, so low or maybe moderate levels of narcissism can push or facilitate you to attain status. But if you have very high levels to the point where your grandiosity becomes obnoxious, then often people won't want to be around you for long.
- 2.81** OK, so age and status. When it comes to measurements of income, occupational prestige, assets, earnings, wealth, and so on, it's unsurprising older people have higher status in that regard, which is because they've had more time to build up their careers and accrue resources and wealth. But in terms of interest in status, in terms of status pursuit, young people are higher. Young adults really want status, perhaps because they don't have it. Relative to older people, once you have it and you're established, maybe your interests start to shift. But when you're young, it becomes a very important preoccupation because of its relevance for reproductive success. This shift, this interest in status when young and then its decline with age, these seem to be associated with changes across the personality or across the life span. So agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability rise, and your level of openness tends to decline with time.
- 2.82** So the Dark Triad traits and age. So your Dark Triad traits are actually highest in your late teen years and in your 20s. This is when, basically, the general population, they peak in all of these traits, gradually decline. You can see this in other studies as well. The ability to form believable lies peaks in your teens and 20s. A friend of mine, an evolutionary psychologist, suggests that this is because that's the age when you're the most interested in attracting and attaining a romantic partner. It's good to use a bit of guile, maybe a bit of deception. Not that it's morally good, but in terms of finding a partner.
- 2.83** Age crime curve. The propensity to commit crimes clusters around age 19. This is for men and women. Of course, men commit far more crimes than women, but this is when it peaks. So these two, the ability to deceive, the willingness to break the law,

these kinds of things, they coincide with our Dark Triad traits being at their peak during these years. Then they tend to gradually decline. There's also this idea in evolutionary psychology called the young male syndrome, which is basically that when you're young, when you're a young male in particular, regardless of time and place, whatever culture, context, historical period, it's like men in their teens and 20s who commit the vast majority of the crimes.

2.84 Basically, the researchers have proposed that there's this burnout effect that occurs over time, such that many of these men, as they grow older, they actually become less interested in crime and committing crime. The burnout idea is interesting. Nancy McWilliams, who I cite here, she has suggested that this may be actually due to physical changes, that when you're young and strong and healthy and robust, you can put yourself in dangerous situations. You can deceive people and potentially anger them, which may create a harmful situation for you. You can commit crimes; you can have interactions with law enforcement. You can do all these things when you're young and robust and full of life and energy. Then once you start to get backache in the morning and if you get a few gray hairs on your head, maybe it's not so wise to put yourself in potentially dangerous situations. And so the biological underpinnings of the Dark Triad traits tend to diminish and people become generally less interested in harmful and risky behaviors.

2.85 OK. Yeah, I've talked about burnout. Small amounts may be adaptive. A small amount of Dark Triad may be adaptive for winning social allies, winning friends, attaining prestige, success, and so on. A bit of overconfidence as well. Having a bit of overconfidence can lead you to work on things and to win the confidence of other people. Older adults, as they become more established in their careers and more settled, they also just become, I think, less consumed by ambition. All of these things—the biology, the individual -level psychology, the cultural context—all of these things are intertwined.

2.86 Older people, on the one hand, you could say, "Older people are less interested in status because they're more mature, they're wiser, they're more worldly, they have a greater breadth of perspective." Or you could say, "Well, it's biological. It's because they're older, they're more vulnerable, more at risk, they can't afford to be in dangerous situations." All of these things are probably intertwined that, as your biology changes, it affects your psychology, which affects your self concept. All of these things are intertwined. These aren't mutually exclusive. And so, as we—we're winding down here.

2.87 I wanted to touch on the Light Triad as well. This is a recent concept developed by Scott Barry Kaufman and his colleagues. This isn't the opposite of the Dark Triad. These are not completely inversely correlated. If you score very high on the Dark Triad, that doesn't mean you would score zero on the Light Triad. If you score very high on the Light Triad, that doesn't mean you have zero Dark Triad scores. These scale are

designed so that, again, all of us have a bit the Dark Triad, but all of us have a bit of the Light Triad in us as well. We follow along this normal distribution.

- 2.88** What's the Light Triad? Humanism, Kantianism, and faith in humanity. Humanism, appreciation of the successes and creations of others. Kantianism, which I think, I listened to this interview with Scott, and he said it's meant to be like the mirror image or whatever of Machiavellianism, this inspired by the thoughts of the philosopher Emmanuel Kant. A tendency toward behaving with integrity and honesty, rather than deceit and charm. And faith in humanity, believing that people are generally good and worthy of trust. That's the Light Triad.
- 2.89** It's motivated more by affiliation and intimacy than by power. It's more motivated by communion, rather than agency. It's more about getting along than getting ahead. The Light Triad is inversely correlated with age. I don't think that's on here, but older adults score higher on the Light Triad, younger adults score or lower. So stronger Light Triad scores—there's a stronger relationship between the Light Triad and self-esteem than with the Dark Triad.
- 2.90** How you feel about yourself? What's interesting here is that the Dark Triad also predicts high self-esteem as well. If you score high on the Dark Triad, you tend to feel a bit better about yourself. But if you score high on the Light Triad, the effect is even more pronounced that you feel better. Then Light Triad predicts self-awareness, whereas the Dark Triad actually, it either has null effects or negative effects with self-awareness. Often, if you're deceitful and exploitative, it's uncomfortable to dwell on those thoughts. And so lot of people high in the Dark Triad, there's not a lot of inner self-awareness and self-reflection going on. Whereas people are on the Light Triad where you're—when you're high on these kinds of traits, naturally, maybe you'll be a bit more self-aware about what you do and how you treat people.
- 2.91** Then, relative to narcissism, Light Triad is an equally strong predictor of higher income. So a small, small to moderate correlation there. Actually, it's small R. The correlation coefficient is 0.1. OK, so I'll finish. I'll close this off with a quote from Robert Greene, who's written a lot of books, probably most well known for *The 48 Laws of Power*. He says, "Those who love this Machiavellian part of our nature and revel in it can get pretty far, but they are eventually tripped up. They don't understand that there's a whole other side of the game which requires empathy and cooperation."
- 2.92** And this is right. If you are completely preoccupied with status at the expense of your relationships, at the expense of getting along with other people, this will often backfire. I mentioned earlier that people who are in prominent high status positions, they may score higher than average on the Dark Triad traits, but they also tend to be pretty good at managing relationships, getting along with others, and not burning bridges. If you burn all your bridges, you're just not going to get very far.

Lecture 3: Status Evolution

At a glance — Status evolution — sex and status.

- 3.1** So today, we'll be talking about sex and status. We've covered a lot of ground discussing what status is. We've talked about individual differences in the propensity to seek and attain status. But there's a question about why we care so much about status. What is the ultimate evolutionary reason why this invisible resource holds so much appeal to us? We've touched on this a bit, but today we're really going to delve deeply into it.
- 3.2** The core reason is that in the ancestral environment, early humans, status was directly tied to evolutionary fitness. Status increased our ancestors' likelihood of obtaining access to critical resources, securing social allies and friends, attracting romantic partners, and ultimately, the real currency of evolution is offspring. People who learn about evolution sometimes get a little too hung up on sex and attracting romantic partners, as if that's the ultimate goal of our evolutionary imperative, is to just hook up with the hottest person or as many people as possible. That's actually not the purpose of the evolution of what drives us to carry our genes forward. It's actually, it's actually offspring. That's what evolution wants, so to speak. And sex is just a means to an end. A lot of people confuse the process with the goal.
- 3.3** And just to clarify, evolution and genes aren't conscious entities. They don't want anything, but we speak in this way metaphorically just to help us get an intuitive sense of evolution. We speak in terms of intentions and desires and goals because humans are social cognitive creatures. This is the way that things click for us when we think about how these processes unfold. In any case, the point is that status does lead to increased romantic appeal, but sex is just the means to an end, biologically speaking. The aim for our genes is to have offspring. Sex is the way to get there.
- 3.4** Our ancestors who had a strong desire to attain status left more children behind than those who did not. We're their descendants. We inherited this desire for admiration and respect and and so on. It's possible that there were humans many thousands of years ago who had no interest in status, no interest in romantic partners. Their genes were not carried forward, and those are not our ancestors. We'll start here with this quote as we get into a bit of the evolutionary psychology of sex and status.
- 3.5** This is a quote from the psychologist and philosopher William James. William James says, "To the psychologist alone, can such questions occur as, 'Why do we smile when pleased and not scowl?' 'Why are we unable to talk to a crowd as we talk to a single friend?' 'Why does a particular maiden turn our wits upside down?' The common man can only say, 'Of course we smile.' 'Of course our heart palpitates at the sight of the crowd.' 'Of course, we love the maiden.' And so probably does each animal feel about the particular things it tends to do in the presence of certain objects. To the lion, it is

the lioness, which is made to be loved. To the bear, the she-bear. To the broody hen, the would probably seem monstrous that there should be a creature in the world to whom a nest full of eggs was not utterly fascinating and precious and never to be too much sat upon object, which it is to her."

- 3.6** So what he's saying here is there are phenomena in the world that we think of as natural. If you say, "Why do we smile when we're happy?", to a lot of people, this is a silly question. It's like, well, you smile because you're happy, and that's just how things are. But for evolutionary psychologists, the question is about, why is that specific expression a link to happiness? What does it communicate? Why did it evolve? What adaptive significance does it hold? Same for why does a maiden turn our wits upside down? Why do we get nervous around romantic partners? What is the reason behind this? The idea here is to not just take things as a given, but really try to look at the mechanics and the roots of where these things come from.
- 3.7** As we move forward, it's important to make this distinction between proximate and ultimate causes. This is an important distinction in evolutionary psychology. If I ask you, "Why did you eat that cronut?", the proximate reason is, "Because I was hungry, because it tastes good." But the ultimate reason is because we need calories to survive. You need energy. The cronut is a delicious and dense source of energy. Then why do we like sweet things? The proximate reason is just "they taste good," but the ultimate reason is because sugar contains a lot of calories, a lot of energy, and so on.
- 3.8** So the proximate reason is more about the why. "Why did you eat that?" "I was hungry." The ultimate is more about the how. In terms of evolution, how did that behavior, well, how and why, but specifically the how. How did this behavior arise in the first place? What is its adaptive significance? And so keep this distinction in mind. When you say, "Why do parents love their children?", don't just say, "Because they're lovable." Many of them are not. Just kidding.
- 3.9** The reason here is because, in the evolutionary sense, the ultimate sense is that parents love their children because they have these genes, carry forward, care for your offspring, nurture them, and so on. But the proximate reason is just it's a natural feeling. You could speak about chemicals, you can speak about oxytocin, and so on. But in terms of this phenomenological experience of a parent caring for his or her child, this is the most natural thing in the world. They're not thinking in terms of evolution. They're not thinking in terms of ultimate causes. So proximate versus ultimate. Let's just keep that in mind as we go forward.
- 3.10** I talked in one of the previous lectures about spiders building this web. They don't actually know what this web is. They don't have an internal model or representation. They're simply following their instincts, and then the outcome is, "Oh, there's a web," and then they go forward from there to use it to capture prey, and so on. Basically, it's just important to keep in mind that often a lot of our behavior is not—when we talk

about evolutionary reasons, these are not verbalized, explicit ideas in our mind as we're acting. A lot of this is just impulsive, intrinsic.

- 3.11 OK, so sex differences in status pursuit. We talked in a previous lecture about how status is universal. There are differences in them. There are some interesting differences between men and women. They're both motivated to attain status. Everyone seems to want it. We talked about how men wanted power more than women did. But status, although both men and women desire it, it's accorded in different ways. There are different kinds of, there are different arenas of status between the sexes on average. But before we get to the differences, we should talk a bit about the commonalities. These are cross-cultural universal findings from modern developed countries, as well as in small-scale hunter-gatherer communities.
- 3.12 These are the things that confer status to both men and women—being in good health, having strong alliances with your family, with your friends, being a trustworthy person, having strong moral character, being generous, being willing to share your possessions and resources, and not being selfish, and then knowing a lot of things, especially knowledge that is relevant to survival or to helping others to get along or get ahead.
- 3.13 OK, status competition for mates. Well, a lot of the arenas of status are about, in an evolutionary sense, attempting to attract a romantic partner. The reason why this competition exists in the first place is because not everyone is equally kind, intelligent, healthy, ambitious, resourceful. Not everyone is equally attractive, empathic, generous. Not all of us are equal on all of these desirable qualities. And thus a competition arises where there's a simultaneous mutual mate selection process where people are both trying to find someone that they would like to be with, while simultaneously trying to be the person that others would want to choose to be with. Yeah, generally people want to stand out in at least some of these dimensions to be selected, while also trying to find someone who has those qualities as well.
- 3.14 Here's a quote from my friend and the great evolutionary psychologist, David Buss, who says, "The mating preferences of one sex set the ground rules of competition in the opposite sex." What does this mean? Essentially, whatever one sex desires, the other one will try to meet those desires, will try to fulfill whatever the goals are, to advertise those qualities about themselves. So men compete with one another. There's some interesting difference here as the logic of sex differences. Men compete with one another, on average, right? We're talking specifically about average differences in heterosexual men and women, especially young people who are in that stage of life when their desire to find a mate is the strongest.
- 3.15 So men compete with one another to appeal to lots of women, and women compete, generally speaking, to be chosen by high quality men. We'll get into the biological reasons why that is here in a few. The women are choosier, which we'll get into, but women are still competitive because, again, high quality men tend to be choosy themselves, and so they're competing for that group of desirable men. So there's this

mutual mate choice, men choose women, women choose men. But the way that this plays out is different based on preferences and the arenas of competition differ based on sex.

- 3.16** So to begin, we'll talk a bit about why there are these differences and how they arise. Men are more willing than women to accept invitation for casual sex from an opposite-sex stranger. This is like a classic study. The reference I have there, this is a recent one. There was a classic study from the 1980s that originally found this, where they basically asked—these researchers paid hired actors, attractive young actors, to go around this college campus, this was in the 1980s, and go up to students on the campus and say, they asked three different—so there were three different questions, three conditions. They didn't ask the same student these three questions all at once, but they went around and asked these three questions to various people, one question at a time per person.
- 3.17** The questions were, "Would you like to go on a date? Would you come back to my apartment with me? And would you like to go to bed with me?" That was all they said. I think they might have introduced with a name and then followed up with that question. It was some small number of women were willing to go on the date. It was an attractive actor, so some small number of women said yes to the date. Zero said yes to going to the apartment, and zero said yes to going to bed. I don't think anyone's surprised by that. Then for men, it was some astonishingly high, like the vast majority said yes to going on the date. Then the vast majority also said yes to going back to the apartment, and the vast majority said yes to going to bed with this stranger.
- 3.18** And it was funny. This is an interesting bit of trivia, is that the researchers note in the paper that, of the men who declined, they were apologetic or remorseful, like, "Sorry, I have a girlfriend. I don't think I can do this." Or like, "Oh, my fiancé is in town. I don't think—" They would apologize. There was this expression of regret. This aligns with some other interesting research as well, regarding what —when you ask men and women about their regrets, specifically about sexual regrets, women tend to regret more acts of commission. On average, they're more likely to regret the things that they have done in their sexual history. "I wish I didn't sleep with this guy or that guy," whatever. "I wish I hadn't done that."
- 3.19** For men, it's the reverse. Men are far more likely to regret sexual omission. "I wish I had slept with someone. I wish I could have gotten with her. I had that chance and I'd —" You know, like that. There's this asymmetry here, and we'll talk about why this is in terms of the risks that each sex carries when they enter a sexual encounter. But there was a more recent study, replicated the original finding. Men are more willing to accept an invitation of casual sex from an opposite-sex stranger.
- 3.20** But then they asked about celebrities, and this was a study from 2011. The male celebrities, I guess these are still, whatever, these are still popular today. They're like Brad Pitt, Johnny Depp. I think in 2011, they're getting old now. They're still good-

looking. So then once they introduced celebrities as an option, like, "Imagine you have a chance to sleep with Johnny Depp or something," then women were equally likely to sleep with this stranger as men were. And men were no more likely to say yes or no to an attractive female celebrity versus just an attractive female normal person, ordinary person.

- 3.21** Why is this the case? I think status, of course, has something to do with this. Johnny Depp or Brad Pitt, these are ultra-high status guys. But I think there's an element of familiarity here as well, a feeling of intimacy. Celebrities are strange. It's a strange category. There's this parasocial relationship where you feel like you know them. You watch a lot of their movies. You have this comfort with them. Maybe you watch their interviews or something. You don't really know them, but you feel like you do. There's a comedian, Adam Carolla, who suggested that the reason why women are willing to sleep with celebrities is basically because they feel like they know them. On a weird psychological level, on a parasocial level, they don't feel like they're strangers. And so I think that feeling of intimacy plays a role here as well.
- 3.22** More on this, this theme of differences in sexual desires and behaviors. On Tinder, men like more than 60% of female profiles, and women like only 4.5% of the male profiles. It's not just Tinder. Tinder is seen, I think, as like, that's the hookup app. It's this unserious app that people who are interested in casual sex go on. But then on Hinge, which, at least last I heard, it is supposed to be the more serious app that people use for dating, for something more serious. But even here, only 10% of men receive about 60% of the likes. There is this massive asymmetry. I said before that women try to—men try to be attractive to lots of women. They're trying to maximize their chances of finding any woman that would sleep with them. Then women are more selective. They want to select and be chosen by a highly desirable male who matches a lot of those qualities that we discussed earlier—ambition, generosity, and so on.
- 3.23** Why do men compete so strongly for status? We'll start with men, then we'll go to women. Parental investment theory is an idea that was developed by the evolutionary biologist Robert Trivers, in the 1970s. The idea here, Trivers proposed, is that the sex that invests more in the offspring will be choosier because they carry greater risk. And so who carries greater risk? Women do. I've drawn this analogy to joint bank accounts. Imagine that you have to open a joint bank account, and the bank requires one person. The bank requires two people to open the joint bank account, and they require that one person invests a million dollars, and they require that the other person invests one dollar. And this is the only way that this bank account can be opened. So who's going to be choosier in terms of who they will open this bank account with? The person who has to invest a million dollars, or the person who only has to invest one dollar?
- 3.24** Well, as this plays out in the biological realm between men and women, men are investing only one dollar, so to speak, whereas women are investing a million. There's an increased cost of contracting an infection or an illness, but then also the costs of

pregnancy, the costs of child rearing, all of these things, the physiological cost, the caloric cost of having to find sources of energy, and especially in the ancestral environment, the burden of pregnancy was severe, and thus women were choosier. So whoever invests more resources essentially gets to call the shots. The person investing a million dollars is going to be more selective, more carefully scrutinizing of the other partner who's investing far less. And so, yes, the intensity of the mate selection and the level of scrutinizing from women is intense due to this difference in parental investment.

- 3.25** Why do men compete for status? Well, higher status men—and this is true not only in modern developed societies, but also in hunter-gatherer societies as well. More sexual partners, more extra-marital affairs, more overall offspring, more surviving offspring. Again, remember the proximate-ultimate distinction. There's not necessarily a direct tie that men are thinking, "Oh, if I attain a lot of status, then I'm going to have more surviving offspring." That's not the thought process that goes on. At most, for a young guy, they might think something like, "Oh, if I do this thing, then girls will like me." That may be as far as it goes in terms of what's actually going on in their mind. But the evolutionary process of partners, offspring surviving, that's not really what's going on here. But that's how it plays out in an evolutionary sense.
- 3.26** Women's preferences set the ground rules. Recalling that quote from David Buss, what do women want in men? They want commitment, usually expressed in the form of love and kindness. They want a man who has economic resources and a high level of occupational prestige. Again, these are averages, but indicating ambition and status. They want resources, both to take care of themselves and then for potential offspring. Physical strength for protection, especially you could imagine, in a small-scale hunter-gatherer society, the importance of protection, both from other humans, but then from predators as well.
- 3.27** Also care and provisioning during pregnancy. Women are already generally more vulnerable than men are, but when they're pregnant, even more so. It's important for them to choose a partner who will be around for them where there's periods of vulnerability. Then, yeah, physical attractiveness. They want someone who they can have a child with, and then the child will be attractive as well and be able to find a partner and so on.
- 3.28** I thought we would talk a bit about what the qualities that women favor in men are through one of my favorite movies. During the grand introduction of Aladdin, who the genie disguises as Prince Ali, there's this song that the genie opens with, as Prince Ali is being introduced to Jasmine and her father, the Sultan. Look at this. "Genuflect, show some respect, down on one knee." This is what the genie says about Prince Ali. This is status. Look at this high status guy, on top of this giant elephant, with his world-class menagerie of exotic-type mammals. He's rich, he's high status. These are the qualities that women generally favor in men.

- 3.29** There was a recent study showing that a man at the top of the earnings distribution has a 90% chance of finding a partner, and for men at the bottom, it is less than 40%. Interestingly, prosperous women are actually more likely to prefer ambitious and accomplished men. You might think that the reason why women want a highly accomplished man is because maybe they want the material resources. If they're lacking material resources, then of course, naturally, they're going to want someone who's a bit more high status. But if women are also materially comfortable, if they're affluent, if they're very successful, then they'll lower their standards in terms of those qualities. They already have enough in the way of material resources. They're already successful. Maybe you would think they don't need someone like that. It turns out successful women are actually more likely to want a highly successful man, someone who's equal to or above themselves in terms of occupational prestige and marriage and so on.
- 3.30** There's some interesting things going on right now with education where, as more women are attending college compared to men, I think either now or within the next few years, 60% of college graduates are going to be female, and more and more men are dropping out of higher education, that we're starting to slowly see what's called educational hypergamy, where historically men have had a bit more education than their wives. That now, some women are marrying men who have less education than themselves.
- 3.31** But in terms of earnings, they still generally tend to marry men who earn more than themselves. Maybe they'll marry someone who works a blue-collar job but still earns more than themselves. You can imagine a school teacher marrying an electrician or something like that, that although the electrician doesn't have a bachelor's degree, they still tend to earn more than the school teachers on average. Women are still interested primarily in the resource aspect rather than the educational credential.
- 3.32** What else? "Strong as 10 regular men," definitely describing Aladdin's physique, his strength, his formidability. He shoots his magical finger and momentarily puffs up Aladdin's muscles to show Jasmine and her father that this is a worthy suitor. Evidence suggests that this was on the mark. Muscle mass is associated with greater attractiveness, more sexual partners. The rated strength of a male body accounts for 70% of the variance in attractiveness. Again, if you're comparing two men and deciding which one is more attractive than the other, muscularity is primarily what accounts for the difference in attractiveness. These were studies primarily asking women about rating male bodies.
- 3.33** To me, the most interesting study along this line is about how formidability seems to be a stronger predictor of numerical sexual success or number of sexual partners. Formidability is stronger than attractiveness. This was an interesting study, which was, they basically had—these researchers filmed young men, brief video clips of these young men, and then they asked a group of women to watch these video clips, and

they asked them, essentially, "How sexually attractive is this man in this video?" It was a scale, I think, from 1 to 7, like very unattractive, very attractive.

- 3.34** Then they had a group of men come in and watch the men in these videos. So these men watched the videos, and then the researchers asked them, "How likely is it that this man in this video would win a physical fight with another man?" And it was rated from extremely unlikely to extremely likely. And then the researchers tracked the men that they filmed in these videos and had them return 18 months later and asked them about their sexual history over the previous year and a half. And what they found is that attractiveness, as rated by women, had no statistical relationship for the number of women that these men slept with, but formidability did. Formidability was a stronger predictor. How tough a guy looked was more important than how attractive they were in terms of predicting how many women that they had slept with.
- 3.35** There's so much interesting work on this, though. There's an evolutionary researcher, David Puts. He suggested that a lot of men's secondary sexual characteristics evolved not necessarily to attract women, but rather to compete against other men. I mean, ultimately the goal is to obtain mates and have children and so on. But he drew this analogy, basically suggesting that a lot of our secondary sex characteristics—deep voices, large muscles, beards—he found these inconsistencies where he would ask women, "How attractive are beards?" The data are messy, where some women like beards, some women don't. Sometimes it depends. Women do tend to like muscularity. They do tend to like deep voices. But then when you ask men to evaluate a man with a beard versus a man without, and ask, "How intimidating is this man?", or deep voices, "How intimidating are the deep voices?", the effect size is striking.
- 3.36** Steve Stewart-Williams, another evolutionary psychologist, suggested that these sex characteristics are more like deer's antlers than peacocks' tails. The peacock tail evolved to be attractive. The whole point is to attract peahens. Whereas the deer's antlers, they're not really intended to attract doe. Is that right? Female deer? But rather, they're intended to battle against other deer, vanquish them, and then subsequently mate with a female deer. So this is why there's that interesting asymmetry there, where women do like muscles and these kinds of things. But the purpose, these researchers suggest, is actually more so for intrasexual competition—men trying to intimidate and get other men to back down.
- 3.37** OK. Then finally, we'll conclude this slide with the handgrip strength finding. Men's handgrip strength is surprisingly highly correlated with happiness, health, confidence, and number of sexual partners. It really seems like muscularity and formidability, this is a powerful trait that leads to romantic success, and also just, it's sort of intrapsychic benefits as well—happiness and so on.
- 3.38** "He's got 99 white Persian monkeys, and to view them, he charges no fee. He's generous, so generous." This is Aladdin here throwing golden coins to the citizens of Agrabah. He's a generous guy. Then earlier in the movie, if you recall, he gave his bread

to the hungry children. He rescues Jasmine from having her hand chopped off when she gave some piece of food to one of the kids on the streets. Generosity is indeed also an attractive quality that women look for in men.

- 3.39** In fact, cross-culturally, there's a famous study, the 37 Culture Study from David Buss. He looked at 37 different cultures, not just Western cultures, but countries around the world, and asked people what they find most desirable in a partner. The number one, the most consistent trait that people ask for, men and women, what do they want? They want kindness. I think this surprises people because we sort of take kindness for granted. We expect—kindness is a baseline trait. Everyone's supposed to be kind. Why would that be something that is desirable or at the top of the list? But it really is.
- 3.40** If you see it on a list in front of you—that's the thing. These weren't just free association. They gave them a list. Here are some traits that you might find attractive. What do you want? And when they see kindness, oh, then it reminds them that you recognize, "Oh, kindness is really important, and that is the most desirable trait." Then there's some other interesting research suggesting men are more likely to donate to charity when they're observed by women, compared to when they're alone or compared with when they are being observed by men, suggesting that men on some level may be intuitively aware that being a kind and generous person is something that women find desirable.
- 3.41** There was a study showing that Medal of Honor recipients, veterans of World War II—the Medal of Honor is the highest military decoration one can receive—they had more children than other veterans who did not receive this medal, suggesting this is an indicator of altruism, of selflessness, of courage, bravery. There was a paper from Geoffrey Miller some years ago about sexual selection for moral virtues, and he suggested that—yesterday, we talked a bit about how a lot of our compliance, our docility, our willingness to cooperate, and so on, arose from the self-domestication process that Richard Wrangham has suggested, others have suggested.
- 3.42** Miller proposed that another avenue for why people tend to be calm and cooperative and kind and so on —and he suggested that this was mate selection, that generally people prefer to mate with people who weren't aggressive or hostile or coercive. Then this, too, contributed to the gradual domestication of humans as well. He suggested, Miller in his paper suggested, that things like generosity could be indicators of costly signaling. We'll walk through signaling a bit more later, but essentially, it's an indicator that "I'm so resourceful and so ambitious and so kind that I can actually incur costs to myself in order to show others how generous I am." That's the basic idea, which we'll talk about more.
- 3.43** Then handsomeness. We talked about this. Good-looking. Physical attractiveness, a cue for good health. There was a study a while back which asked—they showed women images of men and asked them to evaluate which men were the healthiest and which were the most attractive. There was no difference. These were indistinguishable. It

seems that, in this study, women used attractiveness as an index, a metric of health. So symmetrical faces, masculine faces—not too masculine; there's just sort of a sweet spot for masculinity that women tend to like in men. But again, men with very masculine faces often do have pronounced mating success, presumably because of that intimidation factor that other men see a very masculine face and potentially are just unwilling to mess with the person, or if they see that the guy with a super masculine face is interested in a woman, they're not going to interfere with—they're just unwilling to compete with him.

- 3.44 The "sexy son" hypothesis. This was discussed in various papers, and Richard Dawkins has suggested that, basically, one of the things that women look for in a partner is actually just attractiveness itself. Even if maybe a woman is not necessarily attracted to a man, if they see that other women are attracted to the man, they become more willing to potentially date or mate with that a man. David Buss has done some interesting work on this. The idea here is, if the man is seen by many people as attractive, then he has children, and that child grows up, then there's a good chance that that person will then subsequently be seen as attracted by many people.
- 3.45 David Buss, he's done some interesting work on this where he's basically shown images of men by themselves, with other men, and with a group of women. Then he has had women basically evaluate how attracted—it's the same guy, same guy, same clothes, but in different contexts. Women generally say that the man who's surrounded by women is more attractive than the same man who's attracted—the man who's surrounded by men or by himself. This gets at this preselection idea, the "sexy son" hypothesis maybe, that he's been preselected, that this man is seen by other women—I mean, if they're willing to be around him, then maybe there's something of interest there.
- 3.46 OK, so. By the way, that doesn't really seem to work for dating apps. I've seen research on this that, when men put a picture on Hinge or Tinder or something and they're surrounded by women, there's some evidence suggesting that this actually backfires, that it doesn't work in the—it might work in a lab context where you're looking and these are just pictures that someone happened to have chose. But if you know that this is a dating app, and this is the image that this person is choosing to present to you on a dating app, then women seem to be wary of that, or they think that the person is unserious. And often, those men get fewer matches, if they show images of themselves with lots of women versus when they're with their bros or by themselves.
- 3.47 "Tell her the truth." This is towards the end of the movie. We're no longer in the Prince Ali grand introduction. This is when Genie is like, "Look, you got to 'fess up. You're not really Prince Ali." And honesty is indeed strongly desired in romantic partners. So authenticity—this is a pretty recent study which found that authenticity in relationships, which—just some of the sample items. "I share my deepest thoughts with my partner, even if there's a chance he or she won't understand them." This is a

powerful predictor of relationship satisfaction. It's actually a stronger predictor than emotional intelligence. It seems that being honest, being authentic, is a stronger predictor of relationship satisfaction than emotional intelligence is.

- 3.48** This study also found, interestingly, that people who scored low on these traits tended to show a pronounced preference for dishonest women, so the male participants who scored low when they were asked about their mating preferences and so on. Dark Triad as well—they measured the Dark Triad traits. The Dark Triad traits were inversely correlated, meaning that if you scored highly on the Dark Triad traits, you tend to score low on authenticity. Those people who scored low on authenticity tend to favor partners who were also less than authentic or enjoy playing games in their relationships. So authenticity, all of these things.
- 3.49** So far, we've been talking about a variety of traits that men try to signal about themselves, or if you have a genie, he can signal them for you. So these are honest signals. Continuing on this theme of authenticity, these are honest signals of wealth, education, strength, and so on. This is why I think, this is why I think Genie wanted him to tell her the truth. This is ultimately the most important, is to be an honest and authentic person. It's not that women want the veneer of wealth and education. They want to know that you also have the underlying intrinsic properties that will predictably lead to those things.
- 3.50** It's like winning the lottery. Most women would prefer to mate with someone who earned their riches through hard work, developing trusted business partnerships, making good decisions, versus some guy who won the Powerball. Over here, lottery winner versus a junior doctor. A lot of women would prefer the junior doctor over the lottery winner, even if he's not nearly as materially wealthy, but because his career and his profession indicate something about him that is attractive.
- 3.51** Here we come to the three basic elements of signaling theory. We've been talking a bit about signaling, touching on it, but let's just sort of explicitly walk through it. What is signaling? There are three basic elements. People differ in their underlying attributes. I mentioned before, not everyone is equally generous, attractive, strong, kind, and so on. But these attributes are visibly unclear. At first glance, you don't necessarily know who has more money than someone else or who's kinder or has a stronger moral character than someone else, who's more educated or intelligent than someone else. These are not clear at first glance.
- 3.52** People differ in the strength emitted for these underlying attributes. People will subsequently attempt to signal these qualities about themselves, and then we can see the difference in the signaling underlying that—they're trying to signal the underlying attribute, and that gets at what you're trying to discern about that person. You're trying to figure out what is underlying that signal based on the strength emitted.

- 3.53** That gets us to the idea of honest or costly signals. An honest signal or a costly signal, it has to be difficult to emit. For a signal, there's such thing as cheap talk, where you say something about yourself, and that does count as a signal, but it's a cheap signal. Anyone could say it. Anyone could do it. But there are certain things that only someone who is especially capable would be able to accomplish it. Winning the lottery, in a sense, is a cheap signal. Anyone can buy some scratchers and win a lot of money. But becoming a doctor, a physician, becoming a surgeon—that is a costly signal because it indicates some level of competence, intelligence, hard work, ambition, and so on.
- 3.54** The costly signal idea. People are trying to signal their wealth, their education, professional accomplishments, all these kinds of things, lottery winner versus the junior doctor. On this idea of costly signals, I guess we'll get more into this point later. But this is something that is important to keep in mind as we go forward. Here are the—closing in on the arenas of competition for status among men—formidability, prestige, generosity, moral character, and then appearance, muscularity. I guess fashion, too. Fashion signals level of resources and economic success. We talked a bit about this, male secondary sex characteristics as antlers rather than peacocks' tails.
- 3.55** There are a lot of organized and ritualized contests to reveal certain properties about men. Some researchers have suggested that sporting competitions act as male lek. So lek is essentially a contest between males. For example, two deer or two animals who are butting heads in a competition with one another in the pursuit of trying to attract female partners. The idea here is that humans developed sporting contests, ritualized combat, essentially, whether you're wrestling, through sports, ways to demonstrate athleticism and physical prowess, both to—I mean, so to impress other males. But then through that collective, the collective esteem of the males, the victor is subsequently seen as more attractive to women.
- 3.56** For example, a lot of women actually don't watch sports that often, but a lot of highly accomplished athletes, they'll still have groupies. Women will still like them. A lot of the reason behind this, the logic is that these men, these highly accomplished athletes, are admired by other men. And so women outsource mate selection, this cognitively burdensome task. How do you tell which men are actually worthy? How do you tell which men actually have desirable traits? One way to do this is this preselection process of, well, which man is admired by his peers? Which man is accomplished in a ritualized contest that other men accept as legitimate and valid and worthy of praise directed toward the victor?
- 3.57** This is why I think, for example, there are guys who have large followings on YouTube simply because they stream their video games. I don't know who would possibly—I've never understood that, wanting to watch someone else play a video game and then just watching it. But some of these guys have hundreds of thousands, millions of followers, and some of these guys, they get messages from women. They have these little conventions, and this is surprisingly —and I think what's going on here is that

these guys who stream their games and receive a lot of attention from other nerds, some women will see that and find that interesting and want to meet this person and become closer to them.

- 3.58** Here's a painting that I saw in Naples last year in the Museum of Naples, Archeological Museum. This is called Gladiators at the Triclinium. But essentially, you can see that here's the victor surrounded by adoring women, and you can see the vanquished male being dragged away by Roman slaves. You can see here a very brutal logic of organized contest, at least how they used to look in the past, and I suppose in some cultures. You see the blood. This painting really caught my eye when I walked past it.
- 3.59** How does this work? There are formal, organized rituals, and then there are rituals that arise organically, rituals that you sort of only notice after the fact. This idea—the law enforcement expert, Rory Miller, wrote a book called *Meditations on Violence*, talking about his years working in law enforcement and as a consultant. He noticed that, especially when two young males are in the early stages of a potential physical conflict, they follow this predictable pattern leading up to a physical fight. This tends to take place between two strangers. The first step, eye contact, hard stare, then a verbal challenge. "You got a problem, bro? What are you looking at?" Then the closing of the distance, chest bumping, extension of the arms.
- 3.60** There's a biologist, Adam Hart, who suggested that the reason why men in these kinds of circumstances raise their arms like this is essentially to increase perception of body size. If you look at weigh-ins for boxing or MMA, they're standing on the scale, but they often flex like this. The idea here is to project and take up space and look physically intimidating. This is why the arms extend out. Then you have finger poke, followed by a push, dominant roundhouse punch, and then the fight begins.
- 3.61** One of the things that's interesting about this is that it seldom happens between, say—generally speaking, it happens between two men of roughly equal age and equal size. Very rarely will a male enter one of these monkey dances with a child or with a woman. Very few men will enter the monkey dance with someone who's obviously high on drugs or crazy. Although I have seen an interesting—I can tell this story really quickly.
- 3.62** I was hanging out with a couple of my friends years ago. We were downtown. We were walking. There was a lot of homelessness in this town. There was this small guy, came up to my friend, and tried to grab him. This probably homeless-looking guy, grabbed my friend, and he looked very disheveled and very unshowered. My friend pulled his hand away, and the little guy starts to get aggressive like this. He's obviously on something. My friend was confused because I know—he was a former Marine. He likes to look tough. He didn't want to just back down. He didn't want to run away, but he also didn't want to touch this guy or interact with him. He was confused about what he should do because me and my other friend are watching him and we're like, "What are you going to do, man? What are you going to do about it? How are you going to handle this?" He's like this.

- 3.63** So what he decides to do—the little guy is chasing him—my friend, he has his hands up like he's ready to fight, but he's running backwards because he knows that if he turns his back and runs away, he's going to look cowardly. But he also doesn't want to actually engage because then he'd have to touch the guy. This was like, "Oh, god, stay away, but I'm ready, but don't touch me." So this was a variation of this male monkey dance. Eventually, my other friend interfered, and it all went over without an issue.
- 3.64** OK, so, the monkey dance. What's interesting about it is that it follows that sequence. Generally speaking, it follows this sequence. There seem to be rules even around this organic ritualized combat in which no one says there are explicit rules. No one tells you these are the steps. This is just what happens. Some evolutionary psychologists have recently suggested that people have an intuitive sense of a fair fight. They have this intuitive sense, this is how combat should play out. You shouldn't have cheap shots. You shouldn't gouge the eyes. You shouldn't bite. You shouldn't try to grab someone's testicles or something like that. There are certain things that we intuitively believe that you shouldn't do in a fight.
- 3.65** They suggest that the reason why, cross-culturally, there seem to be these interesting rules about fair fighting is because people want honest assessments of the formidability of the combatants. If someone just suddenly bites the other guy's nose off or something, then it's like, you might think he's crazier than the other guy, but you're not going to think he's actually physically formidable or tough. People seem to know this, too. Intuitively, they seem to know that if they're going to enter a fight, there are certain things you can and can't do. If you do do that, maybe you'll win the fight, but people are going to view you in a shameful way for taking that easy way out.
- 3.66** There's this idea of rapid versus slow escalation, that fair fights slowly escalate. Because if you have a rapid escalation, if someone suddenly does something very rapid, like if at the beginning of the monkey dance, someone just immediately punches the person, you don't necessarily have an accurate indication of who would have actually won if these two were slowly building up to that fight and seeing who's actually more capable.
- 3.67** We'll move on here to professional economic success, honest indicators of resource acquisition ability. This is, I think, if you look at—we'll move on. We'll jump on ahead to this, the workaholism idea. There's a pronounced difference in workaholism between men and women, and there's contentious debate about this, about sex differences in general, and accomplishment, and success, and so on. But if we accept the idea that men are—many men, at least, are on some level aware that professional economic success will reliably lead to them being a bit more attractive to a larger number of women, then it would make sense that maybe they'd be willing to work longer hours, pursue promotions with more, bigger in intensity, why men would be more interested in displaying financial resources.
- 3.68** If you look at—there are studies on social media profiles, for example. Men are more likely to be standing next to an expensive car by themselves. They understand that

these things might increase their romantic prospects. Then also, if you look, we talked a bit about insults before, but if you look at who's more likely to insult the other or question their success or denigrate them for what they've achieved or accomplished, it seems to be men. Men are more likely to make fun of or mock other men's successes. Are haters more likely to be male? I put that in there. I don't know if that's true, but that's my impression.

3.69 OK, so yeah, kindness and generosity. We talked about males donating more to females in fundraisers. Well, no, we talked about men donating more when they're observed by women. But then this was a different study in which researchers found that when the fundraiser was an attractive female, they're more likely to offer larger donations. Another indicator of kindness and generosity is philanthropy. This was an interesting one. There was a study a few years ago indicating that when men —well, when large donors, these weren't necessarily all male, but what they found is that, when people donate to philanthropic organizations, often they want their names to be anonymized. They don't necessarily want their names to be revealed.

3.70 But what these researchers found is that often anonymous donors are seldom truly anonymous. Maybe they're anonymous to the public or to certain people, but often insiders, people who are close to the donor or people who are close to that organization, will eventually find out who donated that money. These researchers suggest that this is a buried signal, the idea here being that it increases the perception of the donor's generosity and kindness that he's such a good person, he didn't even want credit for this, and yet they know who it was. It increases the perception to the people that the donor cares about, who they want to know that they were anonymous in this donation.

3.71 The kindness and generosity idea, I think this may, to some extent, explain why when men have dog photos in their online dating profile pictures, they tend to get more likes. You have to be like—I think the perception, probably accurate to some extent, that if you own a dog, you can take care of a dog. You at least have some amount of kindness and generosity. Dogs are needier than, say, cats. Actually, cats tend to have the opposite effect. When men show cats in their dating profile pictures, they tend to get fewer likes. Dogs are—these are pets that require a lot of work and a lot of care. OK, so 7 minutes.

3.72 OK, so women compete for status, too. But the research is a bit more sparse on this. I think men's competition for status is just so explicit and so overt, and it's so obvious, that it easily captures the attention of researchers, whereas it's only in the last few years, last couple of decades maybe, that women have really, or researchers have really tried to study women's status competition. Why do they compete for status? Well, high status women generally have access to higher status men. High status women tend to have more resources for offspring care, more social support, and then, of course, the higher rate of offspring, offspring survival.

- 3.73** Here are some of the arenas of female intrasexual competition. This is females competing against females for status. Physical attractiveness. After kindness, after some of these basic characteristics, when you ask men what they find attractive, and women know what they like about women, they'll rate attractiveness as being important. Fidelity. Again, this isn't to say, by the way, that women don't want these things in men and vice versa. But these are, in terms of priorities, men tend to rate fidelity a bit higher than women. Maternal ability, which is indicated by some of the things we've talked about before—kindness, empathy, generosity, compassion. But then how the competition plays out is generally through indirect aggression. We'll get to that here in a bit.
- 3.74** OK, attractiveness. How is this signaled? Through cues of youth and fertility. This is generally what men tend to consider attractive. Symmetry, youthful skin, youthful appearance. If you look at, for example, who spends more time engaging in self-enhancing behaviors, this tends to peak in fertile years. Hair strength is strongest at 20 years of age. If you ask, by the way, if you ask men across the life span, what age of women they tend to find most attractive, it tends to cluster around the early- to mid-20s. So even if you ask a 13-year-old boy, "At what age are women most attractive, or women you tend to find most attractive?", it tends to cluster in the 20s, actually. But then if you ask men all the way up to 70 years old, they still say that's when women tend to be the most attractive.
- 3.75** If you ask women at what age are men most attractive, they tend to answer with men who are roughly around their own age. As women age, they tend to find slightly younger men a bit more attractive. But generally, it is, like, women like men who are roughly the same age as themselves. When they're young, they tend to like men who are a little bit older. When they're older, they tend to like men who are a little bit younger. Men, it's generally, regardless of age, they tend to find women in their 20s to be particularly attractive. And interest in engaging in these self-enhancing behaviors, increasing the way that you appear, increasing attractiveness, seems to peak during the most fertile years. This is when women tend to be the most likely to conceive and have children.
- 3.76** Attractiveness. So yeah, intrasexual competition. Attractive women are disproportionately targeted for aggression, and in response, women often dress defensively. They dress in certain ways to avoid this kind of aggression, depending on the context, depending on the environment. There was an interesting study a few years ago that women generally prefer to take appearance-related advice from gay men relative to female friends. The logic here was that women might think that gay men would be more honest about what looks good on them versus what their female friends might say, which they may interpret to be less than honest because of this competition for mates.

- 3.77** There was a funny study here. I think this was just a couple of years ago, which they asked—so these were college women, female participants, and they gave them two different scenarios. So it presented with two scenarios. In one scenario, they said to imagine that you're going out on a mixer. You're going on a mixer in which there will be men and women present, guys and girls on campus, mixed sex event. And then they asked them to imagine that they're going to an event with women only. This is going to be a female-only mixer. You're going to hang out with other women only.
- 3.78** The A column, the A side—so they showed them the silhouettes. They said, "Here's some silhouettes. Draw what you might wear to this event." These are just some examples. The A column, this is for the mixed gender. Men are going to be present at this event. What will they wear? The A column, women, on average, the finding was—so here's one, here's one, here's one for A. And then for B, B is what they would wear, no men present, only women. The B column, here, here, here.
- 3.79** The basic finding here was that, when women were told they were going to go to a mixer where men were present, there was more skin showing in these silhouettes. Whereas when they were going to an event where it was going to be only women, they dressed defensively. They dressed in a way that would not necessarily attract negative attention from other men or judgment or condemnation. They were trying to balance their priorities here. You could imagine that, if there are going to be men present, maybe you'd want to attract a partner. But if there are only going to be women present, if you want to make friends, if you want to get along, then your priorities change and you'll dress differently as a result.
- 3.80** More on female intrasexual competition. Basic finding here is that they were shown women. Women participants were shown images of women in different types of clothing. This was the more modest dress, or the less modestly dressed woman. Then they added this heavier woman here just to see whether it was the clothing or the appearance that was more driving this effect. But the basic effect here is that women reported that they would express more aggression to a woman dressed here in the pink shirt than to the woman dressed here in the black shirt. Then if you compare the heavier woman dressed in the pink shirt compared to the woman in the black shirt, they still reported showing more aggression to the woman dressed in the pink shirt, suggesting that they still felt threatened. Maybe, yeah, this woman is a bit more heavy, maybe men might find her a bit less attractive, but they still found this style of clothing to be—they judged it more harshly and directed more aggression toward her than to the woman dressed in the black shirt.
- 3.81** OK, yeah, fidelity. There was a paper—well, there were several papers by Tania Reynolds, who I've talked about before. She coined this term, the "bless her heart" effect. I guess this term comes from the South. I'm not from the South, but I think it's—you sort of say something that could be perceived as unkind, but then you followed up

with, "Bless her heart," to say, "Yeah, I said this unkind thing, but I still care about this person. Bless their heart." Did I get that right? I think that's, yeah. So bless her heart.

- 3.82** The idea that Tania Reynolds suggested is that women in intrasexual competition, they will communicate information in concealed, in veiled ways, in an attempt to derogate their rivals, to undercut their rivals, while also signaling good qualities about themselves. Often this has to do with sexual promiscuity and sexual history. An example she's given is, if a woman says something like, "Yeah, I'm really worried about Jane. She's been taking a lot of boys home from Tinder lately, and she's been drinking a lot, and I'm just worried about her. I just want to make sure she's OK."
- 3.83** And so on the one hand, she's communicating concern, empathy, compassion, but she's also communicating that, to whoever she's speaking with, that Jane likes to drink and likes to get around. Tania Reynolds and others have suggested that that's actually the purpose of her statement. Of course, the person also wants to express concern. But perhaps it would be better for a friend if she just spoke directly with her and said, "I'm concerned about you," instead of telling other people about what she's done and how concerned she is.
- 3.84** There are two dominant intrasexual competition strategies. This applies to both men and women. Self-promotion, amplifying one's characteristics. This is advertising yourself, talking about or signaling good qualities about you. Then there's competitor derogation. Instead of lifting yourself up, you're cutting others down, reducing the value of your rivals. This seems to be a thornier problem for women. A lot of the insults that men will launch at each other, you could say the guy is poor or weak or something like that. But these can be disproven. If you call a guy weak and he lifts some heavy weight, well, he proved you wrong. If you say he's poor and he buys an expensive car—you can buy on credit and so on—but generally speaking, if he buys an expensive car, probably he's not that poor.
- 3.85** But for women, a lot of their insults at their rivals tend to be clustered around sexual history and promiscuity. If one woman calls another woman a thot or a skank or something, how do you disprove that? How do you prove that you're not that thing? You can't really disprove a negative. And so a lot of the intrasexual competition among women, even though it's more indirect, it's less overt, less physically aggressive, injuries are less likely to result, but they do tend to be vicious in their own way. So men are direct, women are indirect. Men express through overt, confrontational verbal or physical aggression, and women do it often through rumors, gossip, ostracism, often more prolonged as well, where men are more likely to reconcile after an aggressive event. We'll talk more about that later. We can't get to that right now.
- 3.86** So we'll go here. We'll conclude here with contest versus scramble competition and just a couple of other ideas. So, contest versus scramble competition. Contest is how men tend to compete with one another. This is an idea from Joyce Benenson. She suggests that contest competition is this overt competitive, who can outdo the other. This is

more of a male arena of competition. Sports are an example of this, but it's really about who can best who.

3.87 Scramble competition tends to be more solitary, tends to be more indirect, physically safer. It's not—women seldom compete with one another. They're like, "I'm better than her," the way that men might do. They tend to solve these problems on their own. They tend to try to improve themselves, engage in these self-enhancement behaviors, advertise qualities about themselves, without necessarily trying to overtly and directly undercut their rivals. It's less about trying to be better than someone else than just trying to be better overall.

3.88 The male warrior hypothesis, we'll get to that maybe in another time. But here, so we'll close here with the status criteria for both sexes. These are the most status-increasing and status-decreasing qualities that a person can have. This is a very recent study here, but it appears that if you want to increase your status, the best things you can do to be a trusted, smart, reliable leader, get a degree from a college and know a lot of things. Those are the things that you can do to increase your status. This is for both men and women.

3.89 Then if you really want to lower your status, if your goal is to be less well regarded by others, then you should be an unclean, stupid, dirty thief. We'll leave it there.

Lecture 4: Envy Explored

At a glance — Envy explored.

- 4.1 I wanted to get to a couple of the slides that we jumped over in the previous lecture before we get started with the next one. We talked a bit about indirect aggression. There's this great book called *Yanoama: The Story of Helen Valero*. This book, I actually saw David Buss, the evolutionary psychology professor, recommend this on Twitter a couple of years ago. I went online and this book's out of print, so I found it actually in a used bookstore. It's an amazing book, if you can find a copy.
- 4.2 It's about this young woman, Helen Valero, or she was actually a girl at the time, Spanish girl, who was basically abducted by an indigenous tribe in the remote Amazon in the 1930s. Then she eventually managed—the book documents her experiences there. She relays her story and what had happened to her. She lived there for decades, and then eventually returned and told her story to—I don't know how to pronounce this name—Ettore Biocca, who was an Italian biologist.
- 4.3 But in this book, there's a lot of fascinating stories if you're interested in anthropology and hunter-gatherer societies. But she tells this story about how she arrived at this new Amazonian tribe, and immediately, the other young girls there did not like her very much. On this theme of indirect aggression, one of the girls in this tribe hands Helen Valero this leaf packet and says, "You can eat this if you want, but if you don't like it, you can give it to someone else." Helen Valero, she's—I don't know, she actually doesn't describe her age very well, but I want to say she's probably around 13 or 14—she smells this leaf packet and it repulses her. She's disgusted by the smell. She sets it off to the side and doesn't eat it.
- 4.4 Then a few hours later, a child gets sick in the village and he says he ate this leaf packet. The men in the tribe and the women, all the adults are like, "Well, where did you get this leaf packet from?" The child points at Helen and says, "She gave it to me." Then they accuse her of trying to poison a child. This new girl, this stranger, this outsider, tries to poison one of the children. Then they immediately banish her. They chase her out of the tribe. Some of the men are firing arrows at her as she runs away.
- 4.5 This, to me, is a very high-level version of indirect aggression here, where if this had been a young male who entered this tribe and the other males didn't like him, they would have bullied him, pushed him around. It would have been very apparent that they didn't like him and would have tested him and whatever. It would have been a very overt verbal or physical dispute. Whereas in this case, one of the girls gives her a gift. It's a very indirect, very sly way of attempting to eliminate this rival, telling her, "You can eat this and be poisoned yourself, or you can give it to someone else and be blamed for poisoning this other person."

- 4.6 Then if Helen Valero had been killed by one of the men who was enraged at the death of the child, or they banished her off—she survived—but if she had been banished, and then she's mauled by a jaguar, the girl who gave her this leaf packet would have been responsible, but no one would have ever known. That's a high-level version of indirect aggression. Perhaps the way that this plays out among girls and women is why it took so long for this intrasexual competition among women to be studied and investigated because it's more subtle, because it's harder to track, whereas for men, it's so apparent.
- 4.7 This gets us to, briefly, the male warrior hypothesis, finishing up the slides in this lecture. The male warrior hypothesis was posited by—the guy's name is Mark van Vugt. I want to say, that's how you pronounce his name. Him and his colleagues suggest that both he and Joyce Benenson and others have basically documented some interesting research indicating that, overall, conflict and hostility within groups is roughly equal between men and women. It just takes on these different forms.
- 4.8 If you look at sports teams or all-male organizations and groups, the conflict tends to be overt, bullying, verbal aggression, insults, a lot of that kind of hostility. For women, it tends to take the form of ostracism or rumors or backbiting, gossip. But when male groups are competing against another male group, then the level of within-group hostility declines. Most of this work, at least to my knowledge, has been done mostly on sports teams. This is still a tentative hypothesis, I think. But I think there's really something to it where, when male teams are competing against other male teams, suddenly the hostility is muted and it's channeled toward this other team. The men within the group suddenly along much more, the insults and all that stuff, it declines, and it's really directed at trying to vanquish the other team.
- 4.9 Whereas for women, the within-group level of hostility doesn't seem to decline very much, even when they're competing against a female, opposing team. Joyce Benenson and some of her colleagues, they studied men's and women's sports teams and find that women who are playing with one another against another female team, they'll still freeze each other out or will undercut one another or whisper things to each other as they're playing, trying to essentially—they're not trying, but they're maintaining that same level of within-group conflict. If two women don't like each other on the team, it's very hard for them to subdue and mute that when they're competing against another team, whereas for men, it seems to be a bit easier.
- 4.10 The idea of the male warrior hypothesis is essentially that, evolutionarily speaking, in the ancestral environment, men, of course, were competing against one another within community to stand out, to be more attractive, to obtain status, prestige within a group, and attempt to be appealing to female partners. But then often, these groups would go on raids and go to war against other villages, other tribes, other communities, and attempt to capture lives from these other groups as well. This is documented a lot in this book, which is just full of violence.

- 4.11 Essentially, the idea here is that the male warrior hypothesis—when men are within their own group, they're competing against each other. But as soon as they are in a situation in which they are against a very clear out-group in which there's some kind of a prestige or reward to be won, then they can suddenly direct or channel that aggression toward that other group. This seems to be a sort of a weird, peculiar property of uniquely male psychology.
- 4.12 OK, so now we're going to switch over to the next slides. Now we'll be talking about social comparison, envy, and schadenfreude. We'll start with this. To me, I think this is an astonishing quote from Julius Caesar, one of the most renowned historical figures. He's quoted as saying—this is from Plutarch, an ancient historian, who said, "Do you not think it is a matter for sorrow that while Alexander"—meaning Alexander the Great—"while Alexander at my age was already king of so many peoples, I have as yet achieved no brilliant success?"
- 4.13 This was relatively early in Caesar's career. Caesar is lamenting the fact that despite his immense accomplishments thus far early in his career, he still feels diminished when he compares himself to someone who's also achieved great success. Caesar, interestingly himself, was a victim of this social comparison later in his career. In the Shakespearean version of the story, which is actually drawn from the Lives of Plutarch, inspired by what Plutarch had written about Caesar, Caesar had a friend named Cassius, who was a Roman senator. And in the Shakespearean version of the story, Cassius told another senator named Brutus that—he told him a story from childhood. The story was essentially that, when they were both boys, Cassius had saved young Julius Caesar from drowning. Ever since then, he had viewed himself as superior. He saw Caesar in this vulnerable state when they were young children. He rescued him and felt this sense that he was above him for that reason.
- 4.14 But by the time Cassius is relaying this story to Brutus, Caesar has become the leader of Rome, widely beloved by the masses, and Cassius envied him for this. This motivated Cassius to set in motion the events that eventually led to Caesar's assassination in the Roman Senate. I think this is interesting. Early in his career, Caesar felt that he had not ascended high enough. Then later, others killed him because they thought he had ascended too high.
- 4.15 I open with this story to illustrate the realities of social comparison orientation. This is a concept in social psychology that captures the inclination to compare oneself with others, especially with regard to social status. Here are a couple of items in the social comparison orientation scale. "I often compare myself with others with respect to what I have accomplished in life." "I often compare how I'm doing socially, the social skills and popularity with other people."
- 4.16 Again, these fall on a spectrum. There's no one who would ever score—these are scored on a scale from 1 or 0 to 7, very much disagree to very much agree. Very few people would say they disagree with all of these. All of us, to some extent, feel this. But

it's the magnitude, the intensity of these, that really captures this idea that there are some of us who are just habitual social comparers. If you check "extremely agree" with every single one of these statements, this would suggest something about you, about how frequently you're measuring yourself relative to other people. At least by the time Cassius started to form the conspiracy around the murder of Caesar, he probably would have said "extremely agree," at least if you replaced others with Caesar here.

- 4.17 So here's a—this is a question from a measure of whether people prize subjective or objective rewards more. It gets at this idea of subjective versus objective status. You get 2 weeks of vacation or your coworkers get 1 week, or you get 4 weeks of vacation, or your coworkers get 8 weeks. I think to me, on the one hand, this might be a very easy question. Really, you could look at it one way. You could look at it as you get 2 weeks of vacation or you get 4 weeks of vacation, and that's all it is. That's how you could look at it. But then you have this other part where, on the one hand, in option A, you get twice as much vacation as your coworkers. In option B, you get half as much.
- 4.18 And this is actually a question that splits people. It divides people. People who tend to answer with A tend to score very high on social comparison orientation. They compare themselves with others. It's a measure of, well, "It's not how much I get, it's how much I get relative to someone else." They'll incur a cost. They're losing 2 weeks of vacation, in a sense, in order to obtain this relative advantage.
- 4.19 So what are the correlates of social comparison orientation? What person habitually compares themselves with other people? People who score high on psychopathy and this utilitarian reasoning, they tend to score higher on narcissism, on fear of failure, which is unsurprising. I mean, fear of failure and narcissism, the idea here that, if you care very much how you look in the eyes of other people, then naturally, you're going to fear losing esteem through failures. Interest in status displays, also tied in with narcissism as well. People who compare themselves with others are going to be interested in broadcasting and demonstrating certain things about themselves that would enhance their image in the eyes of others.
- 4.20 FOMO, fear of missing out. This is a pretty striking effect of 0.5. People who compare themselves with others have a strong fear of missing out. They don't want to be excluded. They don't want to feel like others are having fun without them. Then it also social compares and to score highly on malicious envy and benign envy. We'll talk about the difference between those two forms of envy in this lecture.
- 4.21 OK, so envy. Well, what is envy? We'll start here. The emotional consequence of upward social comparison. It's the feeling that we experience when we start to compare ourselves with another person. It does seem to be, to some extent, potentially evolutionarily adaptive. We've discussed before about how certain negative emotions, although they feel unpleasant, they do serve some adaptive purpose. They do hold some evolutionary significance. They direct us to do certain things. They direct us away

from others that, on average in the ancestral environment, would have been advantageous for survival or reproduction.

- 4.22 Envy, to some extent, alerts. It leads us to become more aware of our shortcomings. The purpose here for envy seems to be a status-leveling mechanism of ensuring that we're not falling too low or that others aren't rising too high. It can spiral out of control, of course, but it does seem to be natural and it does seem to be found cross-culturally in human societies around the world. Here's how some researchers describe it. At its core, "envy is born out of the perceived danger to lose respect and social influence in the eyes of others. Envy's function may be to foster the motivations to regain status or harm the superior position of others."
- 4.23 So some people have suggested that envy is actually a difficult expression to capture. What does envy look like? If you think about what anger looks like, that's pretty easy to envision in your mind. When you think about what happiness looks like. But what does envy look like? I think that's right, that it's probably harder to capture than some other emotions, but I really like this image from the television series *Mad Men*. Some of you may be familiar with this show. It's a group of advertising executives in Madison Avenue in the 1960s.
- 4.24 In this scene, Ken Cosgrove, who's out of the frame here, he has just told Pete Campbell and Paul Kinsey, two of his colleagues, that he just had a story published in a prestigious magazine. You can see that the expression these two—and if you watch the scene, they're saying, "Oh, you. Good for you. Well done." They're smiling, but you can tell that these are not genuine, authentic smiles. These are forced, strained smiles. When you listen to it, you can hear the strain in their voice. They also imply in this scene that they're surprised. Like, "You? You got a publication? OK." They're a little bit —this is a sort of a way of complimenting while undercutting at the same time.
- 4.25 I think that this is, I think envy would generally be difficult to capture. This works because, in American society, we try to suppress it for the most part. I think we try to promote the ideal of being happy for other successes. These two are trying to do that. They're trying to say, "We're happy for you," but it's coming out in a very forced way. Whereas pure envy would be, I think, much harder to capture in an image.
- 4.26 Tall poppy syndrome—this is an idea that's popular in New Zealand and Australia. I think in the UK, they talk about this, too. I haven't heard many in the U.S. mention this, but this is an idea in these cultures, in New Zealand, Australia, and in the UK, that if someone seems to be rising too high, if they seem to be seeking status, bids for status, others will resent this. They'll sort of undercut them, they'll criticize them.
- 4.27 A friend of mine, Chris Williamson, he hosts a great podcast, *Modern Wisdom*. He and I have talked about this, where in the UK—the difference between the U.S. and the UK is that we have this norm in the U.S. of if someone's doing well for themselves, you should be congratulatory, you should be happy for them. Whereas in the UK, the praise

for success is more subdued. It's often accompanied by undercutting remarks and people aren't always as thrilled to see their peers succeed there. This is similar to the crabs in the bucket metaphor, where as a crab seems to be rising up, the others will pull them down. People seem to be intuitively aware of this, many people at least, where they'll feel uncomfortable when they're receiving too much praise or they'll try to downplay their accomplishments because I think they're aware that they don't want to attract that envy, that negative attention.

- 4.28 I'll be referring to some of my favorite quotes from various thinkers throughout this lecture. This is François de la Rochefoucauld. I think I'm pronouncing that right. He wrote a great compilation of maxims in the 17th century. He says here, "It takes great talent and skill to conceal one's talent and skill." He's suggesting here that, on the one hand, if you've done a lot of great things, you're highly accomplished, you're highly talented, it's a talent in itself to not constantly want to broadcast that, to suppress that, that impulse.
- 4.29 Here're a list of 10 laws. This is called Jante Law in Denmark. These aren't actual laws, but these were written by an author and satirist in the mid-20th century in Denmark. These laws, to some degree—they're widely known in Denmark. To some extent, they probably don't apply as much because of the influence of American culture has changed so much of the world. But in Denmark, people are still aware of what these laws are, these satirical laws. "You 're not to think you're anything special. You're not to think you're as good as we are. You're not to think that you're smarter than we are. You're not to convince yourself that you're better than we are. You're not to think you know more than we do," and so on and so forth.
- 4.30 The idea here is that Denmark has, at least in recent history, the recent history, have been a very egalitarian society. They don't like when people are rising up too much. I like this one here. "You're not to laugh at us." That they're really hypersensitive to people who appear to be self-promoting, self-enhancing, and adopting this attitude of some kind of a superior position.
- 4.31 Status leveling. We've talked a bit about the egalitarian nature of hunter-gatherer societies and reverse dominance hierarchies, about how they're extremely sensitive to bullies and to people who try to take more resources for themselves or steal other people's romantic partners and mates and so on. But one of the things that some societies do—this is again documented in *Hierarchy in the Forest* by Christopher Boehm—is arrow swapping. The idea here is that, when men go out on a hunt and return with meat, it's considered a prestigious act to allocate the meat around the community. The man who delivers the meat is considered to be impressive, prestigious. There's a lot of thank yous.
- 4.32 The men take turns doing this, regardless of who actually killed, regardless of who actually was the one to take out the animal. They swap arrows, so to speak, so that the person who is credited with the killing actually gives the arrow to someone else, so that

they can deliver the meat. It's like the hunter-gatherer equivalent of a participation trophy. This is a way for them to level it out because often there is one man in particular, or maybe a couple of men, who are extremely talented hunters. But if they were to take credit every time, the other men would grow to resent that person for being the one to constantly receive credit.

- 4.33 This is from the !Kung San, which is a hunter-gatherer society, modern hunter-gatherer society. One of the informants in this community describes to a researcher what the norms are around status leveling. "When a young man kills much meat, he comes to think of himself as a chief or a big man, and he thinks of the rest of us as his servants or inferiors. We can't accept this. We refuse one who boasts, for someday his pride will make him kill somebody. So we always speak of his meat as worthless. In this way, we cool his heart and make him gentle."
- 4.34 And so, he's describing specifically after a kill. If there's one person who makes an impressive kill, especially if he does it repeatedly, the others will mock him. They'll mock the way maybe he throws his spear. They'll tell him that the animal is actually not that big, or they'll start to make fun of other things that he does, his appearance, the way that he runs. They'll attempt to try to undercut him so that he doesn't feel that he's superior to the others.
- 4.35 Relatedly, if leaders and big men in these leadership roles exist, they themselves will often display self-effacing behavior, mock themselves, or they might say something like, "Oh, you're right, the animal wasn't that big." There are stories, for example, of talented hunters who will make an impressive kill, but then they'll downplay it and say, "Oh, it wasn't actually that big. " The other hunter-gatherers, often when they hear this, when they hear someone say, "Oh, the kill wasn't that big," they understand that he actually did make a really big kill. They can infer this self-effacing behavior from talented hunters. This envy does seem to be natural, intrinsic to some extent.
- 4.36 I find interesting how frequently you'll read about the concept of the evil eye in very small-scale societies. The evil eye, a belief complex based on the idea that an individual, either male or female, has the power to cause harm to another individual or to that individual's property by simply looking at or praising that person's property. I mean, even praising. But the evil eye is associated with envy, essentially—that someone looks upon another person or their possessions and feel that they either desire that possession or they don't want that other person to have that anymore.
- 4.37 In some small-scale societies, they associate the evil eye with subsequent damaged property, or if a child falls ill. For example, if someone is on the receiving end of the evil eye, and then the next day their child gets sick, they will assume that it 's because of the evil eye. The person who was looking upon them with envy may have poisoned their child. Or if some of their property is damaged or missing, they'll blame it on the evil eye. "Oh, that person, the way that they were looking at me." And this can lead to accusations of sorcery or witchcraft or the way that they looked at you cursed you.

- 4.38 And so some of these communities have developed defenses. They may just conceal their good fortune. If they happen to come across a useful resource or food or something along those lines, they just won't really talk that much about it. They may disfigure their own good looks through body paint or through piercings or unusual hairstyles, or if they have a particularly good-looking child, they'll rub suit or paint or something on it so as to avoid the envy of others in the community.
- 4.39 Sometimes I wonder if this is happening today. You see a lot of young people now with a lot of piercings and a lot of tattoos and a lot of aggressive hairstyles. And I think—I don't know, my feeling is that envy is on the rise in society today, and some of this temporary or permanent disfiguring of the body and appearance may be an attempt to either fit in or to avoid envious looks from others.
- 4.40 You can see, we've talked a bit about status leveling in small-scale hunter-gatherer societies. There's also work on this from developmental psychology, young children. Essentially, you give 5- and 6-year-old children an option. There are two choices. You can get 8 treats, the other person gets 8 treats, or you can get 7 treats and the other person gets zero. The majority of 5- and 6-year-old children will choose the 7 for the self and zero for the other. They will take the absolute smaller amount to obtain a relative advantage over another. It's not until kids, I think, reach about 8 or 9 years old that they start to prioritize fairness and equality and those kinds of things. But when they're young, when they're unsophisticated, when they're thinking less about social image and how they look to others and all that stuff, then they care a bit more about having more than someone else.
- 4.41 It does seem, when you look at hunter-gatherer societies, when you study the evil eye, you study how children behave, it does seem that envy is a natural universal. It does seem to be adaptive to some degree. It serves a purpose. But as we think about these things around status, around emotions, we should bear in mind the naturalistic fallacy, which is—essentially the naturalistic fallacy is this belief that just because something is natural, therefore it must be good. "Oh, that's just nature. Therefore, oh, that's just—" People use this as an excuse sometimes. "Well, that's just how things are. That's just nature. That's how people behave. That's how animals are," and so on.
- 4.42 But it's a fallacy because you can't necessarily state that just because something is the way it is, therefore it should be that way as well. Morality is not—you can't necessarily hold norms and laws and morals hostage to whatever happens to be natural. In fact, laws, norms, constraints on behavior, every society has those two. Those are also natural. Every society has standards for behavior in order to constrain certain aspects of our nature. In a way, both of those two things are natural. You can't necessarily decide how to have a society or develop norms around what happens to be natural or not. That's a separate question.
- 4.43 So good does not mean natural. Just because you want things to be a certain way, that doesn't necessarily mean that's how they are. If you have a certain set of moral

principles in your mind, that doesn't necessarily mean that that's how reality works either. A lot of people want to recruit nature or reality into their arguments to bolster them, to say, "Well, that's how things are, therefore that's how they should be," or "That's how they should be, so therefore, that's how they are." But these kinds of questions about how humans should behave, how society should be formed, they can't necessarily be answered with science.

- 4.44 Science can be used as an instrument. If we learn and study human nature, this can help us to decide. We can have a goal in mind and then use things that we've learned about human behavior, about science and so forth, to promote certain goals over others. But it doesn't tell you what goals to have. There's a contentious debate right now around sex differences and the gender pay gap, for example. People will say, "Well, men earn more than women. That's because men are disagreeable or because they're ambitious," and so on and so forth. "That's how things are. Why are we fighting it? That's just a reality."
- 4.45 But then others would say, "Yeah, but that's not right. We should be maybe promoting or coercing men to be more agreeable and less ambitious, and to prioritize women's ascent into higher paying positions." The drive underlying both of those are natural. Status leveling is natural. The drive to have more resources, that's natural, but then so is disagreeableness among men. That question can't necessarily be resolved. You can actually use the instruments of shame and stigma and law and coercion and so forth to actually get men to be less ambitious. You can do that. But then the question of, "Is that the society that you want?" That question can't be answered with science. That's a moral, philosophical, political question.
- 4.46 Moving on. There are two types of envy. Envy is not just one thing, similar to how status isn't just one thing. We also talked about how narcissism isn't just one thing. Envy is not just one thing either. There's benign envy. This is essentially—the reason it's called benign is because you don't necessarily wish ill toward anyone else. The goal of benign envy is to improve yourself. You see someone else that you admire, someone who's impressive, and you feel like, "Man, I wish I could do that." You envy the person because of the attention they're receiving. But then the subsequent feeling isn't to tear them down or to undercut their accomplishment. It's more so like, "I wish I could do that. I'm going to improve myself." The goal associated with benign envy is to level yourself up.
- 4.47 Then there's malicious envy. You see someone do something impressive or receiving lots of attention, and then hostile thoughts will stir in your mind, and then you start to feel resolved to subvert that person's accomplishments or to denigrate them in some way. The goal here isn't to level yourself up, but more so to try to level that other person down. This is a quote from the Greek poet Aeschylus. I put that in quotes there because I did not know how to pronounce it. "It is in the character of very few men to honor without envy a friend who has prospered." I think this is an eloquent quote, but

then there's another quote that gets at the same idea, less elegant and more blunt, from the cultural critic, Gore Vidal. "Every time a friend succeeds, I die a little."

- 4.48** Again, this gets at this idea, I think, of envy is natural, but how much do you want envy to proliferate in your society? That's not a question that can be answered with science. Some cultures have managed to constrain envy. They've managed to channel it in certain directions, or they promote one form of envy over the other, maybe benign envy. You see someone else and you want to be like them, use them as a sort of an ideal or a goal. You strive toward it. Other cultures, other individuals, may say that malicious envy is more preferable, that it's not right, it's not fair that someone else has so much in the way of resources or success or attention, and we should undercut them, or we should seize their resources, or we should take what they have. It's not right that they have it.
- 4.49** Malicious envy. Continuing on with malicious envy, it's not just about stuff, not just material resources. We can feel envy and want to take what others have in addition to material possessions, also their happiness, relationship, their odds of future success. A lot of the way that malicious envy is expressed is through attempting to undercut other people's happiness, the way they feel. They may withhold warmth or congratulations, or other things that may make another person feel good, in order to try to bring the happy person down a notch and get them to feel a bit less happy.
- 4.50** Subjective status seems to be a stronger predictor of envy than objective status. I mentioned this study before, but we'll go through very quickly about how people seem to envy others more so for the level of social attention and esteem they have, more so than for the amount of economic resources or wealth that they have. And yet there's something interesting here about the way that our society is going, where it's still, I think, considered impolite to talk about how much money we have, but the social media metrics, followings, likes, and all those things, those are out in the open for anyone to see.
- 4.51** Malicious envy and coercive redistribution. This was a recent study indicating that people who score highly on malicious envy are also more likely to be in favor of coercive redistribution, which is the belief that it's OK to seize other people's assets to distribute them more equitably. Malicious envy was a stronger predictor of support for a coercive economic redistribution than self-interest or fairness or instrumental harm—instrumental harm being the belief that it's OK to harm a smaller number of people to help a larger number. It seems to be that malicious envy drives a lot of the support for this kind of large-scale redistribution.
- 4.52** Then more quotes from my favorite thinkers. Adam Smith on envy avoidance. "The man who has had large and sudden success will realize envy makes it difficult for others to share in his joy. The successful man will mute his trumpeting of his good fortune. He will affect humility, probably unsuccessfully, but he will at least try." Adam Smith, he's mostly known for his book, *The Wealth of Nations*, but he also wrote a great book

called The Theory of Moral Sentiments. He 's a great philosopher, I think. Here, I think he's describing how successful men do behave. Maybe he's describing how they should behave, too. But I think this is generally good advice, this belief in envy avoidance. It's best to try to avoid having those kinds of feelings directed at you or to elicit that feeling in others.

4.53 Wise advice, I think, to not trumpet your good fortune too much. There are consequences for envy, which I think Adam Smith may have been aware of and why he wrote that quote. Leaders have historically been known to fire advisors for being too good at their job, especially if they feel that their advisors have ambitions to usurp them or take their power. This is, echoes, "Never outshine the master," which is one of Robert Greene's laws from his book, 48 Laws of Power. That's actually a first law. He suggests that one of the most critical errors you can make, especially early on in your career, is to look better than your boss. He suggests that you should not do that, or you should downplay, or if you are the recipient of a lot of credit for something you've done, to ensure that you credit the boss for his or her mentorship or guidance or help. Otherwise, you may attract their vitriol and they may try to undercut you in some way, another consequence of envy.

4.54 This is why a lot of cultures prize modesty and humility—probably most cultures. American culture is unique in that humility and modesty are often discredited or made fun of or thought to be fake or inauthentic. But historically and cross-culturally, it's actually self-promotion and bragging that have been met with shame and stigma, not modesty and humility.

4.55 Here's another idea from Adam Smith's The Theory of Moral Sentiments about envy. He suggests that "when people's joys are too great, we respond with envy. When people are doing really well, when they've achieved an outsized accomplishment, we respond with envy. When others' sorrows are too small, we don't take them seriously." If someone is telling us how bad their day went and traffic and how they were late for work, it's like, "OK, big deal." But if they tell us something truly tragic, something seriously bad happened to them, then we do respond with sympathy.

4.56 Adam Smith suggests that we're most likely to sympathize with other people's small joys and great sorrows. When other people tell us about something small and good that happened to them, we can respond with authentic and legitimate happiness with no signs or no trace of envy. When other people tell us about something truly tragic that happened to them, we really will sympathize with them. I think this is to some extent why people will often downplay their successes and accomplishments as we've been discussing. And often people will magnify. They'll exaggerate the bad things that have happened to them, too. They'll embellish, embroider things that have occurred in order to elicit this sympathy and get people to take them seriously.

4.57 There's Arthur Schopenhauer. He was a cranky old misanthrope. So he suggested, the philosopher Schopenhauer, he suggested that if you want to test people for envy, you

can tell them some good news about yourself. Then often you'll notice a quick response, a sort of a brief flash in their face of disappointment, tension, strain in their voice, similar to that image that I showed you earlier of Mad Men. That very brief, inauthentic smile, that strain in the voice. You can also tell if people envy you by telling them some misfortune of yours. He suggests that, momentarily, their eyes will light up for a fleeting second. They'll be momentarily gleeful, pleased that something bad has happened, that idea of schadenfreude, which I'll discuss here in a few.

- 4.58** We've talked about age, age and its relationship with various personality traits and age and the Dark Triad traits. Now that we know the link between age and Dark Triad, age and agreeability, and these other traits, we could probably guess by now that there's a relatively strong inverse correlation between envy and age, meaning that younger adults tend to feel more envy than older adults. Envy is tested by various scales. Here are a couple from one dispositional envy scale. "I am troubled by my feelings of inadequacy." "Frankly, the success of my neighbors makes me resent them."
- 4.59** Interestingly, in the study about envy and age, the younger adults in that sample had higher incomes than the older adults, and yet they still reported feeling more dispositional envy in their everyday lives. Again, this could be tied to personality differences, this drive for success, for status, and so on. When you're a young person, it may be, to some extent, adaptive to see what other people are doing and have that elevate you, elicit this desire to level up. And in another way, it could lead you to want to also cut people down, that feeling of being inadequate, despite being relatively prosperous in a way of material resources.
- 4.60** The targets of our envy, this is an interesting one. So who do we tend to envy? We don't envy everybody equally. Even when we would typically feel envy towards someone, it can be subdued based on various dispositional factors. It can be influenced by appearance, various other traits, various other features. But it seems to be that the main targets of our envy, the people that we are most likely to envy, are those who are similar. There's a similarity effect, similar to ourselves.
- 4.61** The sociologist, Helmut Schoeck, he suggested, "Envy is a phenomenon of social proximity. Envy is always between neighbors. The envious man thinks that if his neighbor breaks his leg, he will be able to walk better himself." This idea of social proximity and being between neighbors, people who we could imagine ourselves being, that's who we tend to direct our envy toward. Those are the two key principles here, which we'll discuss in a minute.
- 4.62** Similarity and then domain relevance. Domain relevance is, "Is this an area where I want to succeed in myself? Do I have my identity invested in that area of success?" So if you see someone who is much older, completely different background, different education, different everything, and they're doing extremely well in some sport that you have no interest in, they're receiving a lot of attention and so on and so forth, odds are you're not going to feel much envy toward that person. But if you see someone

who's roughly the same age, same gender, same background, everything, and you would like to be a painter, and you see this person, who's very similar to yourself, doing very well in the artistic realm, and they're a great painter and receiving a lot of attention, that will tend to elicit a lot of envy.

4.63 The second half of this quote here, "The envious man thinks that his neighbor breaks his leg, he'll be able to better walk himself," that reminds me of just a couple of folk tales that I like. There's an old Jewish folk tale about a guy who's walking along a beach, and he comes across a lamp, and Genie appears and says, "I'll give you a wish, but the caveat is, whatever you get, I'll give your neighbor twice as much." The man pauses and thinks for a second, and he says, "I want you to pluck one of my eyes out." There's an Irish version of this tale where the man tells the genie, "I want you to beat me half to death." This gets this idea. They 'd rather have this relative advantage, if it means that the neighbor, that the other person, will be damaged even more than themselves.

4.64 OK, Girard. A lot of these ideas about envy tie into some of the themes from Girard. Girard seems to be having this renaissance, no doubt due to the influence of Peter Thiel. And Luke Burgis wrote a great book called Wanting recently about Girard's ideas. A couple of friends of mine, David Perell and Jonathan Bi, they just recently released a YouTube series on Girard's ideas. Excellent series. And Girard was a philosopher, literary critic. And Girard claimed, and he was on the money empirically, which we'll get to, that envy is an emotion that operates between similar individuals. We compete for status, we compete with people who are closest to us.

4.65 But one of the things that Girard pointed out is that there are some dangers around the increasing egalitarian nature of society. Girard suggested that, historically, people have mostly competed with those in their own social strata. So aristocrats competed with aristocrats, merchants competed against merchants, soldiers competed against soldiers, within their own realm to attain status within their little faction, within that strata of society. Girard—he lauded, he was happy about the fact that these barriers were being broken down, that people were able to be what they wanted to be, compete in the spaces that they wanted to compete in.

4.66 But he also suggested that this could also increase the potential for envy, for what he called mimetic rivalry. Some of you may be familiar with that term. We won't be able to get into that today. But essentially, he suggested that now, essentially, everyone is a competitor with everyone else. If you used to only compete with other aristocrats, but now you're competing with literally everyone, the world becomes full of competitors because everyone is able to do anything else that you may be interested in as well.

4.67 Continuing on this point of similarity, the counterfactual nature of envy. "It could have been me." That's basically the idea here of who are most likely to envy. Could I have done that? Am I capable of doing that? Those are the people that we tend to envy the most. Same background, bringing, credentials, so on and so forth. Someone who you have similar attributes to, that's what leads to envy. Relevant domain, we mentioned

that as well. Is it an area that you yourself would like to do well in? This gets at this idea of the magnitude of the differences between people. We envy people like ourselves, but we don't necessarily envy people who are so far ahead of us that we could not necessarily imagine being in their place.

4.68 Another quote from sociologist Helmut Schoeck: "The best means of protection against envy of a neighbor is to drive a Rolls-Royce instead of a car only slightly better than his. Overwhelming and astounding inequality arouses far less envy than minimal inequality." Girard, I think, was perhaps right to some extent that the world becomes an arena full of competitors, but still, in our everyday lives, we do tend to compare ourselves most with people around us. And we don't necessarily think of people who are much further ahead or much further behind or much higher, much lower. We don't necessarily think of them as our competitors.

4.69 I think to some extent, this is why, for example, a lot of the—you won't meet a lot of poor working class people who detest multibillionaires. The people who tend to despise the 1% are people who are usually in the top income decile or maybe the top income quintile, the top 10 or top 20%, the people who are close but not quite at that high level because the status disparity is so small. When the status disparity is large, to the point where that's so outside of your reality that you couldn't imagine even being in that position, it's not going to arouse that much envy. You notice that, you know, millionaire senators aren't always huge fans of billionaire founders. I'm not naming any names, but if you think about who tends to dislike founders and the ultrarich the most, it's not ordinary working class people.

4.70 We'll talk a bit about schadenfreude, and now we'll transition here. It's related to envy, as we'll see. Schadenfreude, it's a German term. The literal translation is "shame joy." I was stationed in Germany years ago. I lived there for about three years at Ramstein Air Base. I also did a language program in Berlin. Then I dated a German girl for a long time. And all that time immersed in German culture, I can speak German on the level of an impaired toddler. It's a very interesting language. We have no equivalent here. Shame joy. We just borrowed the German term. The line goes, "The Germans have a word for everything."

4.71 Envy is what predicts schadenfreude, this feeling of pleasure at the misfortune of others. Again, similar to the people that we envy, we experience schadenfreude for people who are similar to ourselves performing in a domain that is relevant to ourselves, when we see someone who reminds us of ourselves experience some setback.

4.72 There was a study here on similarity in schadenfreude. Essentially, this was just college students, males and females. The basic finding here is that they asked to imagine someone similar to yourself who fails a test or fails an exam. They're similar to yourself, and they're taking the same class as you. What they find is that men experience much more envy and schadenfreude when they learn about a male who fails their exam

relative to a female. Then women were more likely to experience envy and schadenfreude towards a female relative to a male. The envy really does seem to be directed primarily at those who are similar to ourselves and the schadenfreude as well.

- 4.73 Schadenfreude also is the strongest predictor of moral outrage. This is a preprint. This is a brand new paper here. These researchers found that—they were trying to predict what were the variables that could predict moral outrage on social media platforms. They found that schadenfreude was actually the most prominent, strongest predictor, followed by concerns over justice, deservingness, and so on. But it really seems to be schadenfreude. They write in their paper that people may experience schadenfreude first before using claims about deserving this as a way of justifying one's experience of malicious pleasure. They use the line that, "Oh, this person were expressing outrage because they deserve it." But really, they're experiencing some degree of pleasure from directing their vitriol at that individual.
- 4.74 Then there's gluckschmerz, "luck pain." This doesn't necessarily involve social comparison. It's not even directly tied to status. I just think this is a funny, interesting concept worth lingering on just for a moment, that it arises when someone you dislike experiences good fortune. You see them experience good luck and you feel a bit of pain in a response, like, you don't want that person to get that thing. There are other status-related emotions as well. There's an interesting idea around anger right now among evolutionary psychologists, Aaron Sell and his colleagues. They propose that anger is essentially a bargaining emotion. He describes it as a sort of a recalibrational emotion. The idea here is to bargain for better treatment.
- 4.75 Remember, this is the ultimate versus proximate. Why did you get angry in the moment? Someone mistreated you? The ultimate question, the evolutionary question is, what adaptive significance does anger hold? Why would anger evolve in the first place? What does it actually do for us? Anger seems to drive us to bargain for better treatment. If someone mistreats you in some way, people respond either by inflicting costs, maybe yelling at them, getting verbally hostile or aggressive with them, or by relinquishing benefits, giving them a silent treatment, or ceasing communication temporarily, or blocking access to resources that they might desire.
- 4.76 Imagine you ask your best friend to pick you up from the airport and the person's 5 hours late and you start yelling at them. Of course, you're yelling at them because you're upset. But the underlying evolutionary logic here is you're yelling at them, you're imposing a cost on them. The message you're communicating is, "Hey, you can't treat me this way. You can't do this to me. I'm yelling at you now so you don't do this again, to basically recalibrate our relationship so that you're aware that you can't be 5 hours late." So, yeah, anger, inflicting costs, imposing benefits.
- 4.77 I'm assuming there's probably a gender difference here, where men, when they're angry, are more likely to inflict costs, express verbal or physical hostility, a confrontational aggressiveness. Then for women, probably more so responding with

the silent treatment or with, at least in romantic contexts, withholding sex or just intimacy within the relationship.

- 4.78** Shame and humiliation to other status-related emotions. These seem to track our social reputation. When you do something that, or rather, if you're accused of doing something that could potentially lower your status, we respond with shame and humiliation. Interestingly, shame does not arise as a result of actually doing something wrong. It rises in response to accusations of wrongdoing. So even if you haven't done anything wrong, the studies suggest that the accusations alone are enough to get you to respond with shame.
- 4.79** Also interesting here is that—so social pain, which essentially shame, humiliation, feeling that your status has been thwarted, it seems to linger longer than physical pain. And there was a study from 2011 which suggested that—basically, what the researchers did was they asked people to recall various painful physical and social memories. For physical memories, people recalled, like breaking a finger, a leg, an arm, maybe getting into a car accident, sports injuries. Then for socially painful memories, things like discovering that your partner was unfaithful to you, being betrayed by a friend, being insulted by a close family member, discovering that a friend has betrayed you, those kinds of things.
- 4.80** And when they asked, "How much did that hurt in the moment?", on average, they reported the physical pain was actually more painful than the social pain. But when they asked them to remember, think about that in the moment right now, "How much pain do you feel?", people feel more pain when they remember the socially painful versus the physically painful memories. Social pain seems to linger longer, and when you recall those moments, it elicits more pain.
- 4.81** They did some brain scans on these individuals as well and found that the areas of the brain associated with physical pain were more active when they thought about those socially painful memories versus when they recalled the physically painful ones. This suggests that these emotions really do serve an adaptive purpose. They linger in our mind, I think, because what good does it do you to remember how much—I mean, generally, physical pain is aversive anyway. We naturally avoid it. Social pain, shame, humiliation—often we have to learn over time what are the actions, what are the things that we did to elicit those responses from ourselves, from other people, and they linger longer to get us to avoid doing those things again or avoid interacting with people who caused those painful emotions in us. And so it lingers in our memory for longer.
- 4.82** This is a quote from Alain de Botton. I think he runs School of Life. I think that's what it's called. But he wrote this great book, *Status Anxiety*. Here he discusses the way that status can act as a form of relief during periods of intense suffering. He says, "Provided it is not accompanied by humiliation, discomfort can be endured without complaint. Soldiers and explorers willingly tolerated privations exceeding those suffered by the

poorest of their societies, sustained by the awareness of the esteem in which they were held by others." He's suggesting here that, despite material deprivation, despite intense physical suffering, the knowledge that they would be praised by others, the knowledge that their status would be, that status would be conferred upon them by others, was enough to sustain them through these experiences.

4.83 Then we'll close here with a brief discussion of pride. Pride is an adaptive emotion in response to receiving status, and it motivates us to strive to attain it. This is an expression that I think anyone can recognize, that when people receive admiration, respect, especially prestige, that they respond with pride. There are two facets of pride. We're going along, there seems to be two of everything. Well, there are two kinds of pride. There's authentic pride, which rests on valid accomplishment, things that you are aware you've done, that you're secure in, that others know that you've done as well. It's associated with being outgoing, friendly, communal, having good relationships. Authentic pride seems to result from acquiring prestige, pursuing the prestige route of status.

4.84 Then there's hubristic pride, which isn't necessarily based on anything solid. It seems to be associated with hostility, manipulateness, people who appear to be very confident in themselves. But then if you challenge them on it, they suddenly fall apart or they get angry with you because on some level, they're aware that their pride actually has no foundation. These people tend to be interested in achieving status through the dominance route.

4.85 So we'll close here with a final quote of this lecture with Bertrand Russell, a callback to the earlier quote by Caesar. "You may envy Napoleon." So this is Bertrand Russell. "You may envy Napoleon, but Napoleon envied Caesar, Caesar envied Alexander, and Alexander envied Hercules, who never existed. You can get away from envy by avoiding comparisons with those you imagine, perhaps falsely, to be more fortunate than yourself."

4.86 And so we spend a lot of our time engaged in upward social comparisons. So Napoleon is envying Caesar, who envied Alexander. So we're always looking upward. "Who's doing better than me? How do I compare to those who are even more accomplished, wealthier, higher status, and so on?" But in a way, I think this quote, you could interpret it as understanding that the people that are above you may not be as fortunate as you think.

4.87 But then also, related to that point, thinking about those who aren't doing as well as you. There are a lot of people—there's this idea of downward social comparison, too, that you can recall and be grateful for your position when you start to think of those who are less fortunate.

Lecture 5: Status Games

At a glance — Status games.

- 5.1 Good morning. So, before we get into the content of this specific lecture, I wanted to follow up on something I was speaking about yesterday. A thought occurred to me that I probably wouldn't say if I were delivering this lecture at Cambridge or Yale or some of these other elite institutions. And this is something that's mostly speculation on my part, but this idea of the importance of mate selection, women being choosier than men.
- 5.2 I think this could potentially be this idea of mate evaluation. One reason why there's been this push over the last few decades among women in particular, and especially among sort of women in higher social, like the higher end of the socioeconomic scale, why they've been interested in entering historically male spaces, male organizations, universities, occupations, and so on. My speculation is that women, on some level, may want to become closer to these men in order to more closely evaluate the quality of these men. So by entering these spaces, they can get a more sort of honest and reliable evaluation of these men, observe their interactions with one another, perhaps more accurately discern the potential mate quality of these men.
- 5.3 And this isn't to say this is a conscious decision. Remember, a lot of this is—these are sort of ultimate explanations as opposed to proximate explanations. And a lot of this may be sort of implicit unconscious, sort of an unconscious evolutionary impulse dressed up in the language of our time, access and inclusion and so on. Just speculation. But, you know, something that had occurred to me.
- 5.4 So, OK, we're going to divide this lecture into roughly two halves. First, we'll discuss social status as it relates to stories and plot lines, and then we'll discuss status games or arenas of competition in which people compete to attain social esteem. So, in his excellent book, *On the Origin of Stories*, Brian Boyd—he's actually a professor of literature, but he's well informed on the research on evolutionary psychology—in this book, he says, "Humans naturally pursue status with ferocity. We all relentlessly, if unconsciously, try to raise our own standing by impressing peers, and naturally, if unconsciously, evaluate others in terms of their standing."
- 5.5 And so this book is about sort of how you can read fictional stories through the lens of evolution and evolutionary psychology. But why would a professor of literature care about the evolutionary, or reading stories through an evolutionary framework? Well, we could think about the purpose of stories. What do stories do? They impart useful knowledge. They serve as entertainment. They promote social cohesion. And how do they do this? How do they do those three things? Primarily through holding the attention of the status trajectory of the protagonist. This is how the classic plot line

goes, where you follow one protagonist throughout the course of a story and see what they do, the obstacles they overcome, and so on.

- 5.6** Many people are familiar with this idea of the hero's journey, originally developed by Joseph Campbell in this book, *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*, although he drew on a lot of work from Carl Jung and Otto Rank and Eric Neumann and several other sort of these old-school psychoanalysts. And so Campbell's idea of the hero's journey—he examined old stories from a variety of different cultures, Arthurian tales from England, indigenous folk tales from various small-scale societies, and more modern tales from the 20th century when he was writing.
- 5.7** And so here's sort of an adaptation of the hero's journey in *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*. This is sort of a modern revised version of first, the hero is in the ordinary world. They're sort of doing mundane tasks. They're sort of stuck in whatever rut they're in. They're doing nothing in particular, nothing extraordinary. Suddenly there's this call to adventure, and then the plot begins, although initially there tends to be this sort of refusal of the call. They don't actually want to go on this adventure at first. There's a sort of pressure, this unwillingness to go through, but often external circumstances intervene, and then they have to go on this adventure, anyway.
- 5.8** And then, of course, they meet the mentor. They begin to actually enter what is called the special world. And this is when the plot line really enters full swing, the sort of second and third acts of the story, where they run into adversaries where they have to overcome serious obstacles. The whole idea here is that there's this kind of symbolic death and rebirth, and in some stories, there's an actual literal death and rebirth of the hero as they learn that they can overcome these immense obstacles.
- 5.9** And so Christopher Booker did an interesting sort of Jungian analysis of story plot lines in his book, *The Seven Basic Plots*. And in his book he writes—you can see, I read these on Kindle. Some people are telling me now, "You should get your books in print version because the regime, they're going to be updating all of these books." Isn't there a story with Roald Dahl? Didn't they censor some of the content of his books? But for now, I'm still using Kindle for some of my readings.
- 5.10** "So early in our lives, most of us became familiar with a story which ran something like this." And this is Christopher Booker's concise version of the hero's journey. "Once upon a time, there was a young hero heroine, not yet embarked on adult life, living in lowly and difficult circumstances." This is kind of, you know, the ordinary world.
- 5.11** "This humble little figure, almost certainly an orphan, was regarded as of little worth by most people around and may even have been actively maltreated. But one day something happened to send our hero or heroine out into the world where they met a series of adventures which eventually brought about a miraculous transformation of their fortunes. Emerging from the shadows of the wretched former state, they were raised to a position of dazzling splendor, winning the admiration of all who beheld

them. The hero won the hand in marriage of the beautiful princess. The heroine won the love of a handsome prince. They succeeded to rule over a kingdom. And from that day forth, they lived happily ever after."

- 5.12** And so that's sort of emerging from the wretched state into the dazzling splendor. This is a sort of symbolic death and rebirth idea. There's a movie called *Death Wish*. This is not a good movie, but it gets at this idea. A lot of these stories, they start from—the protagonist of the story starts from a position of low status. And then through the process, sometimes they even sort of fall into an even deeper pit, even lower status before eventually rising up in this sort of classic hero's journey tale into a position of high status. And following that trajectory is what holds the audience's attention. We're deeply interested in the dynamics of status shifts, especially for protagonists that we sympathize with.
- 5.13** So the *Death Wish*. I couldn't put the tagline up here, but the tagline, it goes something like, "They came for his family, now he's coming for them." So it's like the first part, low status. They came for his family. Oh, but he's coming for them. OK, high status. Now he's coming.
- 5.14** OK, so contours of story plots. This is—so Campbell wrote his book. I think it was published in the 1940s, but now more recent sort of big data, machine learning, all these kinds of recent developments in how stories can be analyzed. So there was this study, this finding. They did a sentiment analysis, which is basically an analysis of how the emotional content of a story, essentially sentiment analysis, emotional content of a story, of 112,000 plots from books, movies, video games, and so on. I think they even looked at commercials.
- 5.15** And the punchline, the main conclusion, was that if we had to summarize the average story that humans tell, it would go something like this. Things get worse and worse until, at the last minute, they get better. And this is kind of that transition of status, the status of the protagonist. They're low status. Maybe they become lower status. And then they sort of gradually ascend, symbolic death and rebirth, into a higher state.
- 5.16** And so this is the pattern here. And of course, it's not all on their own. There's their own effort, their moral character, the mentorship of others, the ability to form strong alliances. And this pattern—Will Storr, he wrote a great book called *The Science of Storytelling*. He suggests that many people, we feel that we are low in status. This is why this status trajectory of the hero's journey is so intuitively appealing, and why you find it cross-culturally, universally, is that most people feel that we have less status than we should. And so we can easily identify with a protagonist in that kind of state.
- 5.17** But just like a hero in these stories, we feel that we—our real selves—we secretly possess skills, the moral character, the ability, the value of someone who should have more. We're not, we're not accorded the status that we're actually due. And this is true no matter our level of actual privilege. You know, our objective privilege, no matter

where we are in life, we tend to engage in this kind of upward social comparison, which we've talked about in previous lectures rather than downward. We don't think so much about the people beneath us. We're constantly looking upward—most people—and wondering, "Why does that person get that and not me?"

- 5.18** In that book, *The Science of Storytelling*, Will Storr, you know, he describes how even, even British royalty, they'll sort of gossip among one another and say, like, "So-and-so has a bigger garden, or so-and-so has a bigger house." Despite the fact that they are sort of objectively well-off and held in high esteem, they're constantly looking at one another or people who they perceive to be above them. And so when we see a story of someone who is sort of clearly someone is in a lower status position than we believe that they should be, we sympathize, we find them appealing, and we want them to succeed.
- 5.19** And we're also predisposed to dislike—well, we're predisposed to dislike cruelty in general. But if you combine that with high status, the same individual who's both cruel and higher status, that really annoys us. And that tends to be the primary hallmark of a good villain, someone who's in a high position, who's also evil, someone who has more status than they should. So the protagonist has less status than they should, the adversary has more status than they should.
- 5.20** And this is actually the story antagonist's, the most common flaw in these kinds of stories—that the antagonist is already generally in a pretty high status position, and they want dominance at the expense of others, and they abuse the power that they already have in order to attain even more. And so when the low status protagonist finally triumphs over the high status villain, we cheer. We feel vindicated. We ourselves feel as if we have perhaps triumphed ourselves.
- 5.21** So the psychoanalyst Bruno Bettelheim wrote *The Uses of Enchantment*, and he analyzed fairy tales. One of his points in this book is that one of the main challenges of a fairy tale writer is to arouse the listener's sympathy. How do you get people to actually sympathize with the protagonist in a story? Blake Snyder in *Save the Cat*, who's a modern —so he's a screenwriting expert in Hollywood. He wrote this book, *Save the Cat*, and he suggests that the moment—the ability to arouse the listener's sympathy relies on one of two things. The protagonist has to either do something good or be the victim of some kind of misfortune.
- 5.22** And so in addition to being a low status protagonist, it also helps if the protagonist has strong moral character or if they're actively mistreated. I think that this is an interesting point here, and we'll talk more about this. There's a recent idea developed over the last couple of years by a psychologist called the virtuous victim effect, where people are naturally inclined to sympathize with people who have been mistreated. And we tend to evaluate them as having strong moral character, not because of anything they've done, but rather because of how they themselves have been treated.

- 5.23 And so this gets us to this quote from Wilt Chamberlain, this idea of, like, do we—this idea of the underdog, the low status protagonist, how we track their status trajectory. Wilt Chamberlain, the legendary NBA player, said, "Nobody roots for Goliath." He himself was Goliath. He's one of the tallest players, one of the best players. But he sort of lamented the fact that people, people didn't always give him the amount of support that he thought he should deserve because he was great at the game, but he was also visibly so much bigger than others. Is this true, though? Do we always root for the underdog? The hero's journey idea suggests that we do, but there are some exceptions to this. It kind of depends whether we root for the underdog or not.
- 5.24 So there was a study published. Let's see, this was just a few years ago. Well, no, this was 2008, so 15 years ago. This is an interesting study. It's the only study I know on this question about when people root for the underdog versus the overdog. And essentially, in the absence of anything at stake, when people are just asked—so in this study, they asked people, they sort of pit two different entities together, saying, "So here's a small business, a mom-and-pop shop, and here's a large, powerful corporation. Which one of these would you like to prevail or make more sales?" And so on. Generally, if you just put that question to people, they'll naturally side with the small business.
- 5.25 If you ask about an established artist who's already very famous and an up-and-coming young artist, and they're both entering a competition, if you ask people, "Who would you like to win?", generally people say, "I want the up-and-coming artist to win." But then when you say, "Well, who would you bet money on to win? Who would you bet money on to win, the corporation or the mom-and-pop shop? Would you bet on the up-and-coming artist or the established artist who's already won a lot of other art competitions?" And in this case, when material interests are at stake, when physical interests are at stake, too—there were other cases of, like, "Who would you like to support you in various circumstances, the underdog or the overdog?" In this case, people root for the overdog.
- 5.26 So I find that to be interesting. Once people sort of have something on the line, when there's some skin in the game, then we're not always so enchanted with the underdog. Or maybe we are, but our interests, our priorities, shift. So I mentioned the virtuous victim effect. So this is the idea—the way that they did this, I thought it was kind of an interesting approach that they used, where essentially, all they did was tell people in one of the studies, they just said, "Here's a person who had their iPad stolen." That's all it was, compared to someone who didn't have their iPad stolen. One person had something stolen, the other one was not victimized.
- 5.27 And subsequently, people evaluated the person who had the item stolen as being a more moral person, sort of elicited sympathy. They assumed that this person had stronger moral character. And so people seemed to be inclined to positively evaluate those who have suffered. And I think this is why, generally speaking, we tend to root for

the underdog when we consume stories, especially if the protagonist has been maltreated.

- 5.28** There's this idea of audience sympathy, which I think gets at this virtuous victim effect. So Blake Snyder, who I mentioned earlier, said you can arouse audience sympathy either by getting the protagonist to do something good, or you can arouse it by having the protagonist be maltreated. I think this works even for certain kinds of antihero dramas. So I have the example of *Mulan*. She does something good for her father. She sort of takes his place in this movie and puts herself at great risk so that her elderly father wouldn't have to suffer.
- 5.29** But then even in these sort of morally ambiguous prestige dramas, like *The Sopranos* or *Breaking Bad*—I think *Breaking Bad* did this masterfully. I mean, Walter White, by the end of that show, was a monster. But you were along for the ride because, the very beginning of that show, Walter White is depicted as a financially struggling schoolteacher. He has a son who has, I think, multiple sclerosis or some kind of a physical ailment. He works part-time at a car wash. And you see at one point, he's sort of down, like, literally down, you know, physically down, scrubbing a tire of a car. And his high school students are walking by, snapping photos, making fun of him and saying, "Wow, you know, you have to wash cars?" Like, you know, kind of laughing at him.
- 5.30** And naturally, as an audience member, you see this and you feel bad for the guy. And now you can slowly come to understand how he, how he makes his subsequent decisions that put a lot of people in great harm. My guess is that if those scenes had been removed and you hadn't seen him struggling and hadn't seen him in this sort of low status position, you wouldn't have been as interested in the story, and the audience members wouldn't have been so understanding of his actions.
- 5.31** So what else predicts interest in stories? Well, so these kind of classic stories seem to rely on action on the part of the protagonist. There was this book, *The Bestseller Code*, in which they used machine learning—and similar to the other study I cited on sentiment analysis—and they ran books that made the bestseller list versus those that didn't. And they found that active words like "do," "need," and "want" appear more often in bestselling novels compared to those that don't. And then there are terms like "dislike," "suppose," and "wish" that appear more often in non-best sellers. And the idea here seems to be that people are attracted to stories in which protagonists make things happen rather than just having things happen to them.
- 5.32** And this often happens, you see, in the hero's journey stories. They often start with the external world intruding in on them and they're forced to make decisions. But then after that, once the story really gets going, they start to have to make crucial decisions. And I think this can often explain, even in movies, which movies tend to do well versus those that don't. I mean, Marvel and superhero movies, these protagonists really sort of make decisions. They take action. You really sort of see visibly the protagonist actively doing things and desiring things and going after them, rather than sort of

dithering and kind of that kind of movie where it's more sort of introspective. They may be more popular with cultural elites and certain audience segments, but for mass appeal, there has to be some action to get them interested in a protagonist and in a story.

- 5.33** There's a paper that was published a couple of years ago from Manvir Singh, who's an anthropologist, and he developed this idea of the sympathetic plot, that human minds are configured to learn and cooperate and sympathize. We've talked a bit about this, about how humans are basically wired to get along and get ahead. And so this is—the people that we want to form our relationships with, we want to form friendships with people who are mostly interested in getting along. And so this explains some of our interest in stories and which protagonists we find appealing. He suggests that these kind of hero's journey stories—Manvir Singh suggests that hero's journey stories exploit these mechanisms.
- 5.34** So remember, people watch stories to learn how to overcome obstacles. We watch heroes work hard and prevail. And even if the obstacle is not relevant to our own lives, like, taking out Thanos is not something that any of us will ever have to do. But watching the heroes do it, it's inspiring, it's uplifting, and to just sort of see—we want to know that when we encounter obstacles in our own life, that we would be able to overcome them too. We also want to form social relationships with these kinds of appealing people. And recall that when we form first impressions of other people, much of the variance in terms of how we evaluate people relies on moral character and competence. Those are the things that we tend to look at when we are making our decisions about or forming impressions of others.
- 5.35** Heroes are typically both. They typically are competent and communal. And even if they start out kind of incompetent in their low status positions, you'll often see that gradually they attain competence through mentorship and through the sort of trials of the story. And they tend to be communal. They tend to have strong moral character. They bond and get along with others. And we want them to succeed because we naturally want to help worthy people. And we see heroes suffer these setbacks, often they'll fail early on in the story, and this gets us to walk on and hope that they'll prevail.
- 5.36** I think this gets us to this idea of parasocial relationships. There were a couple of studies during the lockdown on this, that they were sort of tracking loneliness and people were sort of cooped up in their houses. And they found that, relative to people who had little contact with other people, those who maintained ties, whether through Zoom, face chats, regular phone calls, they didn't seem to suffer much in terms of loneliness. But they also found that people who consumed a lot of media, especially sort of binge-watching TV shows, they also reported relatively little loneliness. And they suggest that the parasocial relationship, this idea of having a relationship with someone who is not really having a relationship with you back, that this may mitigate loneliness.

- 5.37 Now, these were sort of short-term studies. My guess is this might work in the short term, maybe on a scale of months, but in terms of years, I don't know that consuming television shows over time would sort of be as satisfying as having relationships with real people. But I haven't seen the sort of long-term longitudinal studies. These were just a couple of studies published, I think, at the end of 2020. OK, so that's the sort of the sympathetic plot, this idea that we sort of sympathize with the protagonist on their journey, and we sort of form this relationship with them. We think of them as someone we could potentially be friends with, and we want to succeed.
- 5.38 So continuing on this idea of stories and status, there's a nice quote here from Sigmund Freud. He wrote this essay in 1908 called *Creative Writers and Day-Dreaming*. And he suggests here that—so he's talking specifically about creative writers. "He understands how to work over his daydreams in such a way as to make them lose what is too personal in them and repel strangers and to make it possible for others to share in the enjoyment of them. He has thus achieved through his fantasy what originally he had achieved only in his fantasy—honor, power, and the love of women."
- 5.39 And what he means here is that often if you listen to people tell you their dreams or their daydreams, it's kind of dull, it's kind of boring. Often, if they tell you what's going on when they're daydreaming, Freud suggests, you'd be repelled. You'd be disgusted by them. But what the creative writer does, Freud suggests, is transform those thoughts, maybe some of them, twisted into a story, into a novel or maybe a movie. And in that process, the creative writer may be daydreaming, that, "Oh, maybe someday I can achieve power and honor and the love of women." Well, through the process of converting those thoughts into actual content, into stories, into things that people may enjoy—and depersonalizes them to make them lose what is too personal in them—then people will find them appealing.
- 5.40 And this gets, to some extent, to this idea of stories. So we've been talking about stories themselves, protagonists on the status trajectory. But the motivation behind why people write stories in the first place, the evolutionary motive, that is. So Freud seems to have been right. So more recent research, empirical research, suggests that poets and artists who have been published or exhibited had more sexual partners than those who produced as a hobby or not at all. And it's important here to remember the proximate versus ultimate distinction.
- 5.41 So the author of that specific study, he notes here that "the tendency to turn one's current preoccupations into imaginative writing have persisted because of sexual selection. Not that mating is the preoccupation of those who write." So it's more so that writers have this, or creatives have just this sort of urge to produce things. And then as a consequence, people are attracted to them, and then they sort of carry their genes forward. They're mating through finding more partners, rather than the creative themselves thinking, "Oh, I'll have more surviving offspring if I create things."

- 5.42 I think even that motivation alone, I mean—I guess I've heard interviews with musicians who say that when they started their band, "Yeah, maybe we'll get some girls." But it's often either, it's sort of a second thought, sort of a secondary thing. They just really love music. They really wanted to play. They wanted to get with their boys, you know, whatever it is, and rock out. They didn't necessarily think like, "Oh, we're just, we're going to become super famous this way." I don't think that kind of mating motivation is powerful enough to sustain you, especially when, most of the time, most creatives, most creatives don't go anywhere in their careers.
- 5.43 And so, yes, the reason why people produce creative art is not the same reason as how creativity evolved in the first place. And that's the, that's the sort of ultimate versus proximate distinction why people produce creative art. That's sort of the proximate in the moment. Why do you want to do this? "I love the music. I love to paint." But then why did creativity evolve in the first place? It sort of signals underlying attractive qualities about a person that will garner them more sort of social allies and romantic partners.
- 5.44 And so it's not just stories that seem to garner status for storytellers. Language itself, the medium through which stories are conveyed—it also seems to be tied to status. So there was a book from Jean, I think it's Jean-Louis Dessalles. I hope I'm pronouncing that name right. I think he's a French cognitive scientist, and he wrote this book, *Why We Talk*. And one of the questions he asks in that book is, "What is the purpose of language?" There are multiple purposes, but one that he suggests is that communication itself serves as a signal of one's intelligence, their willingness to get along, to say impressive things, their level of knowledge, and so on.
- 5.45 And he asks—a lot of people think that language is to communicate useful information. One popular idea is that it's just to impart knowledge, and that is true. But then he asks, "But why is it that people, why would people communicate at all in the first place? Then why not just keep that useful knowledge to yourself? Why are people so interested in communicating and speaking?" And often the content of our language doesn't actually carry much useful information.
- 5.46 And so the idea here is that it's actually the listeners who are evaluating the speaker, and they assess the quality of the speech. They want to know what you know, and then they reward the speaker with status if they say things that are useful or interesting or entertaining. And in the book, the author notes that most language is ordinary, but the cost is low, with high potential upside. So most language doesn't carry anything particularly interesting, if you think about small talk or idle chatter. But he suggests that speaking is relatively low cost and the odds of sort of winning status the more you speak can explain how it evolved in this way.
- 5.47 Think of like a penny slot machine. Each time you speak, you're just putting a penny in a slot. It's relatively low cost to you. But the upside of potentially saying something that might be interesting is so high. That's one reason why language may have evolved.

- 5.48** So that's one argument for language. Another, and these aren't mutually exclusive, but Robin Dunbar has suggested specifically about ordinary language, not impressive language. Robin Dunbar, the evolutionary psychologist at Oxford, suggests that language is essentially the equivalent of grooming behavior among primates. One of his findings, him and his colleagues—just pretty interesting that most grooming among primates, it's not done for the purposes of hygiene. They're not actually doing it—most of the time, when they're grooming each other, they're not actually removing insects. What grooming is is social bonding. It's about affiliation. It's about sort of testing out "who's my friend, who's my ally, who's my enemy?"
- 5.49** Who grooms who is an indicator of status, too. Apes that are being groomed tend to be higher status than the apes that are doing the grooming. You can sort of assess the hierarchy in that way to see who's doing the grooming versus who's receiving it. And so what Dunbar suggests is that the way that humans bond is through speaking as well. So most speaking isn't done for the purposes of communicating useful information. It's rather, in the same way, to test social bonds, to build communal relationships, to sort of see where you stand with another person.
- 5.50** Even simple things, like in American culture, we'll say, like, "Hey, how are you?" And you're not really saying, like, "How are you physically doing?" Or mentally or whatever. What you're really asking is, "How are we?" Like, how do you feel about me? Will you say, "Good"? Will you ask me back? And if the person just walks by and doesn't say anything, or they'll just say, "Hi," and not say anything, this sort of tells you where you stand, especially if it happens consistently. And so this sort of seemingly empty content of much of language actually carries information about the relationship between you and the other person. And so Dunbar suggests that this is small talk, idle chatter. This is sort of human grooming.
- 5.51** OK, so public speaking and the Yerkes-Dodson law. So public speaking is a unique one. And so the book that I mentioned earlier, *Why We Talk: The Evolutionary Origins of Language*, he discusses how—the author of the book discusses how public speaking is kind of unique in that, in the ancestral environment, anyone who engaged in public speaking was essentially making a bid for status. And if you recall, hunter-gatherers are extremely sensitive to people who try to self-promote or brag too much. And so he suggested the reason why public speaking may be so anxiety-inducing.
- 5.52** I don't know if this is true, but I once heard, more than once—there's this popular survey going around that people fear public speaking more than death. People have heard this, right? I don't know if that's actually true or if that's just one of the things that people say with no—anyway, but it is true, often. Especially for new public speakers, they feel anxious. They feel this physiological response to it. So because, in the ancestral environment, if you were trying to capture everyone's attention all at once, essentially the idea here is, "You think you're so important, then you're talking to all of us at once. Well, it better be good." And people are sort of, they're

physiologically, intuitively aware of this. And this is why blood pressure raises and all those things, is because they're aware that this is a high-stakes interaction.

- 5.53** And so the Yerkes-Dodson law. This is a separate line of work which basically finds that there's an optimal level of stress for public speaking and for public performance in general, such that if your stress is too low, then your performance tends to be low as well. You're sort of low energy, lack of focus, uninterested. Having too little stress can be detrimental. But when you have a sort of medium, moderate level of stress, that can actually enhance performance. It makes you a bit more focused, a bit more attentive, a bit more alert. But then when your stress gets too high, then it can be self-defeating and you sort of have an intense physiological reaction and your performance suffers as a result. So a bit of anxiety, a bit of stress can be optimal.
- 5.54** But the whole reason, the whole purpose of anxiety before public speech appears to be associated with concerns about status, specifically in the ancestral environment. And again, I've mentioned this, I think, a couple of times in these lectures, that physiologically, our bodies, the way that we evolved, our minds, our mental adaptations—they were shaped in an environment very different than the ones that we live in today. Culture evolution, technology, all these things evolved much faster than our bodies did. And so we're sort of designed, so to speak—our bodies are intended for those kind of small-scale communities, those kind of small-scale societies.
- 5.55** And so a lot of our minds, our bodies, our psychologies, there's a sort of mismatch between our environments that we live in now and the environments that we evolved in. So I talked about this. Grooming isn't only about hygiene. It's about bonding, relationship building, coalition forming. And this could, this seems to be why humans engage in small talk, a sort of idle chatter, sort of checking in with people, seeing how they're doing. And again, that's not to say that language also doesn't carry useful information. It serves both purposes.
- 5.56** OK, so we're going to transition now into status games. Much of the remainder of this lecture will be based on this book that just came out two years ago. Will Storr, whose name I mentioned before. It's a good book. Will Storr is a friend of mine. He and I spoke as he was working on this book. He spoke with a variety of other researchers and psychologists and interesting people. We're just going to speak about just a couple of points from this book.
- 5.57** Will Storr suggests there are three status games. There's dominance, which we've spoken about a bit—dominance in terms of the avenues toward status—bullying and coercion, and the threat of inflicting costs. Then there are virtue games. This is sort of attaining status through moral grandstanding, through some people would call this virtue signaling or just sort of demonstrating your goodness, competitive altruism, displays of kindness. And then there are success games.

- 5.58 I think virtue and success games are probably more associated with prestige, the prestige route to status, especially success. Good virtue as well. Remember, prestige is about what the high status individual can do for you. What benefits can they confer to you? And that's why we sort of accord them status, because of those benefits. And so, yeah, I just wanted to put this note on games here that we call them games. It's not meant to trivialize. Games, you can think of them as sort of ritualistic, predictable interactions. Right? But it's not meant to say that this is as simple or as unimportant as a board game. These are important phenomena. It's important to understand them, I think.
- 5.59 And then, OK, so just a couple of notes about dominance. Dominance games are generally not great. We'll get into some dominance games and how they're not always bad. You may need a bit of dominance in certain contexts. Virtue seems to be OK in moderation, but when it spirals out, which we'll talk about later, this can actually sort of backfire and create problems. And then success games appear to be the most sustainable, more iterative over time, most likely to last.
- 5.60 So, dominance games. This is the original status game we've talked about already, that you see dominance games in the animal kingdom. Humans, to some extent, still practice dominance games. And so today you'll see dominance games played out in mafias and street gangs and armies and sort of brute displays of violence, or the potential for violence is how you attain status in a dominance game. But interestingly, we talked about the self domestication hypothesis and the execution hypothesis as well, that humans, ironically enough, we sort of killed our way out of dominance games, where we sort of repeatedly murdered bullies over and over to the point that we became more docile, more compliant, more cooperative and domesticated. So this series of sort of violent actions led to a sort of peaceful, relatively peaceful state that we're in today.
- 5.61 In the book that I mentioned earlier in that lecture on the self-domestication hypothesis, *The Goodness Paradox*, Wrangham also talks about other animals that have undergone this process of domestication. He speaks about dogs, for example. Dogs are far more peaceful than wolves. And the reason for that is because over time, humans, humans bred them into being nice. And anytime one of these animals became violent or vicious or attacked you or didn't love you enough, their owners would just kill them. And then we sort of turned these animals into loving creatures and we sort of did that to ourselves. That's the idea.
- 5.62 OK, so gradually, dominance games, or dominance route to status, shifted to the opinions of others, more so to prestige. But, so Will Storr notes in the book, "The human expectation that social status can be seized through brute force and intimidation, that the strongest and the biggest and boldest will lord it over the rank and file, is very old, awesomely intuitive, and deeply ingrained. Its younger rival, prestige, was never able to dislodge dominance from the human mind."

- 5.63 So the idea here is that we don't like bullies. We don't like people who attempt to coerce others into doing what they want. But at the same time, we're often very responsive to it. We find it strangely compelling. And it does seem to be sort of intuitive to some degree. We respond to bullies in a certain way, especially when we don't feel that we have sufficient social support. It seems to still sort of exist in our mind. And we intuitively understand that someone who's strong and powerful and aggressive, that they do often get their way, especially if their victims are unable to sort of unite and retaliate.
- 5.64 And so, yeah, a bit more in dominance games. So, like I said, mafias, street gangs, militaries —the vast majority of the perpetrators in those kinds of dominance games are male. Male soldiers, male gang members, male mafiosis, young guys killing one another. And, yeah, we talked about the age crime curve and how the propensity for violence and aggression tends to peak in the late teens, early 20s. And that kind of aggression, these dominance games, they seem to be a leading cause of homicide.
- 5.65 So Wilson and Daly and others have documented what actually leads to murders. Most of the time, it's young men killing other young men, altercations over trivial disputes, often disputes over respect, which is, we've talked about respect as kind of a synonym for status, and disrespect. And so dominance games among men tend to be sort of around verbal or physical aggression. For women, women partake in dominance games, too. They tend to be more indirect, more sort of focused on verbal rather than the physical, reputation destruction, gossip, innuendo, and so on. We talked about the "bless her heart" effect and sort of speaking in such a way that your words can convey multiple meanings.
- 5.66 And so people might ask, "Why do women participate in overt physical dominance games less?" Well, that's because women are—essentially, they're biologically the more valuable sex. The species would very quickly perish if women suddenly became very interested at a young age, at the peak fertile years, if women suddenly became very interested in taking dangerous risks and dying. You know, whatever, you know, whatever we think of the sort of fertility crisis now would become much worse.
- 5.67 It's possible that in the ancestral environment, there were women who were very interested in taking risks and fighting and getting into disputes and maybe going along and raiding other villages and so on. They died before they could have children. It was the women who played it safe, who were calm, who were cautious, who weren't that interested in physical aggression—those are the ones who survived and managed to have children and rear them into adulthood. And so those genes were carried forward. And women today sort of behave in that way, whereas for young men, they could go off and beat each other up and kill each other and so on, and yet still sort of have the time to maybe engage in a couple of acts of mating and have some kids before they perished. And so, and this is why we see that pattern today.

- 5.68** Virtue games. The virtue games, like I mentioned before, it's about displaying generosity, competitive altruism, philanthropy. I mentioned the buried signals idea before—why some donors choose to remain anonymous. So today this takes the form of people sort of compete in virtue games, in religious institutions, in maybe nonprofits, NGOs, in activism, universities and media, maybe. Although today, interestingly, it seems like even corporations are trying to get in on the virtue game, trying to signal their support for political or moral stances, often even at the cost of what is ostensibly their goal, which is to increase their profits. Sometimes it seems like they're willing to lose profit in order to play these virtue games. They're sort of paying in order to win one of these kinds of games.
- 5.69** So, more on virtue games. There was a study published just a few years ago on this idea of moral grandstanding. And it was later published in a book called Grandstanding by Justin Tosi and Brandon Warmke. And the idea here —well, the definition of grandstanding: "The use of public moral discourse for self-promotion and status attainment." So it's important here to say that just because people are making moral proclamations and so on, it doesn't necessarily mean they're doing it for the purpose of self-promotion. But some people do. Some people are sort of cynical and duplicitous, and they're willing to use moral discourse to advance their own agenda and increase their own status.
- 5.70** So people who answer these kinds of questions, people who very much agree with these kinds of statements, "When I share my moral political beliefs, I do so to show people who disagree with me that I am better than them." So if you say extremely agree, chances are, you know, you would score high on this sort of moral grandstanding scale. "When I share my moral political beliefs, I do so in the hope that people different than me will feel ashamed of their beliefs." So someone who says they extremely agree with that statement would be likely to score high on moral grandstanding. So those are a couple of the sample items.
- 5.71** So it's—yeah, so this is a nonpartisan phenomenon. Republicans and Democrats are both equally likely to grandstand. This is sort of equal participation here. But extremists on both sides are more likely to grandstand there. They're the most likely to grandstand. And people who are sort of more moderate or more centrist are sort of in the middle. They're less likely to partake in those kinds of activities, of trying to shame other people for their beliefs or broadcasting their beliefs to show how much better they are, how much stronger their moral character is, or their views are than others. There's no sort of competitive display of moral goodness.
- 5.72** So grandstanding is associated with other traits, left- and right-wing authoritarianism, or sort of the willingness to coerce other people into adopting or expressing your own political views, the willingness to reshape society into whatever sort of image you would like it to be. It's also associated with status-seeking, which may not be surprising. And then it's also associated with narcissism, especially the antagonistic dimension of

narcissism, or that sort of hostile, confrontational element of it, of willing to say things to enhance your self image.

5.73 OK, so we'll move on to victim signaling now. Yeah, this study. I noticed when this study was published, none of the authors were on Twitter, and perhaps wisely so. Often when researchers post controversial findings on Twitter, they sometimes get some backlash, unkind remarks. They published this. It was in a high-quality journal, JPSP, really a sort of prestigious academic outlet. And so, victim signaling. What do they look at? So, victim signaling is "public and intentional expression of one's disadvantages, suffering oppression, or personal limitations." So you get the idea here.

5.74 I mean, some of the sample items, as I recall, are, "How willing are you to publicly broadcast that you've been mistreated? How likely are you to say that people like you are underrepresented in the media?" Or you like to talk about how beleaguered you are, how many hardships you've suffered. Well, victim signaling—expression of one's disadvantages—strongly correlated with the Dark Triad traits, and it had the strongest link with psychopathy. So people who are higher on this victimhood scale, they were also more likely to cheat in economic games.

5.75 So this study that had multiple different experiments that they looked at, they ran the Dark Triad scale against the victim signaling scale, found a strong correlation. They also had people come into the lab and play these economic games, and the researchers rigged the game. So basically, you could easily cheat if you wanted. It wasn't that hard to cheat in this game. They found that people who scored high on victim signaling were also significantly more likely to cheat in these games, unsurprisingly, because they probably score higher on the Dark Triad traits, the people who are playing these games.

5.76 It's important here to note that it's not that victims are more likely to have Dark Triad traits, not that victims are more likely to be psychopaths or anything like that. It's actually the reverse. It's rather that people who are high on the Dark Triad traits are more likely to feign victimhood. They're more likely to express or make false claims towards being mistreated in order to obtain some kind of material reward. The authors of this paper suggest that in modern Western societies, we have a very—our concern for victims is more pronounced than a lot of other societies. And historically, we have a more sympathetic stance towards victimhood.

5.77 And so people with Dark Triad traits, basically, if you drop them into whatever environment, they're going to see, "OK, so behaving this way, saying those things, those are more likely to get me sort of material, social, professional, sexual rewards. Those are the things I need to do," and then they execute. And the researchers suggest that in modern Western societies, they sort of picked up on, in certain environments, if you pretend to be a victim, you can accrue rewards for this. So, again, it's not that victims are more likely to be, to have Dark Triad traits, but rather people who have Dark Triad traits are more likely to feign victimhood.

- 5.78** And actual victims may be less inclined to broadcast mistreatment, not more. This is my sense, anyway. And there's some interesting research on this, too, about people who've actually been mistreated. Often they feel ashamed or embarrassed or humiliated, and they prefer to withhold some of those experiences. They're not so eager to broadcast them. Whereas people who have Dark Triad traits and who are aware that they can gain some rewards for it, they may be more likely to fabricate or embellish hardships.
- 5.79** And so this gets us to this idea of sort of false positive versus false negative, about whether we should believe every single story of hardship, how careful we should be about scrutinizing these stories. On the one hand, you could lean toward sort of believing everyone, ensure that all victims, anyone who claims victimhood status is cared for. If we do that 100%, anytime anyone says they were mistreated, we immediately believe them and provide care and resources and rewards to them, but then you risk free riders. You risk Dark Triad-types pretending to be victims and sucking up resources that could be better allocated toward people who have actually suffered.
- 5.80** On the other hand, you could be extremely careful about who you believe and sort of carefully scrutinize every single person's story, every single instance of hardship, and carefully screen out the free riders. But in this case, you're going to risk overlooking actual victims. You're going to risk leaning in the opposite direction, in the false negative direction, and people who are actual victims, you're going to be less likely to believe them. And so I think right now in society, we're sort of having this debate play out, not in such explicit terms as this, but we're sort of arguing, "How much should we believe people? Should we believe every instance of hardship? In what cases should we believe victims?" And so on.
- 5.81** And I like this idea of sort of understanding victimhood claims from the stance of false positive versus false negative and which way we should be leaning, because essentially the idea is, it's impossible to know for certain whether every single person who claims hardship is honest. And so we sort of have to make that decision collectively—which way we want to lean.
- 5.82** And so this gets us to this interesting study, this really cool study, I thought, of the logic of aversive medical treatments. So Mícheál de Barra and his colleagues looked at this question of why is it that, historically, medical treatments have been so ugly and aversive? The repulsive medicine, drilling of the skulls and the limbs, amputation, leeches, bloodletting—why has the history of medicine been so gruesome? And often, a lot of these treatments, if you sort of look at the history of medicine, a lot of these treatments have been neutral at best and often ineffective.
- 5.83** And so the idea here is actually to ensure that people were truly sick or injured. So imagine in the ancestral environment, there's a group of guys about to go on a raid to another village. One of the guys says, "Oh, I'm not feeling very well. I have a stomach ache. I'm going to hang back, guys." If everyone understands that if he goes back to the

camp, he is going to have to meet with the medicine man who gives him some really disgusting concoction of plants and mushrooms and whatever it happens to be, and it's going to make him vomit, it's going to make him very sick, very ill—physically, he's going to have to go through an extreme ordeal—he's not just going to be able to hang back and lay down for a bit. He's going to go back and have to take a very, a medicine that will cause him serious pain. Then they're more likely to believe him.

5.84 And so essentially this idea is that, in an ancestral environment of humans, if every single time a person said they weren't feeling well and they didn't have to participate and help the community anymore, then very quickly you'd have a little group of layabouts of everyone claiming to be sick. And so the way around this, the way to sort of enforce cooperation and get people to contribute, is anytime there was someone who claimed that they were sick or injured, and you couldn't necessarily visibly tell that something was going on with them, was to impose the cost of unpleasant medical treatments, such that basically, only a really sick person would say that they were sick, because you know that they're going to have to do something very unpleasant as a result. And so it prevents exploitation by making faking illness more costly.

5.85 And so this may be why cultures have introduced this kind of stigma around victimhood, because if everyone claims that they can't work or they can't contribute in some way, then why wouldn't everyone just claim to do this and stop working altogether? And so cultures have sort of introduced this kind of social technology, these social norms, around victimhood, that, "OK, you can be a victim, you don't have to contribute if you don't want to, but just know you're going to have to pay a cost in terms of your reputation if you want to do that." And so this sort of creates a situation in which people are less likely to claim to be sick or injured or to be a victim.

5.86 So we'll move on to success games now. So success games in the modern world—wealth, education, influence, fame, doing impressive things. In the ancestral environment —doing useful things, navigation, hunting, tool-making, and so on, gathering, child-rearing, having sort of knowledge of wildlife in plants. And this is essentially a sort of a prestige, prestige route to status. Success is determined by whether you can confer benefits to other people. Today, success games are played through promotions, awards, sports championships.

5.87 And I mentioned that this is kind of probably the most sustainable kind of game. Dominance games can be very unstable. Virtue games can quickly spiral out of control. And success games, though—there's trying to compete to earn money and to sort of elevate your position in society. This seems to do sort of less damage overall or seem to have fewer costs than the other two games.

5.88 And so we're going to transition here a bit into signaling versus countersignaling of status. And so this is sort of continuing on this sort of theme of success games. How successful you are determines what kind of signaling game you can play and how the signals that you emit can actually affect the status that you hold already. So

countersignaling is basically self-handicapping. It's doing something that's typically associated with low status, but when a high status person does it, it actually doesn't hurt their status oftentimes. And in certain cases, it can even increase it. It's sort of a signal of confidence. "I'm so high status, I can afford to do this low status thing."

- 5.89** So I like this example. This was from—I borrowed this from the advertising executive Rory Sutherland, who says, "If you work at Pizza Hut and you ride a bike to work, it's probably because you can't afford a car. But if you are a chief executive and you ride a bike to work, it's because it was a choice, because you wanted to." And then it becomes this high status signal. Medium status signal, driving an expensive car. So it's low status, medium status, but then high status can do the low status thing and it doesn't actually damage their status in the same way.
- 5.90** I posted online recently, like the difference in how the items look on menus. If you go to a fast food restaurant, it'll just say "hamburger." If you go to a mid-tier chain like a Red Robin or something, it'll say, "Sizzled USDA-grade beef on a house-made sesame bun." It'll sort of have this long description. And then if you go to an upscale chic restaurant, it just says "hamburger." And so this is a sort of a countersignal of "we're such an upscale, fancy chic restaurant that we don't have to worry about impressing you about how our meat is made and how our buns are baked here." So it's an expression of confidence.
- 5.91** There was a study from my friend Zachary Brown, who analyzed a bunch of PhD dissertation titles and found that students at lower-ranked universities used more sophisticated language in the titles. Essentially, the claim here is that there's this sort of countersignaling such that PhD students at higher-ranked universities didn't feel the need to impress. They didn't feel like, "Oh, I have to, I better use really, really sophisticated language in my dissertation title so that people know I'm smart." The idea is like, "Oh, I'm already at this really fancy university. I don't have to prove that I'm smart." Whereas those at lower-ranked universities feel like a bit more self-consciousness about it.
- 5.92** There was also a study some years ago about professors. Professors at lower-ranked universities were more likely to use their official title in their voicemails. This was back when people still had answering machines in their offices. And at lower-ranked universities, they were more likely to say on their voicemail, "Hello, you've reached Professor so-and-so's office," or "you've reached Doctor so-and-so's office." Whereas at higher-ranked universities, it's more likely to say, you know, "Hey, this is Bill, you know, leave me a message." And the idea there is similar here, that professors at really, really high status universities didn't really feel the need to show off their title.
- 5.93** And so, yeah, there are other examples, simple social, social media bios. One that I really like is J.K. Rowling. So her bio on Twitter, at least last I checked, was "the author formerly known" or no, "the author also known, also known as Robert Galbraith." I don't know if any of you read the Cormoran Strike novels. I think they're superb. Maybe

not quite as good as the Harry Potter series, but I thought that her detective novels—so she writes her novels, her detective novel series—I think it's still ongoing—under this pseudonym, Robert Galbraith. And that's her title. Yeah, here's my other author name.

- 5.94** And then, yeah, casual clothing. You'd see that often higher-ranking executives or higher-ranking people in various organizations will dress in a more casual way. But not everyone can engage in this kind of countersignaling to sort of express confidence in their status. Self-deprecating humor. There was a study from Geoffrey Miller and some others. They found that when a low status person uses self-deprecating humor, people don't like it very much, and often they evaluate that person more negatively. But if a high status person uses self-deprecating humor and makes fun of themselves, essentially mocks themselves or highlights their flaws—a high status person, when they do that, they're actually perceived as more likable. People like them even more.
- 5.95** And so it's important to know whether you should be countersignaling or not. This is similar to the pratfall effect. This is a classic finding in social psychology that people who are seen as too perfect, if they make a mistake, they subsequently become more likable. Here are a couple of other examples of countersignaling. Arriving fashionably late is one. And then, yeah, pronounced humility. Certain people can do this. If you're high up on the status ladder, arriving a bit late can be good. Whereas if you're still sort of early on in your career and you arrive somewhere late, you've actually lost time. You've lost time that you could be building social relationships, seeking profitable opportunities, sort of meeting new people, expanding your social circle, and so on. And then, yeah, pronounced humility, similar to self-deprecating humor, making fun of yourself.
- 5.96** So we'll touch briefly on the dynamics of status ambiguity. This was a book written about two decades ago from the sociologist Roger Gould. He suggested in this book, he makes the case—I thought a pretty compelling case—that status ambiguity or status equivalence is actually more likely to give rise to conflict. So he found, for example, that cross-culturally, homicides are more likely to occur between individuals of equal status. So, for example, even within families, sons are more likely to kill fathers, fathers are more likely to kill sons, same with daughters and mothers, but then also between friends, between colleagues, coworkers, people of the same gender, same sex.
- 5.97** And he also attempted to control for the amount of time spent with individuals. We generally spend more time with people who are similar in status to ourselves. When he controlled for that, there was still this significant difference, that violence and homicides are more likely to break out between individuals of difference—or equal status. So I think there's an analogy here between sort of status and interesting animal research, and human conflict as well.
- 5.98** So animals are actually more likely to fight. So same species, animals are more likely to engage in conflict. You think about chimpanzees or wolves, similar or same species. When are they more likely to fight one another? When they're actually similar in size.

When one animal is much larger than the other, the small animal just backs down immediately. Why risk it, right? They submit instantly, and the conflict never even begins. When two animals are roughly equal in size, and it's a question who would actually prevail in this conflict, that is when violence is more likely to break out between animals.

- 5.99** And it seems that way with humans as well. We talked about the male monkey dance before that, usually it occurs between two young males of roughly equal age and size, even for—there was an amusing study a few years ago about who would sort of give way when walking on a sidewalk. And when two individuals were of roughly equal size, it was sort of like a 50-50, sort of who would give way on a sidewalk first. But when one individual was noticeably larger than the other, the vast majority of the time, the smaller individual gave way. They controlled for sex, too. This is sort of same sex, two people on a narrow sidewalk. The smaller individual almost always gave way to the larger one.
- 5.100** And so the idea here is that, in some cases, status designators ease social relations, sort of knowing in advance who's in charge, who's the boss. There have been some interesting reports and studies about trying to have organizations with no rank or no official titles. And often these quickly sort of spiral into chaos. It's good to know who's accountable for what, who's responsible for what, who's in charge, who makes the final call. And so having these rules, right—the boss decides, or ladies first, or listen to your elders—just having those rules can sort of ease these kinds of interactions.
- 5.101** So you might be asking yourself, well, didn't I say earlier that hunter-gatherer communities are extremely sensitive to people who attain too much status for themselves, that they're mostly egalitarian? There's this sort of emphasis on status equivalency in small-scale human societies, and the answer is, yes, they are. And they're also far more violent than modern societies are. So in the Yanoama Amazonian tribe in South America, something like a quarter of male deaths are due to homicide. So they have this sort of status equivalency. And there's a ton of within-group conflict among them—not as much as primates, chimpanzees, and so on. Humans are more docile.
- 5.102** But because status equivalency is stressed, often there's actually no way to sort of arbitrate between disputes. Sometimes there are elders, sometimes there are big men and chiefs who can help to resolve it. But often when two men get into an argument or a fight, there is no one who can kind of come down and say this, you know, to stop doing this or to resolve the conflict one way or the other. Hunter-gatherer communities are more violent than even the most violent and dangerous cities in the U.S.
- 5.103** OK, so association value. Yeah, I wanted to touch on this. So, yeah, although equal status can create conflict, we do tend to prefer friends who are similar in status to ourselves. You know, part of this is just because, you know, this idea of, this idea of association value, two components. One is, this is about who we are friends with, our

social allies, how much value someone could add to your life, and how willing they are to add value to your life. And when status disparities grow too large between friends, if one friend suddenly ascends into great fame and fortune or something, they may, number 1, may increase the value they could add to your life, maybe increase.

5.104 But number 2, may actually diminish because once they sort of take off and become a superstar or rock star or something, they may have less time. And often you'll find that, among friends, that friendships will often erode over time if one friend rises too high, too quickly, or too low, and so on. Most of our friends tend to be right around our own sort of level of status and situation in our life, and we can get more into that later.

Lecture 6: Luxury Beliefs

At a glance — Luxury beliefs.

- 6.1 OK, so I want to start this lecture by saying a bit about my own background. Here's the cover of my forthcoming memoir. In my book, I describe never knowing my parents, growing up in foster homes in Los Angeles and all around California. I fled as soon as I could when I was 17, enlisting in the military right after high school.
- 6.2 I then attended Yale on the GI Bill, which was a very different environment for me. At Yale, there are more students from families in the top 1% of the income scale than from the entire bottom 60%. There was a bit of a culture shock there, not just because of the economic class divides, but also the social class divides and the cultural class divides as well. And so throughout my experiences traveling along this class ladder, I slowly started to develop this idea of luxury beliefs. And luxury beliefs are ideas and opinions that confer status on the upper class while often inflicting costs on the lower classes.
- 6.3 My claim throughout this lecture will be that luxury beliefs have, to a large extent, have replaced luxury goods. We're going to be concentrating on this idea I've been developing. This framework is bolstered by ideas and findings from several disciplines, including sociology, behavioral economics, and social psychology. But really, the seed of this idea was planted from that culture shock I experienced from spending my life in foster homes in California, and then joining the military and traveling the world, and then entering an elite college campus.
- 6.4 Let's get into the luxury beliefs idea. We'll start with this quote from the 19th century sociologist, Émile Durkheim. He says, "The more one has, the more one wants, since satisfactions received only stimulate instead of filling needs." The puzzle is, is he right? I mean, this is—to some extent, you could think of this as a counterintuitive idea that the more you have, the more you want. Well, there have been two different studies, recent studies, looking specifically at this question, one from 2019, one from 2020, and these two studies obtained the same result. The finding is that, relative to lower class individuals, upper class individuals had the strongest desire for wealth and status.
- 6.5 The researchers took objective measures of wealth and status, things like income, level of education, occupational prestige—these are objective metrics. Then they measured the desire for wealth and status through items. The scale contained items like, "I want my peers to respect me and hold me in high esteem." "I would like to cultivate the admiration of my peers." People who have lots of wealth and status were also more likely to strongly agree with those statements.
- 6.6 Relatedly, another study found that household income in childhood predicts desire for status in adulthood. Essentially, if you grew up in a family that is relatively wealthy, as an adult, odds are you have an especially pronounced desire to obtain status. Now, I

think some of that may be due to your surroundings. If you grew up in an affluent home, an affluent neighborhood, you're surrounded by people who are probably relatively accomplished, who have done well for themselves, and you yourself may start to cultivate this longing to meet those standards. You're around people who are doing well, you want to do well. It raises your sights for yourself and how much status that you want.

- 6.7** But the basic finding, I think, is a little bit counterintuitive. You might expect that people who are relatively low in status would have the strongest desire for wealth and status. The people who are at the bottom of the socioeconomic spectrum who maybe aren't doing so well in life, those would be the people who'd really want wealth and status. They're dispossessed and don't have much, and maybe you would think they would want to climb up and attain those things. But it's actually not the case. It's actually the people who are at or near the apex of the socioeconomic spectrum, the top of the ladder, who want it even more.
- 6.8** I suppose that you could think that makes sense in a way, too. You might think that maybe the causal arrow is such that it's actually the people who have this intrinsic desire for status, that's what motivates them to get to the top of the ladder in the first place. But then once they get there, it doesn't just go away. Once you reach the top of the ladder, the longing for wealth and status doesn't dissipate. It either remains the same or perhaps it even grows stronger because, by that point, you're around people who are highly accomplished, perhaps even more highly accomplished than yourself. This continues to stir this longing.
- 6.9** So that's the punchline here. The more you have, the more you want. The more you grew up with, the more you want. That seems to resolve that puzzle that was Émile Durkheim right? Well, seems like he was.
- 6.10** The second puzzle, what do top hats and defund the police have in common? The idea here being, how have luxury beliefs, or what is the relationship between luxury beliefs and luxury goods? What is the dynamic underlying this? What's changed? I mentioned the definition of luxury beliefs earlier, ideas and opinions that confer status on the upper class, while often inflicting costs in the lower classes. It's funny. I coined this term, and I thought it was something new. Then I started doing a lot of reading and realized the term is mine. I coined the term. The idea underlying it seems to be quite old.
- 6.11** Here's a quote from Adam Smith in *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*. This was more than 200 years ago. Adam Smith wrote, "Vain men often give themselves heirs of a fashionable profligacy, which in their hearts they do not approve of, and of which perhaps they are really not guilty. They desire to be praised for what they themselves do not think praiseworthy and are ashamed of their unfashionable virtues, which they sometimes practice in secret and for which they have secretly some degree of real veneration." We'll unpack a bit of this quote later.

- 6.12** But what is he getting at here is that vain men, people who are self-important, they often adopt beliefs out of the desire for social approval. Often, they'll practice a separate set of habits and customs and virtues in private that they are unwilling to broadcast, perhaps because on some level, they're ashamed of them, but they are also respectful of these beliefs. They think that they are admirable, but they're just unwilling to publicly talk about them. That was Adam Smith.
- 6.13** For me, the whole concept of status symbols, especially luxury goods, it really begins with Thorstein Veblen. He was an economist and sociologist who wrote this book, *The Theory of the Leisure Class*, in 1899. The core idea, the core insight of this book, is that because we can't be certain of the financial status of other people, a good way to determine what their position in society is, is to see whether they can afford to partake in time-consuming and expensive hobbies, whether they can afford expensive material goods. So in his day, in the late 19th century, when he wrote this book, people would wear expensive clothing, tuxedos, and top hats, and evening gowns, pocket watches, and monocles. These were things that ordinary people in his day could not afford.
- 6.14** He even goes so far as to say that butlers are status symbols as well. On the one hand, butlers serve this functional purpose to assist the wealthy person, but he suggests they also keep these butlers around to signal to other wealthy elites that they're among them, they're one of them. They're signaling at one another with their clothing, with their hobbies, with their tastes, with their activities, golf and beagling, and so on and so forth.
- 6.15** These ideas were echoed some decades later by the French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu in his book, *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgment of Taste*. The idea here, Bourdieu coined this term "cultural capital." He suggested that the way that people at the top of the social hierarchy within a society display their status, they have to convert their economic resources into cultural resources, the economic capital into cultural capital. People don't just go around showing one another how much money is in their bank account or what their assets look like. They do it through what you call the dispositions of mind and body, cultural capital.
- 6.16** Only people who don't have to work the life of a manual laborer can spend time learning intricate and expensive hobbies that have no practical utility, or do use this term "distance from necessity." The further you are from reality, from the hardships of everyday life, the more time you can spend on expensive tastes and customs and opinions and habits. So at this point in the mid-20th century, he talks about how the elites of his day, especially in France, they'd learn how to talk about art or about wine or about obscure philosophy or history and so on. To some extent, maybe these ideas had some practical utility, but by and large, a lot of it was in order to demonstrate their high social standing.
- 6.17** In a neat example of scientific consilience around that time in the 1970s, Amotz Zahavi, who 's a biologist, came up with this term "costly signaling," which we've talked about a

bit before. But Zahavi was one of the pioneers of this idea. The idea here is that only—he's talking specifically about animal research. Only healthy animals are able to display certain traits and features about themselves. Only very fit animals can do this. A well-known example is the peacock's tail. Only a healthy peacock can carry around this long, beautiful, burdensome tail around them and display it to the peahens. Only healthy birds can do this, can afford to do this, while managing to evade predators. The idea here is that only a healthy bird can do this, and peahens observe this and are more willing to mate with them.

- 6.18** But a lesser known example is the behavior of healthy adult gazelles. When they spot predators, often they'll engage in this behavior known as stotting. This is a costly signal. They spring vertically into the air with all four of their feet raised. The message that this sends to predators is, unlike these other gazelles, I'm so fit that I can afford to expend valuable energy to show you how strong and robust I am. It's a costly demonstration of their underlying physical strength. So the idea here is that animals engage in costly signaling with their physical capacities, whereas Bourdieu and Veblen suggest that humans engage in costly signaling to signal their economic capacities. How much in the way of resources do they have?
- 6.19** My claim here is that luxury beliefs are akin to fashion. Unlike with biological signals, luxury beliefs and cultural capital, these are subject to decay. They can work for a limited amount of time. You can broadcast certain ideas and opinions and so on. When it spreads, the idea loses a lot of its luster, similar to fashion, to fashionable status symbols. Initially, when a new item of clothing comes out and only a few people are able to afford it or to obtain it when it's scarce, it holds a lot of value.
- 6.20** But then gradually, if fashion companies produce more of the item, if the cost of the item drops, if you start to see it at outlet stores and so on, then it's less impressive. And the tastemakers and the people who have a lot in the way of cultural and material resources will go on and adopt a new look, a new idea, a new article of clothing in order to keep up and to demonstrate their high social positions.
- 6.21** Elites have dealt with fashion and status in different ways. Sumptuary laws. Sumptuary laws have existed in various cultures around the world. In feudal Japan, there was a period where the merchants started to grow wealthier than the aristocratic Samurai. So merchants were middle-tier status. They were not especially well-respected. They weren't as low as the peasants, but they were definitely not seen to be anywhere near as high as the nobility or the aristocratic Samurai. So the Samurai in feudal Japan, these were the aristocrats. And they didn't like it. The Samurai didn't like it, the aristocrats. They didn't like that suddenly merchants were becoming wealthy, and they petitioned for these sumptuary laws to be passed in order to restrict merchants' ability to display their wealth and restricted their ability to purchase silk garments.
- 6.22** "Only the aristocrats should be allowed to wear silk garments, not these vulgar merchants who are hawking their wares and not spending their time practicing martial

arts and reading poetry." This is a quote from a paper documenting this period. "In everything, people have a liking for finery above their station. It is distressing to see a merchant wearing good silks." This was a quote from someone during this period in feudal Japan. Sumptuary laws have been passed in Europe and in other places. The idea here is to prohibit non-elites from obtaining certain goods, whether they're by making the good inordinately pricey, reducing the number, making it intentionally scarce, or just outright passing laws saying, "Hey, if you're not a member of this rarefied social group, you're not allowed to purchase this thing." That's one way to retain the status of an article of clothing or of a luxury good.

- 6.23** Other elites have dealt with the link between fashion and status in a different way. So spices in Europe. Initially, during the spice trade, spices were extremely expensive to obtain. Only the elites could afford them. But gradually, as the Europeans colonized India and the Americas and various geographic regions around the world, spices became more abundant and more available, and suddenly ordinary people in Europe were able to obtain spice. In response, due to the widespread availability of this good, elites in some European countries decided that they were vulgar. And in one notable example, King Louis XIV banned spice from the court kitchens from all dishes except for desserts.
- 6.24** And so they reacted to this. There's this luxury good. Initially it's difficult to obtain. Once everyone can afford it, can acquire it, the elites react and say, "Actually, we're not interested in that anymore." Other examples, in the 18th century and into the 19th century, the proper way for a gentleman to dress or to stand for their portrait, rather, in some countries in Europe, was to, the gentleman, they put their right hand in their waistcoat pocket for their portrait. Then gradually, the middle classes started to have their portraits taken. It became a bit more affordable, more widespread. They started to adopt this position for their portrait. Then the elites abandoned this practice because it became too popular with the masses or with the middle classes at this point.
- 6.25** And dueling in the American colonies. Dueling initially was only practiced by the aristocrats of the American colonies in the 18th century. So, yeah, here's a rendering of Aaron Burr and Alexander Hamilton, during their duel. Initially only practiced by the elites in the colonies, and then gradually this practice spread to the masses, to everyone else. In response, the elites abandoned it, and gradually it was outlawed in the late 19th century. In that case, it was probably good that that dueling was outlawed. But the underlying principle, the dynamic here, is that the elites, they come up with different ways to either retain status for certain kinds of goods, or if it becomes too widely available, they'll abandon it and move on to something else.
- 6.26** What is the connection here with luxury beliefs? Well, I opened with that question about defunding the police. Here's some survey data. The defund the police movement gained a lot of support in 2020 and 2021, especially among cultural elites. Initially, it was actually called Abolish the Police. There was that op-ed that I cited earlier with the

New York Times. This gained a lot of traction. I found a representative survey of Americans, which found that the highest income category, so this 100,000 or more. I wonder how this would look if it was broken down further by even higher income brackets. But at least here, the highest income category, they were the most supportive of defunding the police.

- 6.27** There were some other surveys. These were not representative U.S. surveys. These were just within major U.S. cities. I saw in Minneapolis, in Detroit, I think New York City and others, that the highest income category, they were the most supportive of defunding the police in these cities. Some of these surveys found that white residents reported that they were twice as likely to say that they were afraid of the police than black residents. College graduates were twice as likely to report being afraid of the police as non-college graduates.
- 6.28** And yet, when you—the reason why this is a luxury belief is that as a lot of the defund movement has been either implemented directly in policy or has just shifted social attitudes around law enforcement, cultivating an atmosphere where police officers are either retiring en masse or having difficulty recruiting and so on, just this general shift in society, crime has been increasing and it's been primarily poor, low-income people who are bearing the brunt of what's been happening here.
- 6.29** I think perhaps some of these cultural elites are misguided. They think that, well, it is true that most perpetrators of crime are members of poor, marginalized communities. But it's also true that victims of crime are primarily the victims of, or rather, members of poor, marginalized communities. And because there are many times more victims than there are perpetrators, to not stop crime is to actually victimize the poor. For example, 1% of the population is responsible for 63 % of the violent crime. This has been replicated in various countries, this general idea that a small number of people perpetrate most crime. It's been found in the U.S., it's been found in Sweden, it's been found in European countries. I think it's been found in Japan as well.
- 6.30** And so this idea here that we shouldn't—we should be lenient toward crime because it's helping the poor, it's actually very much the opposite. This is data from before the defund the police movement of who are the victims of crime. Compared to those who earn more than \$75,000 a year, which is roughly median income, the poorest individuals are 7 times more likely to be victims of robbery, 7 times more likely to be victims of aggravated assault, 20 times more likely to be victims of sexual assault. They're also the primary victims of homicide and all kinds of violent crimes. So those numbers are probably worse now.
- 6.31** In response to that whole movement around law enforcement, there were stories of wealthy people in the U.S.—so in Manhattan, for example, a lot of the wealthy residents fled to the Hamptons. In Chicago, there were reports of affluent people hiring off-duty police officers to patrol their neighborhood, people hiring private security. Essentially, you can advocate and promote this whole defund the police idea, which a

lot of cultural elites did. But then privately, they're ensuring that they and their loved ones are protected from crime.

- 6.32** In San Francisco, violent crime has been rising, and people haven't really seemed to care that much about it. But a few months ago, there was a tech executive or a tech entrepreneur who was killed, and that was actually covered in the media. It was like, when poor people kill each other, who cares? But now, another member of the affluent, another member of the elite, when they get killed, suddenly the media pays attention. Now, I think we're slowly starting to see this. Now that crime is starting to affect white-collar people, now people are taking it more seriously.
- 6.33** We'll shift here for a moment to language and cultural capital. Paul Fussell wrote this great book, *Class: A Guide Through the American Status System*. When he was writing this book in the 1980s, he noticed differences in how people spoke, upper classes compared to the others. The upper class would say "tiresome" or "tedious." Everyone else would say "boring." Upper classes would say "dinner jacket" or "black tie." Everyone else would call it a "tuxedo." Today, when I was growing up and when I was in the military, I never heard terms like "cisgender" or "cultural appropriation," "heteronormativity," "unhoused." I mean, these terms were just not on my radar. Then suddenly, I arrive on campus and these terms were everywhere.
- 6.34** This cultural appropriation idea. So I mentioned earlier that I grew up not knowing my parents. I remember I made this joke before: "No woman's ever given birth to a kid and not know it was theirs." So there's more information about my birth mother than my birth father. My birth mother was Korean. This was documented by the social workers that were responsible for my case. I didn't know who my father was. We knew nothing about him. I took a 23andMe some months ago, and it turns out that my father was Hispanic, most likely Mexican. I didn't know this.
- 6.35** A few years ago, I was at Yale with a friend of mine, this Mexican-American guy. He's a good friend of mine. We're in his dorm room, and I put on his sombrero. He was like, we were joking around. He's a good friend of mine. He's like, "Hey, take that off. That's cultural appropriation." I was like, "Oh, my bad." Just joking, right? But then I texted him after I got those DNA test results, and I was like, "Hey, remember that time you told me I'm not allowed to wear sombreros? Well, guess what?" I was like, "Yes, I am." I think that example just goes to show how the whole conversation around cultural appropriation, a lot of these ideas, is just so confused. I didn't even know what my own ethnicity was, and so I didn't even know whether or not I was culturally appropriating anything.
- 6.36** Another, one more story. There's this other term. I didn't add it here, this term "justice-involved person," instead of saying "criminal." I had a friend who actually—so a friend of mine from high school, I have two friends from high school who have been to prison. One of them has been to prison twice. When I saw that term "justice-involved person," I don't remember what outlet it was in, but it was in prestige media. Someone used it in

in all earnestness. I texted him and I said, "Hey, I have good news for you. You're not a criminal anymore. You're a justice-involved person." And he responded to me, "Hey, that's great. You're not a college graduate anymore. You're a classroom-involved person."

- 6.37** Terminology. I think that these are examples of luxury beliefs, too. These are costly status symbols. I mean, even in order to learn what those terms mean, how to use them, in what context, when to use them. I think "unhoused," this is sort of—we're in this interim period where people are trying to decide whether we're going to just go with it or if we can still say "homeless." I've also seen the term "houseless." I think we're still in the conflict of, "Are we going to update the language?" If you use "unhoused" right now, I think it really does signal that you're on the vanguard of the luxury belief class. These are reliable indicators of economic and cultural capital. They're honest signals.
- 6.38** There's a quote from an interview by the NYU professor Scott Galloway. "The strongest brand in the world is not Apple. The strongest brands are MIT, Oxford, Stanford. Academics decided we're no longer public servants, we're luxury goods." Now, you can learn a lot of these luxury beliefs if you spend time on elite college campuses, but you don't have to. Really, the key is, do you have the type of job? Are you in a position in your life where you can spend a lot of time listening to the right podcasts, consuming the right media content, reading the right periodicals, and keeping up with the latest fashionable trends? And can you scroll Twitter all day? Do you have a job where you're not on your feet, where you can stay on your computer or stay on your phone? And if you can, then you—if you're not an actual member of this class, you're at least adjacent to it and can learn and pick up on it.
- 6.39** We'll transition now into this idea of luxury beliefs as possessions. The idea here is that a lot of our beliefs, the way that we treat our possessions, rather, especially our valued possessions, can be extended to the way that we treat beliefs. There is this sort of—some psychologists and linguists have suggested that the way that we think about language, there is this idea of embodied cognition, that the way we speak about metaphorical concepts are rooted in our understanding of the physical world. We say things like, "A rising young executive climbing the ladder, reaching the top." You're not actually reaching the top of anything. I've been using this term of "climbing the top of the socioeconomic scale" or something, but there's no actual physical scale anywhere. It's just a mental ladder that we keep in mind.
- 6.40** We think of high-minded, upstanding, lowlives, behaving in underhanded ways. People cherish and abandon their beliefs. I think in some cases, we really do think of these abstract metaphorical ideas and opinions that we hold as if they were physical possessions. There's this idea of the endowment effect in behavioral economics. The basic idea is that when people don't own an item, they value it less than when they do. If you show people a pen and ask, "How much is this pen worth?", they might say a

dollar. Then if you give them the pen and say, "This is yours now. How much are you willing to sell me that pen?", they'll say "\$2," something like that. Once they have an item, they value it more highly. They assign more value to things that they own.

- 6.41** My suggestion is that this is also how people treat beliefs. When they see beliefs out there—opinions, different viewpoints out there—they're evaluating them. Maybe they don't know how much they're worth. They're thinking about it. Then once they adopt that belief, they're extremely attached to it and unwilling to relinquish it. They're unwilling to part with it. Before they adopted that belief, they didn't assign so much value to it, but now that they hold it, suddenly it increases in value. We prize it highly, become more likely to relinquish it.
- 6.42** This is something I've been thinking about. Why are people so stubborn, unwilling to change their minds? Well, there's some interesting work from Hugo Mercier and others. They basically suggest that we want reliable social allies. When we see people, especially on our team, in our in-group, on our coalition, and part of the reason why we have the coalition is because of certain beliefs, we want to be able to trust that they're reliable group members, and we don't want them to betray us or leave our group or abandon us. And so by being obstinate, it serves as a signal of your reliability. "I have this belief, we all believe in this thing, and if I'm unwilling to change my mind about any belief, then you're going to trust me more if I'm on your side."
- 6.43** Flip-flopers seem unreliable. The idea here being that, if I'm constantly, every time I'm exposed to a new belief, a new idea, I'm going to believe that now, I'm going to believe this now, I'm going to believe this. You seem wishy-washy, you seem untrustworthy, you seem unreliable. But if I say, "This is what I believe. These are my principles. I'm not going to change them," if you agree with me, then you're going to see me as a reliable ally. Relatedly, there's this interesting idea of what some psychologists—they've called this the Black Sheep Effect, about when we're willing to punish different people, what the threshold of evidence is.
- 6.44** The basic idea is that when guilt is uncertain, people are less willing to punish an in-group member than an out-group member. If there's ambiguity about whether a person committed a transgression, if they're part of your group, you're going to be lenient toward them. If you're not certain, you're going to say, "Maybe they didn't do it." You're going to be nice. If they're part of an out-group and there's ambiguity about whether they actually did something wrong, you're going to say, "They probably did it. Let's punish them. Let's get them."
- 6.45** But this effect reverses if guilt is certain. So if a member of your in-group commits a transgression, and you're completely certain they did it—there's foolproof evidence—you'll want to punish them more harshly than if an out-group member did it. I think this gets at why people become so enraged when they see a traitor. Someone who is a part of your group and then betrays the values of that group, we see them as worse than

someone who was never part of the group in the first place. I think you can see this play out.

- 6.46** I mean, even in certain kinds of religions, being a nonbeliever is bad, but being an apostate is actually even worse, sort of abandoning the faith. People really don't like that. I think you see this play out in politics too. Someone who used to be part of this party, and now they're a part of that—there's a lot of resentment and animosity towards someone who changes their mind in that way. I think this may also be why people are reluctant to change their minds.
- 6.47** There's another reason as well, which is that it prevents us from being duped by charlatans. Again, if you are so open-minded that you are just willing to believe every new idea that surfaces — "Oh, today I learned this. That's what I believe now. Oh, this other thing that stands in contrast to that. It's at odds with this other idea." You're just constantly believing every single thing that you hear. You may be more likely to be fooled. So obstinance, in a way, serves a protective function. Presumably, whatever you've believed until now has kept you alive. You're not dead. So whatever contents you have in your mind have allowed you to survive. And so the idea here is that the threshold for adopting a new belief should be sufficiently high such that you are unlikely to be fooled or duped or tricked. And so this bias towards the status quo may defend us from being susceptible to implausible ideas.
- 6.48** So returning to this idea of luxury beliefs, members of the educated and affluent categories in society, they're the most susceptible to these kinds of beliefs. And you might ask yourself, well, we talked before about how education is, or rather, intelligence is correlated with education, with income, and all these things. So why is it that supposedly smart people would be so susceptible to ideas that maybe sound good, but in practice often cause a lot of harm? This gets us to the idea of the social brain hypothesis, which is that our intelligence, our ability to solve novel problems, absorb new information, recall information that we already have, it didn't really to solve these technical problems, truth-seeking, but rather social problems of getting along with others.
- 6.49** Remember, many of our traits, our most important traits, they arose in order to solve evolutionary problems—ultimately having offspring, but surviving, reproducing, getting along, not dying. Sometimes, knowing the truth about the world can help with those things. But often the more important goal is to get along with others, social harmony. Some researchers have suggested that in the evolutionary past, in our ancestral environment, the number one threat to humans was other humans. We evolved to mind-read, to anticipate, to get along, to not be targeted by others. And as a consequence, our intelligence arose, and we implicitly ask ourselves:
- 6.50** "What are the social consequences of holding or not holding this belief? If holding this belief will cause me to be ostracized or lead my friends to abandon me or to dislike me, then I'll be unwilling to adopt that belief. On the other hand, if holding this belief and

broadcasting it garners me status among my peers, will get them to like me, get accepted, get promoted, and so on, then maybe I'll be more willing to express it, especially if there's no cost to myself for expressing it. If there's no personal cost of me believing something, but there are incentives and benefits to me expressing it, then I'll be perhaps more likely to do so."

- 6.51** Intelligence, this isn't to say that it can't be used. Intelligence can be used to solve technical problems and pursue the truth. But the main purpose of it is getting along with others, coming up with good arguments for why you do what you do. We can use it, but that's not what its intended purpose seems to be. An analogy is that using intelligence to seek the truth is like using a butter knife as a screwdriver. It works. It's a little bit awkward. You often need assistance, you need help. This is why we have—well, if you really want a truth-seeking society, you want freedom of inquiry, you want people checking your work, you want peer review, you want all of these measures in place so that when you make a truth claim, other people can double-check because our truth-seeking apparatus, our intelligence, our intellect, our rational mind, it's flawed. It's flawed in the sense that using it for those things, that's actually not what it's for. It's more so to get along and promote social harmony and promote cohesion within the group.
- 6.52** How do these beliefs spread, these luxury beliefs? Well, we listen to and adopt the beliefs of prestigious people. It starts with one group that is generally highly respected. We talked before about how prestige works. In the ancestral environment, people obtain prestige for being skillful in activities that could benefit the group. Whereas today, people can still obtain prestige that way, but you can also obtain it just for being well-known, just for being entertaining, for doing things that maybe have no practical, useful utility. But because you're receiving so much social attention, people confer prestige on you.
- 6.53** Ancestrally, the prestige route made a lot of sense. No one was famous for being famous in the Pleistocene, in the environment of our ancestors. Back then, if someone who was really skilled at navigating made a claim about how things should be, people would listen to them and assume that they had something useful or important to say. Whereas today, this is less true. Someone who is prominent, who has a lot of prestige in the community, they don't necessarily, and they don't always know, what they're talking about with regard to truth claims. But because they're so prominent and well-known and occupy a high perch in society, people will listen to them.
- 6.54** My suspicion is that a lot of educated people are probably more manipulable, as long as the manipulation is coming from the right sources. I think there's this reputational loss aversion. So loss aversion is a principle from behavioral economics, this idea that losing something is more painful than winning something. The idea here is that it feels pretty good to win \$100, but it really stings to lose \$100. There's that asymmetry. And once you've accrued a lot of reputation for yourself, you really don't want to lose it.

You've built it up, you have this image, you have this job, this position, this esteem, and you're reluctant to part with it, and therefore, you're going to potentially express misguided views in order to retain your reputation if that's the cost you have to pay.

- 6.55** This is a quote from the psychologist Keith Stanovich. He wrote a book called *The Bias That Divides Us: The Science and Politics of Myside Thinking*. It's a really great book. He writes that, "If you are a person of high intelligence"—this is based on his research—"you will less likely than the average person to realize you have derived your beliefs from the social groups you belong to because they fit with your temperament and your innate psychological propensities. "
- 6.56** The idea here is that, again, our intelligence, the reason why it evolved and arose is to get along with groups. If you're a really intelligent person, it's really easy to use that to rationalize the beliefs of your group, the beliefs of your community. If suddenly your group has to adopt a new belief and you want to remain a member of it, you can engage in the intellectual acrobatics necessary to try to believe it yourself and repeat things that maybe don't make a lot of sense. But intelligence, intelligent people can be very good at making things up and making it sound sophisticated and interesting, even if it has no connection to reality.
- 6.57** We're going to continue on this idea of educated intelligent people being potentially more manipulable in some cases. There was a survey in 2019 which found that—they basically asked people, "How afraid are you of getting fired or hurting your employment prospects because of your political views?" High school or less, 25%. College degree, 34%. If you have a graduate or professional degree, 44% of people are fearful of losing their jobs or their employment prospects because of their political views. Then there was another study around that same time that found that self-censorship generally is higher among educated people that gets this idea of reputational loss aversion, this reluctance to say things that may potentially damage your standing.
- 6.58** It seems that this group may be manipulable in the sense that they'll either actually adopt the beliefs necessary to get by, to retain or enhance the social bonds in their community, to be accepted, not lose status. But then they can also be pressured into just keeping their mouth shut if they don't agree with what's going on. Either way, they seem to be more susceptible to this pressure. There are historical examples of this. I read this book years ago, *The Rise and Fall of the Third Reich*. William Shirer, the author of this book, he was an American journalist who was a war correspondent in Nazi Germany. He lived in Germany for a few years in the 1930s, documented what he was seeing, and spoke with people.
- 6.59** He writes here, "Often in a German home or office or sometimes in a casual conversation with a stranger in a restaurant, beer hall or café, I would meet with outlandish assertions from seemingly educated and intelligent persons. It was obvious they were parroting nonsense they heard on the radio or read in the newspapers.

Sometimes one was tempted to say as much, but one was met with such incredulity as if one had blasphemed the Almighty."

- 6.60** So he's talking about people who are supposedly intelligent and educated, but they would say things that were clearly false, and they were getting their information from the places that educated and intelligent people get their information—newspapers, radio, whatever, of this period in the 1930s. That's where they get their information. The whole national socialism ideology, it was adopted by the cultural elites in Nazi Germany. University professors, the students, everyone adopted this view once it became fashionable and trendy and high status. The educated class, in many cases, they were the true believers. They were the most likely to believe in it, or they were the least likely to speak out against it.
- 6.61** This was also the case in the Soviet Union. There was a study which found—this was before the collapse of the Soviet Union. Surveys indicated that university graduates were 2-3 times more likely than secondary school graduates or high school graduates, basically, to support the Communist Party. White-collar workers were 2-3 times more supportive of the Communist Party compared to farm laborers and semi-skilled workers. That was the prevailing ideology of the Soviet Union, was communism. That was the high status belief that you should hold if you want to retain or advance your position in society.
- 6.62** And so my claim here isn't that intelligent people are more susceptible to this or that ideology, but more so, susceptible to whatever the high status ideology is in that society. They're going to be more likely to believe it or be less likely to speak out against it because they don't want to lose their position. Yeah. Regardless of time or place, whatever the dogma happens to be, affluent and educated people are the most likely to say the right things to preserve status or gain more of it, or the corollary, the least likely to speak out against it and be targeted.
- 6.63** We're going to close some of this discussion of luxury beliefs with intra-elite conflict. This is Peter Turchin. I looked up what his title was. He got his PhD in biology, but he calls himself a complexity scientist. He's a professor at the University of Connecticut. He's developed this idea of intra-elite conflict. He's got a great new book out called *End Times*. So this idea of intra-elite conflict—he writes here, "When the rich get richer and the poor get poorer, cooperation between social classes is undermined, but the same process is operating within each class. When some nobles are growing conspicuously more wealthy, while the majority of nobility is increasingly impoverished, the elites become ridden with factional conflicts."
- 6.64** One of Turchin's interesting claims here is that the factors that are responsible for instability and social unrest, it's not mass immiseration. It's not that the masses suddenly become fed up with the ruling class and want to topple it. Rather, the factor that's most responsible for instability and social revolution is intra-elite conflict, where a group of individuals who themselves tend to be relatively affluent and well-educated,

perhaps not quite as much as the existing ruling class, but in that category, they are the ones who tend to be responsible for social revolution and change. They lead the vanguard and topple the existing structure and install themselves as the new ruling leaders. Often, what happens is counterelites challenge existing elites. Often, criticizing the elite is an audition to become a member of it.

6.65 So intra-elite conflict, how does it work? Well, there are always going to be more would-be elite aspirants, people who want to join the elite, and there are elite jobs. So Turchin, specifically speaking about the U.S., he talks about how the number of—and he controls for inflation here and everything—but the number of very rich people in the U.S. has actually been increasing over time, over the last few decades. But the number of seats in Congress, there's only one president, there are a certain number of CEO positions in Fortune 500 companies, and so on and so forth. The actual positions of power, the head of various prestigious media outlets, the places where you can wield a lot of social influence, those have remained roughly static, despite the number of people who are obtaining college degrees and the number of people who are becoming economically rich. That's been expanding, whereas the positions have remained the same.

6.66 He suggests that there may be some intra-elite conflict rising in the U.S., and large numbers of aspirants give rise to hardened dogma as a way to eliminate rivals. That's my claim. I've given this example before of, one thing I noticed when I first arrived on campus at Yale as an undergrad, I would see people talk about investment banks as emblems of capitalist oppression. Those same people would attend recruitment sessions at Goldman Sachs in an attempt to get a job. Gradually, what I came to suspect is that they were basically undercutting their rivals. If they could convince you to not apply for this job because the bank is evil, and then they slide in and apply for the job, then they can get it. I think a lot of this intra-elite conflict —Peter Turchin talks about how once intra-elite conflict reaches a certain point, people no longer compete on merit, but rather resort to dirty tricks, character assassination, and maybe deceptive, duplicitous strategies.

6.67 I have a friend at Cambridge who wrote a paper about sex differences in STEM. There was a young woman in his department who didn't like this paper very much, and she started a petition trying to get him fired. He texted me. He was like, "She's a PhD student. Shouldn't she be writing papers and trying to get published and trying to get a job instead of trying to cancel me? Why is she wasting her time on this petition?" I wrote back to him, "No. If she wants to be a professor, she's doing exactly what she should be doing." Because when she applies to be a professor somewhere, there's going to be a diversity, equity, and inclusion statement, and they're going to say, "What have you done to promote DEI?"

6.68 And she can write, "I discovered that in my department there was an anti-feminist, misogynist, whatever, all the -ists you can think of. He wrote this paper and claimed

that biological sex was real, or whatever the transgression was." She 'll probably get the job over you, despite the fact that you've probably published more papers than her. And when she gets the job, if she gets you fired, that would go a long way to her career.

6.69 I actually tried to convince him to step down and acknowledge that she was the reason, and "help this young woman get a job. Just accept, just resign." But I told him, "If and when she gets you fired, she'll get to put your skull next to her PhD on her trophy shelf." She's actually, I think, doing the right thing here, in terms of, if we accept that this is what's going on, if intra-elite conflict is going on. Relatedly, on this theme of status-seeking and using dirty tricks, people who score high on status-seeking—this is a paper that was just published a couple of years ago, Michael Bang Peterson and his colleagues. They found that people who score high on status-seeking are more likely to support political violence, more likely to share hostile political rumors on social media, more likely to fight over political and moral questions online. They suggest that basically being very political, extremist, dogmatic, this is a good way to obtain more status for yourself.

6.70 I suspect that people who launch these social media campaigns against people or petitions against people, they probably have a pretty strong interest in status attainment. This is another factor, I think, underlying this luxury beliefs phenomenon, is that when you can update beliefs, when you can update the ideas, update the ideological fashions of the day, you can stir up conflict, you can pressure people, you can say—I could imagine maybe 3 or 4 years from now, people saying, like, "Oh, this politician said homeless. That's an offensive term. You should say unhoused. Apologize, apologize, apologize." If the person doesn't apologize for saying homeless instead of unhoused, he steps down, that opens up a seat, and that allows an elite aspirant to sit there. If you can get a professor fired, that opens up a seat.

6.71 So I think this is an intra-elite conflict game maybe playing out where you introduce new ideas, new ideological trends, and this could explain why we're seeing just such a large number of media personalities, academics, artists, executives, all these people, promoting newfangled ideas, especially younger people. A lot of these ideas are coming from elite aspirants who are younger. They're a member of this educated and affluent group, but they tend to be younger, and they're interested in taking the positions of the senior members of their organizations, trying to extort those people or jettison their rivals, trying to free up seats in positions of power.

6.72 We're going to wind down a bit now. We're going to have some time for Q&A, but here's what we've been —this is what we've been covering for this course. We talked about status, whether it's fundamental. We've talked about what a fundamental belief is. We talked about what are the routes to status, what are the two types of status, individual and personality differences. We've talked about sex differences. What are the arenas of competition for status for men and women, what do they have in common, where do they differ? We talked about some of the emotions around status

—envy, social comparison, embarrassment, humiliation. We talked about stories and status, what it is about stories that we find so appealing and how the status dynamics of a story keep our attention. We talked about the status games and what the 3 status games are, how to attain status within those games, and we've been discussing luxury beliefs.

6.73 I'd like to thank all of you for coming out and for all of your thoughtful questions. I really enjoyed this experience. I hope all of you have learned at least something from these lectures. So thanks.